

*Tourism
Social
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Series*

Volume 18

Tourism Social Media

Transformations in Identity, Community and Culture

**Ana María Munar, Szilvia Gyimóthy
and Liping Cai**
Editors

This volume addresses the transformative power of tourism social media and offers novel theoretical and methodological approaches to its academic investigation.

Acknowledging the collective value creation mechanisms of new media, the authors explore how technology nurtures, augments and modifies social or commercial interactions in tourism. The book emphasizes the role of fantasy and imagination in fluid tourism experiences and critically scrutinizes contested concepts pertaining to human interaction in cyberspace, such as equality, anonymity, transparency, democratization, and publicity culture.

The chapters summon insights from Media Studies, Actor-Network Theory, Communicative Action and Symbolic Convergence among others, and offer a palette of emerging methods suitable for academic enquiries of virtual worlds. As such, *Tourism Social Media: Transformations in Identity, Community and Culture* expands the actual research agenda and contributes to increasing research reflexivity in tourism studies at large.

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The books in this Tourism Social Science Series (TSSSeries) are intended to systematically and cumulatively contribute to the formation, embodiment and advancement of knowledge in the field of tourism.

The TSSSeries' multidisciplinary framework and treatment of tourism includes application of theoretical, methodological, and substantive contributions from such fields as anthropology, business administration, ecology, economics, geography, history, hospitality, leisure, planning, political science, psychology, recreation, religion, sociology, transportation, etc., but it significantly favors state-of-the-art presentations, works featuring new directions, and especially the cross-fertilization of perspectives beyond each of these singular fields. While the development and production of this book series is fashioned after the successful model of *Annals of Tourism Research*, the TSSSeries further aspires to assure each theme a comprehensiveness possible only in book-length academic treatment. Each volume in the series is intended to deal with a particular aspect of this increasingly important subject, thus to play a definitive role in the enlarging and strengthening of the foundation of knowledge in the field of tourism, and consequently to expand the frontiers of knowledge into the new research and scholarship horizons ahead.

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Chapter 1

Tourism Social Media: A New Research Agenda

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INTRODUCTION

Advances in information and communication technologies (ICT) have brought unprecedented opportunities and challenges to tourism as an information-intensive industry. Currently the Internet is evolving into a web of increasingly interactive communication platforms, which is once again transforming the virtual landscape of tourism. The emerging "Web 2.0" is claimed to be more participatory and inclusive, as it allows users to create, publish, and comment on digitized content worldwide. It provides a new generation of technological tools, enabling users to develop online communities and networks by collaborating and distributing Internet content and customizing applications (Vickery & Wunsch-Vincent, 2007). Web 2.0 is inherently collective; it is no longer just an informational medium, but a technology that nurtures, augments, and modifies social interactions and communication (Weinberg, 2009). As such, the information age has gradually become the social age.

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2 Introduction

What tourists do

The progression of a collective Web 2.0 has led to the emergence of new tourism cultures and practices. Tourists receive and share information online and form virtual communities on a whole array of social media software. These encompass a variety of different types of ICT tools and take many different forms. Some of the most popular ones are wikis, blogs and microblogs, social networks, media sharing sites, review sites, and voting sites (Stillman & McGrath, 2008; Zarrella, 2010). Tourists share their travel images on Flickr, upload videos to YouTube, write personal stories on Travelblog, provide reviews on TripAdvisor, and publish updates about their tourism experience on Facebook. Hence, the participatory web has enabled new kinds of tourism interactions (such as electronic word-of-mouth), which complement and expand the experience of physical travel in diverse ways. For example, virtual communities such as Wayn or Dopplr focus especially on exchanging content to facilitate the planning of the journey, and by doing so they also encourage sociability and virtual knowledge sharing among members.

Social media emphasize the role of fantasy and imagination as part of a fluid tourism experience. This implies a virtual, emotional, and imaginative mode of travel, preceding as well as running parallel with the actual physical journey. On the other hand, everyday life and work issues gradually infiltrate the days on the road. As long as wireless network hubs make it possible, tourists are eager to regularly keep in touch with their friends, families, peers (and sometimes, work) back home. This fluidity blurs modernist dichotomies neatly differentiating between everyday life and nonordinary tourist behavior, between home and away, or work and leisure. However, as Jansson's (2002) study on the mediation of the tourism experience suggests, this virtual layer does not lead to the "end of tourism" and physical travel, but instead inspires and enriches the "on-location" experience. Perceptions and knowledge of tourism are conceived along the spatial activity of actually visiting places; however, it is equally shaped by the experience of mediated, simulated, and imagined space (Campbell, 2005). Social media provide new channels for the production and circulation of meaning in the tourism experience and imagination.

peer-to-peer

In this sense, tourism social media can be regarded as a novel form of collective value creation. They provide a fast-evolving technological structure shaping tourism cultures on and offline. The extensive creative effort of tourist-generated content and peer-to-peer reviews benefits other tourists with updated and (seemingly) impartial online information. Social networks and online communities provide tourists with information as well as pleasure, entertainment, appreciation, and status. Furthermore, social media sites

have the potential to alter power relations (Shih, 2009), and tourism organizations are now confronted with the challenges of communicating with customers amidst media influences they have little or no control over. A new paradigm of marketing communications is on the rise (Mangold & Faulds, 2009) that entails not only the incorporation of social media in the promotional mix, but also requires a new way of strategic thinking. Social media reviews and user-generated content are believed to be independent of commercial agendas, giving them a new dimension of credibility and legitimacy. Many marketers are overwhelmed with these challenges or lack a full appreciation or knowledge about the potentials and character of social media (Mangold & Faulds, 2009; Merman Scott, 2011).

TOURISM SOCIAL MEDIA RESEARCH

The changing virtual landscape of tourism has received increased attention by tourism scholars. There is an emerging interdisciplinary field of study attempting to describe this phenomenon and to understand its consequences on tourist decisionmaking, behavior, and strategic communications. As such, social media are approached mostly from a business administration perspective, where contemporary studies on tourism and information technologies (IT) are informed by frameworks developed in management and marketing theory. This has resulted in the dominance of a (post) positivistic methodological approach in articles and textbooks (Sigala et al., 2012) and the emergence of research networks (such as the International Federation for Information Technologies in Travel and Tourism or the ENTER conferences), driven by an applied business research agenda. Taking the benefits of a “first-mover” advantage, these networks have developed into a densely knit, closed circle of actors who hold key editorial and advisory positions. These communities are similar to academic groups (Tribe, 2006) as they perpetuate one particular ontological view on technology and tourism and often act as gatekeepers of research production and distribution. Arguably, contemporary IT studies in tourism are still at a stage similar to the first, advocacy phase of tourism research in general (Jafari, 1990). This stage is characterized by a methodological hegemony, where studies of tourism social media are seldom inspired by relevant theoretical advances from other social science disciplines (such as anthropology, sociology, or geography). Nor is there a tendency to adopt critical or interpretivist schools of thought in research agendas, leaving important

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aspects of tourism social media unexplored. To substantiate this claim, three main streams of contemporary research can be pursued.

The first stream is characterized by exploratory research of social media sites and content and provides classifications according to types of tourism and its activities (Pudliner, 2007; Volo, 2010), type of genre, tourist-generated content, and the tourism experience (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2010; Munar, 2011; Tussyadiah & Fesenmaier, 2009), and types of tourists and country of origin (Enoch & Grossman, 2010; Wenger, 2008). These cataloguing approaches are useful to develop a comprehensive vocabulary to address a new phenomenon; however, rigid taxonomies and prematurely determined ontological structures may equally undermine theoretical sensitivity.

A second stream of research examines the relationship among social media, decisionmaking, and information search. The research of Mack et al. (2008) suggests that blogs are not as credible as word-of-mouth and that they act as complementary tools for market communication. Huang et al. (2010) provide an empirical test of a travel blogger's intention model and conclude that there is a positive relationship between blogging and a positive view of the ads of the site. Consumer-centered research approaches are also adopted in other studies of electronic word-of-mouth and location-based services (Lee & Tussyadiah, 2010; Tussyadiah, 2012) and articles that analyze tourists' behavior on review sites and recommendation systems (Bronner & de Hoog, 2011; Yoo & Gretzel 2008; Zhang et al., 2009). Moreover, scholars have examined the impact that social media sites have on travel information search and choice of destination (Fotis et al., 2012; Jacobsen & Munar, 2012; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010) and indicate the increasing role that electronic word-of-mouth plays in consumer decisionmaking processes (Litvin et al., 2008). While acknowledging these contributions, it can be argued that they do not go beyond the descriptive mapping of consumer behavior. It is time to adopt a more "techspressive" (Kozinets, 2008, p. 870) approach to studying sociotechnical systems, acknowledging the role of technology in individuals' self-realization and in collective identity projects. Technology is a mediated emotional landscape; nevertheless, the hedonic and emotional dimensions of ICT have received poor attention among tourism scholars.

A third stream of research takes a supply-oriented perspective, dealing with the challenges that tourist-generated content represent for destination marketing organizations and tourism firms. Munar (2011, 2012) presents a model of generic strategies used by these organizations to interact with the virtual world of social media. Other studies describe patterns of technology adoption of the industry and discuss the challenges that tourism organizations face when wanting to use social media for communication,

promotion, or product development (Ayeh et al., 2012; Hvass & Munar, 2012; Schmallegger & Carson, 2008; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). Finally, there is also evidence of novel approaches scrutinizing the collective, virtual value creation between providers and consumers, for instance on festival social media (Larson & Gyimóthy, 2012).

Challenging Unquestioned Assumptions

Studies of tourism social media are fraught with a number of underlying assumptions, which have developed into list of truisms reiterated in the introductory sections of most articles on this matter. As unreflected orthodoxy and assumptive mantras may hinder conceptual development and novel thinking, there is an urgent need to identify and reassess the most “die-hard” truisms. For instance, social media are often claimed to epitomize a more transparent and trustworthy web. The Web 1.0 represents a virtual sphere dominated by the content of firms and organizations, while the Web 2.0 empowers individual users around the world previously dominated by the content of organizations (Brogan & Smith, 2009; Shih, 2009). Increased participation of end users has the potential of altering previously established power relations. However, the claim of consumer sovereignty is challenged by ample examples of identity theft by media (Poster, 2006) or disputes over ownership of digital content uploaded to social media platforms such as Facebook (Aspan, 2008). It is also possible to question the reliability and trustworthiness of anonymous content. For instance, fake reviews and profiles on TripAdvisor are other problematic practices revealing a paradoxical balance act between transparency and necessary control mechanisms. Interactive media is a double-edged sword that provides opportunities for emancipation and socialization and for increased control and monitoring (Munar, 2010a).

Moreover, it is problematic to deem the Web 2.0 as a domain free of commercial interests. Ooi and Ek (2010) question the altruistic motives of peer-to-peer review sites and suggest that there exists a commercial motive behind most social media platforms. When aggregated, positive travel stories posted on TripAdvisor become valuable commercial assets and rhetorical ammunition in market communication. This exemplifies the tension between the ambition to achieve commercial success and the desire to maintain the illusion of a noncommercial domain.

A common assumption in the literature is the understanding of the web as an enabler for democracy and democratic communication. However, use of

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and participation in the Web 2.0 phenomenon takes for granted access to ICT and the acquisition of technological skills and an appropriate level of e-literacy. Use of and access to ICT, termed the digital divide in literature, varies greatly throughout the world. There is also a socioeconomic and generational divide to be taken into consideration (Prensky, 2001; Tapscott, 2009). Despite the increased popularity of social media platforms, critical perspectives show that not everybody is a writer or enthusiastic information sharer. Social media are claimed to promote the wisdom of crowds, but increasingly there is a debate on the merit and the quality of the user-generated content available, for example, citing the lack of depth and superficiality of tourists' contributions (Volo, 2010; Wenger, 2008).

Social media brings democratization and establishes new forms of social segregation, inclusion, and exclusion in the tourism system. Furthermore, while the majority of researchers prefer to think of web content as instantaneous and ephemeral (with microblogging as a conspicuous example), the information posted on collective platforms becomes permanent and can be retrieved. The tension between real-time communication culture and digital archiving systems creates new challenges related to the management of user-generated information, authorship rights, and data-management rights. It also demands a new reflectivity by users when building their virtual identities or uploading and sharing content on these new media.

Accordingly, this book embraces critical and reflective approaches to understanding the characters and implications of tourism social media at a greater depth. While recognizing the pioneer contribution of tourism management scholars to this field, the authors question established discourses and the assumptions presented above about social media, including truisms about equality, transparency, reliability, and customer sovereignty. By analyzing the structures, social rules, and cultural values of these new technological platforms, the chapters of this volume reveal how social media influences, augments, and transforms tourism interactions and relationships. By doing so, this work does not simply question dominant assumptions about new media, but also contributes to the existing field of knowledge by offering a broader methodological toolbox to better comprehend virtual relationships and digital content in tourism.

Theoretical Approaches for Digital Age Tourism

The evolution of technology and its impact on social change is a recurring theme in the social sciences. Research has focused on the role that

technological development plays in, one, the relationship between individual agency and sociocultural structures and, two, in the provision of value and meaning in society. Technology and lately ICT play a crucial role in the different accounts of modernity and postmodernity (Bauman, 1998). The Internet provides new opportunities that change how people behave and make sense of their lives. The Internet and the web, as agents of social change, have been studied from many different perspectives: first, in relation to globalization processes (Hand, 2008); second, focusing on the digital divide, diversity, and power relations (Kirkpatrick, 2008; Kleinman, 2005); third, with regard to the construction of personal identities and virtual communities (Poster, 2006); fourth, examining changes in space-time constraints and cultural perceptions of body (Basu, Mok & Wellman, 2007; Schwanen & Kwan, 2008; Shaw, 2008); and, fifth, from a historical and sociological standpoint (Castells, 1997[1996], 2001). Furthermore, recent books have examined the impact of social media and web communities such as Facebook, YouTube, and Twitter on both society and on the marketplace (Qualman, 2009; Weinberg, 2009).

Some of the theories that critically elaborate on the relationships among sociocultural change, economic development, and technological transformation are liquid modernity (Bauman, 2000), information age, network society, and Internet cultures (Castells, 1997[1996], 2001), risk society (Beck, 1993, 2000), disembedding and reembedding of social relations (Giddens, 1990), communicative action (Habermas, 1984, 1987), social distinction and cultural capital (Bourdieu, 1984), actor network theories (Law & Mol, 2001), and complexity theory (Burnes, 2005; Byrne, 1998). These theoretical essays and conceptual frameworks have been widely used to examine many different types of cultural phenomena in society and are increasingly applied to the study of tourism (Pritchard et al., 2011; Tribe, 2006, 2009). However, they have so far been bypassed by researchers investigating the virtual world of tourism social media.

Mediated Encounters and Relationships

Interactive digital technology is dramatically changing tourism encounters and relationships. Social media has transformed the way in which businesses can interact with their customers. Users can now be involved in product development in radical new ways, which go well beyond the idea of “outsourcing” or “disintermediation.” Tourists’ value creation on the web changes power and responsibility relations in production processes and

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alters the value chain in tourism. This situation also impacts business-to-business relations and the way in which business compete. The evolution of a site such as Expedia is a clear example of this transformation, as well as the online and self-service strategies pushed by low-cost airlines such as Ryanair. At the same time, the possibility of communicating with customers on a real-time basis provides new opportunities for tourism organizations in their communication strategies, for example, as effective tools in the management of crisis.

The traditional relationship between host and guest is also being altered. CouchSurfing and the peer review site of TripAdvisor exemplify the transformative power of social media. The former, a user-based community where hosts offer free accommodation, promotes alternative and noncommercial intercultural encounters and social interaction. The latter is a review site for hotels, destinations, and attractions, which, despite its openness, is dominated by tourists' contributions and lacks local voices.

Online communities do not follow the structure of markets or hierarchies. Social media empower the customer-to-customer dimension and change the rules of the touristic marketplace. Moreover, social media are based on the establishment of alternative and nonmonetary reward systems (Brogan & Smith, 2009). For example, some of the most popular general sites for video and photo sharing are Flickr and Youtube. Many of the images on these sites have a "real-life" approach, without any or only a minimum degree of manipulation. The large diversity of video films available presents a kaleidoscopic image of destinations that stands in deep contrast to traditional dominant tourist images of destinations as presented by tourism or the cultural industry and that have usually played a relevant role in the marketing of destinations.

The ubiquitous web also modifies the relationship among destinations and between destination and place. A phenomenon like Google Earth, combined with review sites such as TripAdvisor, provide real-time online communication on places and surpasses traditional organizational channels of information about the destination, such as those provided by destination management organizations. ICT have altered local-global relationships. Tourists can see and read travel blogs, reviews, updates, and videos from around the world. Poster (2006) observes that the territoriality of the subject is minimized in digital culture, but not eradicated. Thanks to the Internet, the supply of tourist-generated content is global but consumed and produced locally. Social media sites act as a tool to make sense of and structure the excess of information (Qualman, 2009). Altering local-global relationships, social media provide a mobile virtual layer of

information and storytelling. These platforms transform the perception of space and function as a mobility enabler. The sharing of information is omnipresent and public, however, the production and the interpretation of meaning remain personal and context specific to a particular sociocultural setting.

Emerging Theories and Practices

This collection treats the emerging technological phenomenon of social media from multidisciplinary perspectives.

Part I: Expanding the Theoretical Landscape

This stage-setting part of the book consists of conceptual chapters taking as their point of departure social science theories and examines the relationship between technology and sociocultural change in tourism. This contributes to expanding the field of academic inquiry in social media by applying and critically assessing theoretical concepts and frameworks in order to understand this empirical phenomenon in greater depth.

So far very few scholars have attempted to theorize the communicative patterns of social media. Chapter 2, "Tourism Social Media as a Fire Object" by Richard Ek, presents a stimulating essay on the necessity of an ontological paradigm shift in social sciences. Following in the footsteps of actor-network theorists Law and Mol (1994), Ek stresses the importance of alternative, messier ways to conceptualize and approach the societal and the trajectories of societal phenomena. One such challenging ontology is fire spatiality: a societal topology whose shape is achieved and maintained through the relation between different forms of presence and absence. The metaphor of fire is also omnipresent in the discourse on social media; its "explosive spreading," marketers' efforts to "canalize it," being unable to fully "control" or "tame" it. The chapter discusses the potential of using the fire topology and its attributes to better comprehend the diffusion and development of communication of social media within tourism.

Chapter 3, "Paradoxical Digital Worlds" by Ana Maria Munar, addresses emerging social media cultures and sociotechnical practices through the theoretical lens of Habermas' (1984, 1987) communicative action. The chapter analyzes the paradoxical role of interactive technologies as forces for the reproduction and transformation of tourism. Munar shows that the virtual space of social media reproduces inclusion and exclusion patterns of tourism physical worlds, but also challenges the settled lifeworld of tourism and raises new questions about the goodness, justice, and value of

travel. She discusses the relationship between new media and processes of colonization of personal relations and life-spaces. Social media are both an agent of commercialization of everyday practices and an agent of de-commercialization of activities previously dominated by the market. The chapter reveals the ambivalent potential of these media as communicative technologies for emancipation but also as technological tools for hierarchization, control, and exploitation.

Symbolic convergence theory offers a relevant theoretical departure to address the complexities of social media communications. Chapter 4, "Symbolic Convergence and Tourism Social Media" by Szilvia Gyimóthy, suggests that the predominant mechanistic and behaviorist ontological framework in social media research results in a lack of awareness about the inherently social nature of tourism consumption and Web 2.0 communications. Gyimóthy stresses the urgency of acknowledging the sociality and narrativity of social media and explores the potential of an alternative analytical framework informed by symbolic convergence theory. The linkages between tourism social media, virtual communities, and symbolic convergence processes are illustrated by examples of postings and dialogue strings taking place on the Facebook fan site of an established music festival. These examples highlight the significance of symbolic communities in shaping the tourism experience and the festival concept against the backdrop of contemporary trends in consumer culture.

Changes in consumer culture also have consequences for destination management. Chapter 5, "Social Media Sites in Destination Image Formation" by Raslinda Mohd Ghazali and Liping Cai, proposes that existing theoretical models of destination image are outdated in the context of globalization and advances in IT, particularly the emergence of social media sites. The authors advocate a new conceptual model that builds on the seminal work by Gartner (1993) and that of Tasci and Gartner (2007), and extends the existing understanding of destination image formation. The model posits that, with the social media sites as the agent, an overall cognitive image of a destination can be formed by the overlap and intersection of provision and evaluation of cognitive and affective information by and among suppliers, consumers, and third parties.

Chapter 6, "Sustainability and Tourism Social Media" by Adriana Budeanu, critically assesses the claim that social media may play an important role in implementing tourism sustainable policies. The chapter reveals how, much like tourists' attitude in practice, the virtual interest of individuals in the sustainability of tourism provision or consumption is in its infancy. It discusses how the types of involvement enabled by social media

reshape institutional relations and raises some concerns regarding social media as practical tools for developing and maintaining sustainability. To the claim that social media cause a power shift from institutional to individual actors, Budeanu responds that they add a new regime of social power in tourism, while the challenge for authorities remains to identify the best use and to design suitable incentives to capture the benevolent support of the crowds for sustainable goals.

The critical scrutiny of social media and their rapidly developing affordances will make it possible to revisit contested concepts of human interaction in cyberspace: equality, anonymity, transparency, democratization, hybridization, and publicity culture. Beyond this theoretical exercise in Part I, the book also aims to reflect upon the consequences of Web 2.0 on commercial and social relationships in a variety of practical and empirical contexts.

Part II: Practices and Empirical Dimensions

The chapters in this part present several empirical essays studying the transformation of tourism interactions and the impact of social media. A wide array of tourism interactions and relationships are analyzed on micro-, mezo-, and macro-levels, paving the way to revisit theoretical models of tourism encounters. This collection of essays addresses both customer-oriented aspects, such as the mediated tourist experience on social media sites, as well as managerial issues of how to integrate social media into marketing and organizational communication.

Chapter 7, "Inspiring Design: Social Media from the Beach" by Mads Bødker and David Browning, argues that the affordances of mobile technologies to assist tourist experiences are limited. The design of mobile guides and information systems, or mobile social media, is rooted in the assumption that tourism revolves around spectatorship and guided sightseeing activities (and thus lacks the acknowledgement of the tourist as an active creator). Taking their point of departure in the performative ontology of tourist activities, the authors argue that viewing the tourist as networker can be a useful trope in designing innovative social and locative mobile technologies. The chapter presents ethnographically inspired fieldwork at a popular destination in Australia, using a particular form of video ethnography (EgoPoint-of-View). This reveals tourists' dynamic constructions of destinations or sites as social places, while interacting with and participating in local physical, social, and cultural topologies. The chapter further demonstrates how analysis of egoPOV data produces artifacts that

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can be used to shape a design space, which supports the design of social and locative information technologies in keeping with the networker model.

The social dynamics of travel-related online communities are often based on other commonalities than travel reviews, such as a passion for films or books. Chapter 8, "The Virtual Fan(g) Community: Social Media and Pop Culture Tourism" by Maria Lexhagen, Mia Larson, and Christine Lundberg, investigates the behavior of online fan cultures related to the Twilight saga and its impact on travel motivation and behavior. They demonstrate that social media have added a new dimension to popular cultural tourism that goes beyond enhancing tribal connections among members of fan communities. New locations may become attractive for fan tourists as they develop emotional ties with destinations based on associations with dramatic events or characters.

Making sense of tourist experiences, however, often happens in retrospect. Chapter 9, "Digital Social Construction of a Tourist Site: Ground Zero" by Can-Seng Ooi and Ana Maria Munar, drawing inspiration from Bakhtin's (1981) chronotopes, shows how spatial and temporal structures are being negotiated. By adopting a netnographic approach, Ooi and Munar examine the confessional tales of tourists visiting the contested site of Ground Zero and discuss new forms of technologically mediated authenticity. Through a systematic analysis of tourists' narratives and sociotechnical structures of TripAdvisor, this chapter provides insights into an emerging virtual tourism culture, where tourists are layering new meanings to historical sites, and are contributing to the rewriting of local histories, all as part of glocalization.

Chapter 10, "Tourism Social Media and Crisis Communication: An Erupting Trend" by Kristian Anders Hvass, studies the affordances of Internet technologies and social media as a crisis communication tool. It describes Scandinavian Airlines' use of new media platforms and micro-blogs to communicate with stranded passengers during the 2010 volcanic ash crisis. By combining the social mediated crisis communication model and situational crisis communication theory, the chapter identifies a new pattern of communicative practices to alleviate crisis impacts. The case explains the success of the airline in integrating social media in managing the crisis by portraying its organizational structuring and online learning processes transcending firm boundaries.

Chapter 11, "Web 2.0 Innovations in Events: Human Resource Management Issues" by Pamm Kellett and Anne-Marie Hede, explores how the adoption of social media platforms impacts organizational design, culture, and human resource management. Based on a cross-sectional study

of 12 event organizations, they demonstrate that social media affects event workers by creating role overload and ambiguity. The authors identify three types of social media innovation adopters: spontaneous activists, spontaneous reactors, and organized initiators and discuss the implication of these on human resource management.

Chapter 12, "Identity and Social Media in an Art Festival" by Fabrizio Montanari, Annachiara Scapolan, and Elena Codeluppi, investigates the role of social media through the lens of identity and social identification with an art festival. Drawing on the literature on temporary organizations, organizational identity, and the empirical case of an Italian festival, *Fotografia Europea*, the authors investigate how festivals communicate their central and stable characteristics to audiences by adopting social media-based communication strategies.

Part III. Future Perspectives

The volume concludes with the presentation of "Critical Digital Tourism Studies" by Ana María Munar and Szilvia Gyimóthy, and with Toby Miller's chapter. In an eclectic and highly personal essay, Miller argues for a change of agenda in the way tourism relates to media studies. First, he describes and contrasts two key phases of media studies, identifying the dominant perspectives and weaknesses of both. While Media Studies 1.0 conceptualizes audiences as passive consumers, Media Studies 2.0 acknowledges the agency of media consumers and the coproductive character of communication. This overtly naive perspective paints a picture of a deregulated, individualist, and truthful world of media where amateur opinion makers on social network sites defeat dictated, controlled, professional messages, hence altering the ways in which tourism sites and destinations are presented. Miller recommends media and tourism scholarship to progress toward a new, dialectical 3.0 perspective, integrating the black-and-white binaries of Media Studies 1.0 and 2.0. This agenda may open up new avenues of understanding power balances between media audiences and tourism authorities, the social and environmental impacts arising from this struggle, and the issue of media labor.

CONCLUSION

Social media add further dimensions to the tourist experience and provide new channels for communities to socialize and communicate about tourism. They represent a new form of mediating tourism realities, giving voice to

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personal reflections rather than representing the travel or the cultural industries. Virtual community platforms and online content posted by fellow tourists help other peers make sense of tourism. The reading, viewing, and making of digitized content ease the access to the experience of touristhood so that this experience increasingly not only takes place as a contrast to everyday activities but also in many different contexts.

Late modernity is characterized by high media intensity and saturation. Through the web, the world of tourism has gained access to a vast amount of constantly updated information from multiple sources. The question remains whether this increase in the speed, intensity, and extent of available information will eventually lead to a more human and sustainable tourism development. Social media contribute to expanding the communicative landscape of multimedia societies. Modern individuals are profoundly sociotechnical subjects (Lash, 2002). It is in the interface between the technical and the social that individuals define their identities, express their political beliefs, socialize and form attachments, and interact with the physical world around them. However, beyond aesthetic and hedonic pleasures and social recognition, the promises of new communication channels as tools for human emancipation are still to be proven.

Social media appear as a novel channel for social organization and political mobilization. Nevertheless, the exposure to massive amounts of fragmented information may not be equal to insight, wisdom, or justice. It is still to be seen whether this highly fragmented and ubiquitous public communication space can result both in public mobilization or entertainment and in political and legislative initiatives resulting in increased social welfare and equity. The existence of millions of people enjoying videos of laughing babies on YouTube or updating their personal status on Facebook or Twitter, brings memories of the famous "bread and circuses" of the Roman empire. Social media promise enlightenment but provide new ways to get public recognition and appeasement through entertainment. These new technologies have the potential to start a communicative revolution and to be emancipatory tools, but they may also end up being worldwide digitized circuses.

The question is how the massive amount of information and content displayed online can be transformed into insights that may help to solve some of the main issues that tourism and the world community are facing today. Tribe (2002) suggests the need for a stronger coupling between reflection and action in tourism and an increased commitment to achieving the good of tourism societies. This task also demands research to understand technical development and its impact on one's relationship to the worlds of

tourism. This book aims to increase academic reflexivity on the technical world of social media. It advocates that critical thinking and sociopolitical engagement can be applied to examine the development of the web and its connection to tourism sociocultural practices.

Digitization has provided the academic world with an ever-expanding landscape of data and research material available on the web and through organizations' ICT. However, the analysis of the virtual world represents a challenge to traditional research methods and is characterized by the rapid change in the patterns of use and the fragmentation and massive amount of data related to the different objects of analysis. The Internet changes the way in which researchers conduct qualitative and quantitative enquiry. There is a need for tourism to develop new methodological insights to advance the field (Tribe, 2008).

The theoretical grounding, conceptual developments, empirical evidence, and interdisciplinary analysis presented in this anthology expand the actual research agenda in this field and shed light on some conceptual tensions and ambiguities in the present literature. The book also contributes to increasing research reflexivity in studies that use the web and online content as their sites and objects of study. An important theme to be found throughout the book is the acknowledgement of the complexity of research design and processes when addressing a fast changing information-saturated context. The different chapters critically examine the validity of traditional methods for the study of virtual worlds and new digital platforms. As such, the book offers a new venue for reflections about emerging methods and ethical issues of social media research.

Chapter 3

Paradoxical Digital Worlds

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ABSTRACT

This chapter addresses emerging social media cultures and socio-technical practices through the theoretical lens of Theory of Communicative Action. This conceptual scene is used to explain the interplay between social media and tourism. It analyzes the paradoxical role of interactive technologies as forces for the reproduction and transformation of this industry. The chapter discusses processes of colonization of personal relations and life-spaces. The analysis shows the ambivalent potential of tourism social media as communicative technologies for emancipation but also as tools for hierarchization, control, and exploitation. Finally, further theoretical examination of technological development and tourism practices is sought.

Keywords: Lifeworld; Habermas; sociocultural practices; technology adoption

INTRODUCTION

There is an overarching interdependence between tourism and media. Increasingly, the tourism experience is reshaped by desire, imagination, and media as much as by physical travel itself (Crouch, Jackson, & Thompson, 2005; Jamal & Hollinshead, 2001). The emergence of the Web 2.0 and social media affect even more the way tourists plan, experience, and share their travels (Huang et al., 2010; Volo, 2010; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). The key

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characteristic of the Web 2.0 is that it enhances collaboration and sharing of information online. It is built around social media software, which makes it possible for people to communicate and form communities using their computers (Musser, O'Reilly, & O'Reilly Radar Team, 2007). Some of the most popular types of social media are wikis (Wikipedia), blogs (Travelblog), and microblogs (Twitter), social networks (Facebook), media sharing sites (Flickr, YouTube), review sites (TripAdvisor), and voting sites (Digg) (Stillman & McGrath, 2008; Zarrella, 2010). All these technological platforms allow tourists to create, upload, and publish individual experiences in a variety of digitized forms (Tussyadiah & Fesenmaier, 2009). Social media are new communicative platforms with the potential to transform the way in which individuals share and make sense of their tourism experiences.

Most studies of social media in tourism have examined this phenomenon from the consumer's perspective (Ayeh, Leung, Au, & Law, 2012). A stream of research has provided insights on the impacts of electronic word-of-mouth and user-generated content. Researchers have examined the credibility of blogs compared to traditional word-of-mouth (Mack et al., 2008), the relationship between blogging and positive sentiment toward websites' advertisements (Huang et al., 2010), the impact of social media sites on the Internet and on travel information searches (Xiang & Gretzel, 2010), and the increasing role that electronic word-of-mouth plays in the strategies of traditional marketers (Litvin et al., 2008).

Several contributions have focused on categorizing and examining digitized content, such as online reviews. Studies in this line of research have provided classifications according to types of tourism and its activities (Volo, 2010), typologies of tourists, types of technology adoption, and countries of origin (Enoch & Grossman, 2010; Gretzel, Kang, & Lee, 2008; Wenger, 2008). Bronner and de Hoog (2011) provide a study of motivational factors of tourists' knowledge-sharing behavior on review sites and introduce the term *e-fluent* tourist to describe active online contributors. A similar line of research has focused on a categorization of audiovisual contributions, such as Tussyadiah and Fesenmaier's (2009) study of online shared videos on YouTube. Several articles discuss the impact of new media on tourist decision making (Fotis, Buhalis, & Rossides, 2012; Jacobsen & Munar, 2012). Finally, some research studies have examined the challenges that tourist-generated content presents for destination management organizations and tourism firms (Ayeh et al., 2012; Munar, 2011, 2012; Schmallegger & Carson, 2008).

As can be seen from the research field depicted above, despite a growing body of knowledge, the majority of scholarly contributions are highly

heterogeneous and of an exploratory character. Academic work focusing on theoretical or paradigmatic perspectives on tourism social media is unusual. Most of the contributions are related to management and marketing studies. Theoretical frameworks grounded in other social sciences such as sociology, political science, and geography, just to name a few, are seldom applied. Further, in the field of technology and tourism, research deals mostly "with single empirical studies while conceptual papers driving theory development and critique are rare" (Gretzel, 2011, p. 758). The dominance of specific management and marketing approaches in this field results in a partial understanding of the complex phenomenon of online communication and in the hegemony of discourses oriented toward market development, profit, and efficiency. There is a need to strengthen theoretical knowledge in this field and to address questions such as how new media transforms and is transformed by culture and society. This chapter aims to face this theoretic lacuna by adopting Jürgen Habermas' (1984, 1987) theory of communicative action to analyze how social media generate socio-technical practices that change relationships and eventually become constitutive of the everyday life of tourism.

Social media entail a radical transformation in the possibilities of human communication (Baym, 2010) and Habermas' theory of communicative action has been considered a major theoretical contribution to the understanding of the role of communication in human development (Giddens, 1987). Habermas' extensive work ranges from political science to sociology and epistemology and it has been widely applied across diverse disciplines. Although highly influential within European critical social sciences, his contribution is also a polemical one. His critical view on postmodernism especially has been the target of criticism (Delanty, 2005). Habermas' theories analyze the challenge that economic processes represent for democracy and human emancipation. He argues that the evolution of democracy depends on the revival of the public sphere and that communicative practices and media play a crucial role in this revival. Social media is a new dimension of the public sphere and Habermas' theories can help to provide a deeper understanding of this phenomenon.

Habermas' philosophy of social science, mainly his focus on critical knowledge and the emancipatory potential of social analysis, has influenced a stream of tourism research that reflects on knowledge production (Pritchard, Morgan, & Ateljevic, 2011; Tribe, 2006). Nevertheless, a review of academic papers that make reference to Habermas' work in tourism research shows that the use of the theory of communicative action is very limited (Spracklen, 2011; Tribe, 2006, 2009), especially in relation to

information and communication technologies (ICT) in tourism. Alford and Clarke (2009) denounce this situation and the shortcomings of the dominance of a (post)positivist theoretical approach in the field of ICT and tourism, and advocate an increased use of critical theoretical perspectives, including Habermas' theoretical contribution.

The aim of this chapter is to use Habermas' theoretical framework to critically approach the technological and sociocultural phenomenon of tourism social media. To this end, the discussion presents Habermas' understanding of media in relation to the development of modern societies and explains how social media impact tourism understandings and relationships. Additionally, it discusses the ambivalent potential of tourism social media as communicative technologies for emancipation but also as technological tools for hierarchization, control, and commercialization. Finally, the chapter calls for further exploration of theoretical paths in the examination of technological development and tourism practices.

PARADOXICAL DYNAMICS OF TOURISM SOCIAL MEDIA

In *The Theory of Communicative Action*, Habermas (1984, 1987) proposes a paradigm for the social sciences based on the "mutual understanding between subjects capable of speech and action" (1987, p. 295). Social relations are developed thanks to people's ability to communicate through language with three main spheres of existence: the objective, subjective, and social worlds. Individuals interact with these worlds through communicative actions, which are processes of interpretation in which cultural knowledge is tested and "at the same time processes of social integration and socialization" (1987, p. 139). Communicative action takes place in a lifeworld, which is taken for granted and which allows individuals to perceive their world as accessible. Communicative rationality is essentially reflective criticism made of argumentations that are always open to revision (Giddens, 1987), and the concept of lifeworld plays a crucial role in the possibility of individuals to reach an understanding through communicative rationality:

Insofar as speakers and hearers straight forwardly achieve a mutual understanding about something in the world, they move within the horizon of their common lifeworld; this remains in the background of the participants—as an intuitively known, unproblematic and unanalyzable, holistic background [...] The lifeworld forms a horizon and at the

same time offers a store of things taken for granted in the given culture from which communicative participants draw consensual interpretative patterns in their efforts of interpretation. The solidarities of groups integrated by values and the competences of socialized individuals belong, as do culturally ingrained background assumptions, to the components of the lifeworld. (Habermas, 1987, p. 298)

Communicative action is the medium through which the lifeworld as a whole is reproduced. The lifeworld carries this task of social and cultural reproduction through different functions: "the propagation of cultural traditions, the integration of groups by norms and values, and the socialization of succeeding generations" (Habermas, 1987, p. 299). Although the lifeworld represents values and understandings that are taken for granted by individuals, it is not static. The dynamic change between what is taken for granted and what is taken up for critical revision happens through the social mechanism of *a situation*, which is a segment of the lifeworld context of relevance that is thrown into relief by themes and articulated through goals and plans of action. Despite the relevance of the lifeworld, its very existence is increasingly threatened by the evolution of modern social forms that entail the diminution of communicative rationality and the increase in noncommunicative and instrumental rationality, for example, through the commercialization (market dominance) and the bureaucratization (state and bureaucratic dominance) of social relationships.

Reproducing and Transforming Tourism through Digitized Worlds

Tourism social media is a constitutive part of the lifeworld of an increasing number of tourists. Uploading messages on Facebook or photos on media sharing sites has become a taken-for-granted communicative practice. The relationship of social media technologies with the lifeworld is, however, paradoxical. These interactive technologies help to reproduce but also to transform tourists' lifeworlds, nurturing the dynamics of change indicated by Habermas (1987). First, these media are channels for sociocultural reproduction, they perpetuate established practices and attitudes of the touristic lifeworld. They imitate, in virtual spaces, well-established features of tourism in modern societies. Moreover, to engage in touristic activities appears as "one of the defining characteristics of being 'modern'" (Urry, 2002, p. 2). As a central element of modernity and in everyday life

communication, many of the elements that compose the understanding of tourism are not challenged or questioned in online forums. Tourists communicate about their trips implying an understanding of what travel is, what a tourism product is, what it is to be a tourist, etc. Participants draw upon tourism sociocultural activities that have become established as part of the horizon of their modern lifeworld.

Research on virtual communities has identified the sharing of common frames of reference in relation to social norms, interests and goals, and sense of identity (Williams, 2009). For example, Adkins and Grant's (2007) study of an online community of backpackers suggests that participants draw on a common access to and knowledge of mundane backpacking experiences. In these online communities, there is a sense of a common cultural framework based on the everyday touristic backpacker experiences. These tourists share a common horizon of the lifeworld of backpacking that allows them to share consensual interpretative patterns. Tourists' digitized conversations draw upon established cultural tourism traditions and attitudes. The examination of tourist-generated reviews conducted by Munar and Ooi (2012) suggests that participants understand themselves as part of a community of fellow tourists who come together to create, share, and exchange information. Bronner and de Hoog (2011) identified social benefits and concerns related to solidarity, such as sense of belonging, group attachment, or being helpful as important motivation factors of online contributors.

The sharing of photos on media sites, such as Flickr or Facebook, are virtual practices that reproduce traditional tourism activities while demanding new technological competences. Digitized photos and videos have replaced the postcards and photo albums of the past. They keep tourists connected with the world at home and reproduce in virtual spaces traditional communicative practices about travel experiences. Tourists write personal travel stories and impressions and share them in different social media forums, for example, in blogging sites such as Travelblog or IgoUgo, without problematizing "tourism" or "being a tourist" as such. Their views and reviews posted on TripAdvisor are good examples of the taken-for-grantedness of some tourism elements:

Needless to say, the Forbidden City is one of the great historical sites that we have on this planet (Forbidden City, Mr-Maggot; italics added).

A visit here certainly makes you feel like you can check a box in your "Things to See Before You Die" list (Acropolis, uncvic).

The virtual space of social media reproduces inclusion and exclusion patterns of tourism physical worlds. Despite popular discourses on democratization and participation of social media, not everybody participates and shapes the digital tourism lifeworld. The world of digital technologies, as it also the case with the world of tourism, is only accessible for some. Bauman (1998), in his renowned book on globalization, denounced a global divide between tourists and vagabonds, between individuals with the right to mobility and leisure and those bounded to place. Tourists' social media participation demands the use of skills of complex modern everyday life such as consuming and shifting between media forms, producing, assembling, and deciphering multiple layers of texts and images (Campbell, 2005). Bauman's physical divide is mirrored in a virtual digital divide with the use of the Internet, with access to digital technologies and levels of e-literacy varying greatly throughout the world (Gursoy & Umbreit, 2004; International Telecommunication Union, 2009). The virtual digital divide is creatively presented in the art of Filippo Minelli. His art entitled "Contradictions" (Fig. 1) is a revealing and challenging collection of photos presenting "the gap between the reality we live in and the ephemeral world of technologies" (Pierce, 2008).

The second role of social media is that of transformation of the lifeworld of tourism. Social media communicative potential allows the dynamic



Figure 1. Facebook, Contradictions (Minelli, 2008)

establishment of situations and the problematization of what tourism is and should be. In social media sites, tourists can produce new situations by discussing and sharing novel issues from the “reservoir” of topics of the lifeworld of tourism. When uploading and downloading content about their holidays, tourists choose the elements that they want to transform into a situation, for example, when discussing the value of a natural site, denouncing commercialization tendencies, or sharing personal emotions related to the visit (Volo, 2010). The communicative potential of social media allows the settled lifeworld of tourism to be challenged. Tourists, through their online-created content, raise new questions about the goodness, justice, or value of travel. This entails an increased level of self-awareness about the touristic role (Campbell, 2005). Enoch and Grossman (2010) suggest how tourists’ blogging problematizes tourism experiences by focusing on the negative aspects of life in India, disapproving of different cultural views on sexual relations and gender, or criticizing a cultural encounter with the host community. Tourists’ reviews posted on websites challenge general views on heritage management traditionally concerned with the uniqueness and the cultural value of the sites. User-generated reviews show that tourists are just as concerned about sensory impressions, imagination, practical issues, and personal comfort in the immediate moment as they are about historical and cultural details (Munar & Ooi, 2012).

The emancipatory potential of social media challenges power relations in tourism. Blogs and their users are seen as powerful new agents in the touristic marketplace, acting as new intermediaries that change the rules of the game and challenge firms and organizations serving this industry (Huang et al., 2010). Increasingly, the diversity of digital images and stories about destinations challenge traditional ways of developing and building brands (Munar, 2010b, 2011). Thanks to this emancipatory potential, some studies portray social media content as wild or potentially dangerous. This literature advocates for improved management and marketing control (O’Connor, 2010; Schmallegger & Carson, 2008). However, controlling social media communication may turn out to be an impossible task. Web technologies provide global reach to the content created and shared by tourists (Qualman, 2009); and contrary to face-to-face social encounters, digital interactions introduce the possibility of anonymity and lack of personal accountability, such as an anonymous review posted on a review site such as TripAdvisor (Streitfeld, 2011).

Despite their emancipatory potential, social media are not neutral communication platforms. The sites have different ways to establish limits to the horizon of interpretation and to what can be introduced as a situation

and thus problematized and reflected upon. Social media sites differ in their level of openness and control mechanisms (Baym, 2010). While wikis (like Wikitravel) are an example of open frameworks of communication where software design and structure are part of the discussion among users, other platforms such as social networks or review sites display a much higher level of control by the administrators (Munar, 2010a).

Despite the promises of participation by these media (Sandoval & Fuchs, 2010), social media administrators use interface design and regulations to limit communicative practices and to shape the horizon of communication. For example, on the review site TripAdvisor, tourists discuss openly their opinions on tourism products but are not allowed to question preestablished rating categories and typologies. The terms of use of the social network Facebook also limit the type of communication among users. For example, the site prohibits nudity or drugs consumption in visual content (Pariser, 2011). However, casual sex, binge drinking, drug use, and other prohibited behavior are relevant practices of some tourism experiences (Sönmez et al., 2006; Uriely & Belhassen, 2006). Tourists sharing experiences on social media sites conform to communicative limitations. These technologies incorporate new rules and frameworks limiting what can be represented and discussed. Besides the barriers set up by the administrators of the sites, Internet companies such as Google, Facebook, Yahoo, and Microsoft are increasingly accused of acting as gatekeepers of web content thanks to the use of personalized filters that show the Internet that these companies believe users want to see (Pariser, 2011). These filters provide the type of information that supports users' previously established interests and views, acting as a conservative tool that makes challenging viewpoints different from the users' cultural background more difficult to access.

Commercialization and Colonization of the Lifeworld

Habermas (1987) provides a detailed explanation of the role of mass media in his chapter entitled "The Tasks of Critical Theory." His analysis differentiates between "steering" media and other forms of mass media. Steering media, money, and power do not rely upon communicative practices. Money and power are tools that enhance objectifying (reification) processes and the technicizing of the lifeworld. In systems dominated by steering media, such as the market or the state, persons stop being individuals with a rich and complex lifeworld and are reduced to being members or

consumers. Increased commercialization of social media means a diminution of communicative rationality and an expansion of noncommunicative and instrumental rationality. Eventually this development entails the dehumanization of society (Habermas, 1987, p. 308) and takes place when steering media colonizes the lifeworld. The colonization of the lifeworld happens

to the degree that elements of a private way of life and a cultural-political form of life get split off from the symbolic structures of the lifeworld through the monetary redefinition of goals, relations and services, life-spaces and life-times, and through the bureaucratization of decisions, duties and rights, responsibilities and dependencies. (1987, p. 322)

Steering media and mass media are thus intrinsically different. The latter are generalized forms of communication, which still remain tied to the lifeworld/communicative contexts and can allow communicative rational practices. But mass media is also different from face-to-face communication or word-of-mouth. Through mass media, communicative actors achieve a release of spatiotemporal specific contexts. These media have two main features. First, by being far removed from space and time, mass media allow access to messages in manifold contexts. Second, these media have an “ambivalent potential” (Habermas, 1987, p. 390); on the one side they establish new hierarchical structures and on the other remove restrictions for communication. The question to be examined is to what extent tourism social media represent a digitized form of mass media, contributing to the expansion of communicative action, and to what extent social media help to colonize the lifeworld by expanding the marketplace and objectifying personal relations and life-spaces.

According to Castells’ (2001) analysis of Internet cultures, social media should be understood as an electronic type of mass media, which have two important characteristics. First, they are structured through free and nonhierarchical communication based on the free exchange of ideas (Lash, 2002). Second, they permit self-directed connectivity, which allows any person to connect to the web and publish his/her own information. Self-directed connectivity (Castells, 2001) is a tool for social organization, collective action and meaning, and allows individuals to express their identities and to create and maintain social relations online. However, Castells’ arguments provide a partial view of social media development. An analysis of tourism social media shows that these communicative platforms have steering media features, such as customized advertising. Increasingly,

there is a commercialization and monetization of the content produced by the tourists, which is transforming online communicative platforms into global virtual marketplaces (Cook, 2008; Dellarocas, 2003; Law, 2006; O'Connor, 2010).

The process toward an increased commercialization of new media, or the expansion of instrumental rationality (Habermas, 1987), has been described as social media exploitation (Andrejevic, 2011). It is characterized by the transformation of social and emotional resources into tradable capital. This process can be seen as that of *separation* in which previously non-tradable areas of the lifeworld (such as personal face-to-face communicative acts about travel experiences) become assets in the process of production. The process entails the colonization of the lifeworld. Thanks to digitization processes, what previously were private social experiences of knowledge sharing are transformed into global databases of consumer information managed and analyzed by tourism firms and organizations (Miller & Christakis, 2011; Munar, 2011). This results in the establishment of new property rights on tourist-created content, which benefits tourism social media firms. Related sites are not only public spaces for dialogue, they are "big business." Social network sites such as Facebook have a communicative dimension but equally a commercial dimension with users constantly being exposed to advertising. YouTube is a media-sharing channel for tourists and organizations alike that is increasingly used to promote destinations (Fesenmaier & Cook, 2009). TripAdvisor provides millions of reviews by users but at the same time is a sales channel and advertising platform for tourism firms.

Commercial sites adopt social media tools to expand the touristic marketplace. Popular sites such as hotels.com or expedia.com combine traditional e-commerce features with user-generated reviews and use these reviews as promotional tools on their sites. These sites' financial results show that social media are not only platforms for the free exchange of ideas and personal empowerment, as argued by Castells (2001), but increasingly, very profitable businesses (Buss & Strauss, 2009). Commercialization tendencies are enhanced by the trend of linking e-commerce channels to social media platforms. Lu, Zhao, and Wang (2010) suggest that increasingly, major virtual communities aim to transform their users into buyers and sellers. For example, consumer-to-consumer e-commerce is already the most successful e-commerce business model in China and Facebook and Twitter are used by airlines as sales channels (Hvass & Munar, 2010). The attention paid by scholars to how tourism marketers can benefit from such platforms (Xiang & Gretzel, 2010) is also an indication of the increasing commercial dimension

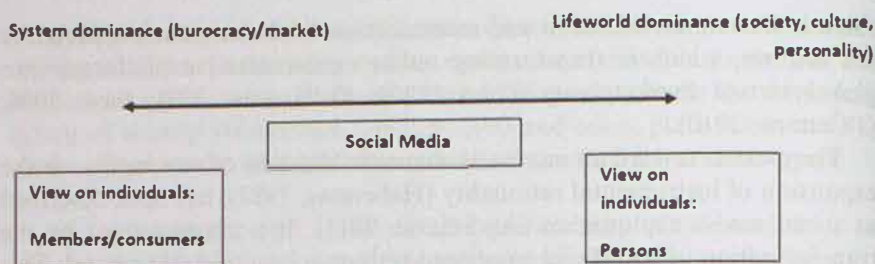


Figure 2. Commercialization and Emancipation of Tourism Social Media

of the media. The structural tension of the double nature of tourism social media is described in Fig. 2.

De-commercialization Tendencies and Emotional Influence

Social media are both an agent of commercialization of everyday practices (such as personal chats on social network sites) and an agent of de-commercialization of activities previously dominated by the market (user-generated travel guides on Wikitravel). Commercialization tendencies cohabit with communicative features that encourage non-monetized relationships and expand the reach of the lifeworld. An example of the expansion of the lifeworld in virtual space is CouchSurfing. This is a virtual community site that provides accommodation services for free and encourages a tourism experience rooted in lifeworld communicative practices, the sharing of personal information, interactivity with the local community, and establishment of a closer relationship between the host and the guest. CouchSurfing is also an example of the paradoxical double nature of social media. From its origins in 2003, its online community had a strong noncommercial identity, but in 2011 the site became a benefit corporation adopting a for-profit corporate model. Despite this change, CouchSurfing exemplifies the de-commodification of host and guest relationships and how social media can alter taken-for-granted understandings in this context. Tourism is not about gazing places (Urry, 2002) but an opportunity to participate in "creating a better world" and to "engage with the world in a whole new way" (CouchSurfing, 2011). The homepage of the community invites tourists to move away from traditional knowledge of places, the kind included in guidebooks, and to explore a

noncommercial experience, which includes communicative interaction with the host community:

Look up from that guidebook before you bump into a statue!
There are millions of people who want to freely welcome you
into their home and show you what it's really like where they
live. (CouchSurfing, 2011)

Through a holistic understanding of hospitality, this community also transforms the understanding of the tourist as a consumer. The site announces that "You don't need to cross the sea to practice a second language or pick up a new cooking technique" (CouchSurfing, 2011). Hosting a tourist is hosting a teacher of foreign languages, a possible friend, and a cultural ambassador. Social media platforms rely on the management and sharing of users' influence. According to Habermas (1987), communicative media entail the use of either cognitively specialized influence (through the sharing of knowledge in wikis or blogs) or normatively specialized influence (information about what is good and bad about hospitality services in a review site like TripAdvisor). Social media adopt these two forms of influence of traditional mass media, but additionally they are also based on *emotional influence*. They are "techspressive" (Kozinets, 2008, p. 870) technologies that provide individual realization, mediated pleasure, and escape.

The language of the virtual world includes a new form of grammar that reshapes linguistic and semantic rules enhancing emotional communication. Social media communicative culture mixes new signs with traditional language structures and enriches textual communication with feelings and a sense of immediacy (Baym, 2010, p. 103). Examples of digital communicative practices are the use of the "like" sign introduced by Facebook or the popular "smiley." Tourists use emoticons to signal happiness or disappointment and informal language to share their feelings. They use blogging sites to share their feelings and emotions related to their travel experience (Volo, 2010). Social media sites are digitized databases displaying tourists' emotional narratives. Access to cognitive, specialized, and emotional influence provided freely by tourists has become a successful tradable commodity that is reshaping the touristic marketplace.

Fluid Time-Space Relationships and Transformation of Reference Systems

Communicative situations are related to different spatiotemporal and social reference systems (Habermas, 1987). First, in relation to space, individuals

experience a space within their actual reach (a specific location such as a building or a room) and worlds within their potential reach (the city, region, country, continent, etc.). Second, from the perspective of time, it is possible to differentiate between the daily routine, the life history, the epoch, and so forth. Finally, from the perspective of a social dimension, there are diverse reference groups such as the family, the community, the nation, etc. ICT and electronic media represent a change in the spatiotemporal and social dimensions of the horizon of communicative situations. Communication through the web compresses time and space and establishes networks that are simultaneously local and global (Castells, 1996, 1997; Robertson, 1995).

Spatiotemporal Dimensions. The tourism social media space dimension is not a physical place but a ubiquitous and fluid virtual touristic one. Digitized communicative practices differ from face-to-face communication or communication in traditional media, which have a common public space with historical shared bonds. Digital media expand the worlds under tourists' potential reach and networks of influence become dominated by strangers (T. Smith, 2009). Bauman's (2000) liquid modernity thesis suggests that the transformation of reference groups and the compression of time and space enhanced by ICT augur the end of the era of mutual engagement. Social media represent the diaspora of public space communication. Bauman's negative view on technological development is a form of determinism in which people are seen as passive recipients of a development that damages personal relationships (Baym, 2010). However, social forces influence the development and evolution of technologies (Castells, 2001).

The possibilities of web technologies are reworked and transformed by everyday life practices rooted in the lifeworld. Social media studies indicate that online communities break traditional bonds, and they also provide sociability, support, information, a sense of belonging, and social identity (Wellman, Boase, & Chen, 2002). Social media technologies allow the emergence of new types of reference groups such as virtual communities and online-based social movements (the open source movement) and contribute not only to the boundary breaking of the social worlds but also to the establishment of new solidarities and personal encounters across frontiers. Thanks to its vast reach, the Internet has allowed the emergence of tourism communities of strangers (Adkins & Grant, 2007). While physical communities have traditionally been built on extended kinship and shared culture, virtual communities are framed as a consequence of "intentional social interaction" (Williams, 2009, p. 4).

Social media allow tourists to be socially and emotionally present, although physically absent. This way, tourists interact in a complex landscape of intertwined physical and virtual communities. A tourist can share photos with colleagues, get an update about a friend's activities by text messaging, or ask a question to a virtual travel community, being active in a multitude of spaces from a singular place. Digital media diffuse barriers between the world of the destination and the world at home, and between physical communities and virtual ones. At the same time, tourism takes place through embodiment and physical space (Urry, 2003). The virtuality and nonspatiality of social media technologies provide another dimension to the content shared in the sites that contains reflections and knowledge about the experience and consumption of physical spaces.

The diaspora of communicative space dilutes national frontiers while raising other communicative barriers. Social media is a virtual prolongation of today's consumer society and of the different level of access to global mobility. The openness of the new media stands in contrast to new emergent stratifications based on immigration control and economic inequality and reflects the different privileges of "tourists and vagabonds" (Bauman, 1998, p. 78). Communicative participation in online space demands an intentional act to be part of tourism. However, intentionality and desire are not enough. Participation is highly dependent on material aspects of cultural reproduction, for example, specific technological equipment, and know-how. These demands shape new social divisions based on technology access and ICT skills, increasing the diversity of tourism practices (Gursoy & Umbreit, 2004). The digital divide also has a generational dimension, with younger generations most actively shaping the web (Prensky, 2001; Tapscott, 2009). Further, tourists may share their experiences in their national languages, such as Hebrew or Danish (Enoch & Grossman, 2010), contributing to limited and localized touristic virtual spaces.

Time is also radically transformed by digitization. Social media provide tools for instant communication (like chat forums), but most of the genres of tourism social media, such as reviews, blogs, travel diaries, or audiovisual contributions, do not aim to be synchronous communication. Digitized texts and visual images are stored, recalled, shared, and commented upon (Baym, 2010). Similar to the difference between oral and written communication, the digitization of tourists' narratives and word-of-mouth involves a relative canonization of tourism communicative practices. However, the massive amount of data recorded and the informality of the communication that takes place in social media (Qualman, 2009), provide a canonization of banalities, similar to the recording of daily talk (Munar,

2010a), which is very different from other types of formal, written tourism information sources such as guidebooks and travel reviews in traditional printed media.

Hierarchy, Control, and Reference Groups. Mass media are characterized by an “ambivalent potential” (Habermas, 1987, p. 390). They establish new hierarchical structures and also remove restrictions for communication. Tourism social media entail major changes in communication channels and hierarchical structures (in the power relations between top-down and center-periphery). This feature results in changes in the way social control is executed. Contrary to face-to-face social encounters, digital interactions introduce the possibility of anonymity and lack of personal accountability, such as an anonymous fake hotel review posted on a site (Streitfeld, 2011). Social media can also be used for increased social control and monitoring (Baym, 2010; Munar, 2010a). For example, the publication of unfavorable, discreet disclosures on the web, including travel tales, can lead to employees getting fired. One example of this is the 13 crew members of Virgin Atlantic who were fired because they criticized passengers and the airline on Facebook (Vassou, 2008). Social media bring new risks that are characterized by being more difficult to manage for individuals and organizations. They are more diffused, multidimensional, and ambiguous. The Web 2.0 has become a new channel for the expansion of the World Risk Society (Beck, 1993). Researchers point to the need for tourism organizations to develop an increased reflexivity about these communicative tools (Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). However, because of the very nature of communication in social media, a systematic enforced repression may also be very difficult to exert.

Habermas suggests (1987) that the one-sidedness of media can alter the potential of emancipation in communication networks. Media have different top-down communication patterns and central-peripheral dynamics. In social media, the tourist is the new centrality. These platforms allow a cacophony of voices but in many cases discourses of local communities are just missing (Munar & Ooi, 2012). In review sites or travel blogs, the conversation is one of tourists for tourists. These platforms contribute to a virtual touristification of place based on the view of the visitor. The tourist consumer is the new centrality and the locals are the new periphery of social media communication. Despite the dominance of tourists’ discourses in social media, there are also examples of organizations using interactive technologies to tap into the knowledge of local residents. The destination management organization of the city of Copenhagen, Denmark, launched a

campaign called "Your Copenhagen" inviting residents to upload stories and images of their city. This is an example of how tourist marketers try to adapt their strategies to electronic word-of-mouth and virtual communities (Litvin et al., 2008) and how knowledge of local residents has the potential to become a tradable resource of tourism organizations thanks to digitization.

Some critical perspectives challenge the community-building dimension of social media and examine the self-promotion tendencies and the lack of solidarity and empathy of web contributors (Williams, 2009). Tourists use social media as a new tool to enhance their ego-tripping experience (M. Smith, 2009, p. 261). Enoch and Grossman (2010), in their study of travel bloggers in India, indicate that "the impression which the reader gets from many of these journals is an absurd one: The Indians are conceived as the ones who prevent the journal writers from fully enjoying India" (p. 529). Virtual communities and networks also provide channels for increasing voyeuristic tendencies (Munar, 2010a) and the reaffirmation of tourists' socioculturally preconceived knowledge of the touristic places (Jackson, 2005). Additionally, social media allow easy and cheap media production but not all contents receive public visibility or influence (Sandoval & Fuchs, 2010).

"When we tell stories, we cannot avoid also saying indirectly how the subjects involved in them are faring, and what fate the collectivity they belong to is experiencing" (Habermas, 1987, p. 137). Social media provide opportunities to enter and establish new collectivities. It entails an expansion of the traditional "we," such as the nation, the workplace, or the family. In social media platforms, the "we" becomes a fluid community of cyberspace users. Here narrativity and storytelling reflect both upon the experiences of subjects involved in activities and on the collectivity of tourists as a whole. Tourism is an activity linked to identity construction and lifestyle (Jafari, 1987; Wang, 2000). Web users shape their identity (at personal and collective levels) also through touristic imagination and activities that are shared as part of presentable digitized stories of their travels. The impact of media expansion has also been noticed by other studies such as Campbell's (2005) "post-tourism" thesis and Haldrup and Larsen's (2010) emphasis on the afterlife of tourism experiences. In a digital age characterized by media proliferation and saturation, tourism is increasingly being imagined and "told" besides being "physically experienced." Social media mediate experiences and provide new layers of meaning and action in tourism.

CONCLUSION

The theory of communicative action helps to reveal the high complexity and the paradoxical nature of tourism social media. These are technological tools that help to shape the evolution of tourism in late modernity. Technological evolution is rooted in sociocultural practices and as such is embedded in a lifeworld of tourism practices. At the same time, technologies have the potential to transform social relations, attitudes, and understandings. The examination of the nature of these media showed that they have an ambivalent potential. Social media platforms help to reproduce understandings and attitudes about the industry and the tourist that are taken for granted in the lifeworld of tourism practices, but they also have an emancipatory and transformative potential. Communication through participative and interactive digital media establishes new understandings of what tourism should be and transforms power relations and structures in this process.

Habermas suggests that the project of modernity entails the increasing colonization of the lifeworld by steering media such as money and power. However, the analysis of social media technologies shows that the evolution of modern societies is not linear but multidimensional and highly complex. Social media have a revolutionary and transformative potential in relation to the touristic marketplace. Thanks to digitization of knowledge and influence, these technologies commercialize and monetize new areas of tourism that previously belonged to the sphere of the lifeworld, for example, when social network sites use the emotional and social capital of individual tourists as commercial resources. Social media technologies enable the process of separation in which previously non-tradable areas of the tourism lifeworld become assets in the process of capitalist production and the expansion of instrumental rationality. However, paradoxically these very same technologies are also agents of the expansion of the lifeworld, communicative rationality, and the diminution of commercial spheres in tourism. They create new communities of strangers based on communication practices and provide tourism services and experiences outside of the marketplace. The case of CouchSurfing is an example of social media expansion of communicative rationality and the lifeworld.

This chapter challenges Habermas' division between mass media and steering media. The barrier between these two types is today increasingly blurred. Social media are at the same time tools that expand personal freedom and entail new possibilities for control and monitoring. Web technologies mix commercial and communicative practices. They allow

tourists to plan different and transformative tourism experiences but also enable organizations to monitor and control individual choices and behavior. The chapter questions discourses that portray social media platforms as neutral and open communicative scenes. The examination of social media sites such as TripAdvisor or Facebook shows that tourists conform to preestablished communicative limitations. These technologies are not democratic public spaces; they incorporate new rules and frameworks limiting what can be represented and discussed. Tourist-generated content increases the diversity of tourism voices and promotes the voice of the tourist consumer as the new centrality of the touristic cyberworld.

Social media have the power to foreground actors in and to redefine and reframe the tourism phenomenon. The virtual space reproduces the unequal opportunities to initiate and participate in communication about tourism that exist in the material world. E-fluent tourists that can digitize their travel experiences have access to economic, sociocultural, and political capital. The interplay of tourism and technology is tied to political systems and economic growth. Positive discourses on the web do not change the fact that individuals are excluded from tourism by visa restrictions, poverty, sociocultural constraints, lack of personal freedom, and increasingly also poor e-literacy and lack of access to ICT. There is an abundance of materiality in the immaterial world of tourism social media. Exclusion and divisions of the material world are reproduced and reshaped in virtual spaces. Finally, as scholars we should increasingly question the purpose of tourism social media research and ask for whom this research is conducted (Tribe, 2006). An examination of the literature shows that technology research in tourism is mainly dominated by positivistic approaches and technical interests (Bronner & de Hoog, 2011; Huang et al., 2010; O'Connor, 2010; Schmallegger & Carson, 2008; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010) and that critical views on the exploitation of online resources and the study of marginalized voices is rare. The academic community needs to adopt new modes of inquiry and theoretical paths to question the complex interplay between tourism and technology development. Increasingly, it becomes critical to address the interests that dominate technological research and embrace critical perspectives to make sense of digital media and their consequences for the future of tourism.

Chapter 4

Symbolic Convergence and Tourism Social Media

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ABSTRACT

The majority of scholarly contributions in tourism social media have focused on assisting practitioners to optimize online platforms or to describe the digital behavior of prospective individual tourists. These studies are dominated by mechanistic ontological frameworks, which take little notice of the inherently social nature of tourism consumption. Acknowledging the sociality of Web 2.0 communications, this chapter explores the potentials of an alternative analytical framework informed by symbolic convergence theory. The linkages between tourism social media, virtual communities, and symbolic convergence processes are illustrated by examples of postings taking place on the Facebook fan site of Roskilde festival. These examples highlight the significance of symbolic communities in shaping the visitor experience against the backdrop of contemporary consumer culture.

Keywords: Virtual communal marketing; symbolic convergence theory

INTRODUCTION

Social media and virtual communities are becoming significant aspects of tourism consumption, and they may fundamentally change the way people select and consume tourism offerings. Social media platforms present novel

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strategic opportunities for marketers, offering unsolicited, user-driven, and more trustworthy ways to construct images of tourism organizations and destinations (Wang et al., 2002). Unlike conventional promotional channels, social media also have the prospect of establishing long-lasting relationships between potential consumers and brands or products. However, as online dialogue and brand ambassadorship has only recently entered the world of strategic communication, marketers must rethink how to address and build alliances with online communities.

To assist practitioners in finding new ways of engaging tourists on social media sites, researchers have mainly offered prescriptive recommendations. These include provision of networking platforms and talking points, involvement of customers in blogs and multimedia promotional tools, enabling of dialogue and customer feedback, and the illusion of exclusivity (Muñiz & Schau, 2007). Scholars have so far focused on finding optimal design solutions tailored to the online search behavior of prospective customers or on simultaneously enabling and regulating consumer sovereignty. Arguably, the preoccupation with a normative agenda in contemporary research practices has resulted in sluggish theoretical development regarding the deeper understanding of social media communications in tourism. Instead of building upon recent contributions conceptualizing digital communications and online communities in general, tourism scholars still adhere to a narrow ontological approach to Web 2.0 communications. The following sections review how two particular schools of communication theory dominate tourism social media studies and subsequently identify flaws in contemporary research practices.

Information Systems Theory

Information systems theory (IST), derived from the classic mathematical models of Shannon and Weaver (1949) and Berlo (1960), conceptualizes communication at the syntactic level, modeling it as a message flow and feedback system between senders, receiver(s), and a mediating channel. These models are helpful in addressing pragmatic problems of how to optimize the transfer of information in a noisy, dynamic system and ultimately assist managers to choose the right channels and instruments for their campaigns to maximize marketing effects. Scholars studying the affective design of social media platforms import the conceptual frameworks of IST, assuming that by grooming various parameters, the "right" interactive setting can be created for customers. In the past few years, a number of practical, how-to-do-it books have been published, offering social

media management recipes within and beyond tourism (Mangold & Faulds, 2009; Sigala, Christou, & Gretzel, 2012).

There are a number of problems involved with treating social media communications as analogous to mechanistic systems, where human communication and decision making are thought to follow rational transaction processes. First, it is assumed that social media communications can be manipulated along a Pavlovian scheme: given the right design and choice architecture (or conditional stimulus), individuals will respond in a predictable way. Second, marketing meanings are conceptualized in an essentialist way, maintaining that they are ultimately captured and defined by marketers' messages. However, marketing scholarship is today more inclined toward the tenets of the value cocreation paradigm (Vargo & Lusch, 2004), suggesting that meanings emerge from the collaborative interaction between providers and consumers. The notion of consumers as active coproducers of marketing messages is particularly important for understanding social media communications, where anyone can create, comment, and add to social media content (Brown, Kozinets, & Sherry, 2003; Schau, Muñiz, & Arnould, 2009; Thompson & Sinha, 2008). This implies not only that communications happen in multimodal networks (many-to-many instead of dyads), but also that meanings are altered while passing from one messenger to another (Kozinets, de Valck, Wojnicki, & Wilner, 2010). Furthermore, as Baym (2010) suggests, the patterns and "reach" of social media communications are unpredictable. Hence static models based on the theoretical underpinnings of IST remain ignorant on the dynamics of such creative and transformative processes.

Uncertainty Reduction Theory

Uncertainty reduction theory (Berger & Calabrese, 1975) focuses on the pragmatics of communication: the motives of information sharing rather than explaining the structure of communication flows. With its roots in behavioral psychology, this school of thought posits that communication is a goal-oriented action steered by tension-reducing tactics. Research on travel planning maintains that tourists undertake an extensive information search and attempt to maximize their knowledge in advance in order to reduce risk and uncertainty (Gitelson & Crompton, 1983; Holloway & Robinson, 1995; Wang et al., 2002). Following this thread, the majority of studies on the online tourism domain are preoccupied with the role of social media in the online tourism information search (Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). Virtual tourism communities are regarded as peer-to-peer review tools, allowing members to

search for various functional, socio-psychological, and hedonic benefits (Wang & Fesenmaier, 2004). Consequently, the operationalization of online behavior and satisfaction of prospective tourists revolves around the conditions of convenient and effective information search (Chung & Buhalis, 2008b) or the factors influencing trustworthiness of different types of review sites (Dickinger, 2011).

Chung and Buhalis (2008, p. 79) regard social media review sites as "an information source [...] and attractive virtual market place," which can be turned into appropriate channels for targeted messages, if only marketers succeed in developing "an informative and substantial online community." However, none of these scholars deals with the question of how exactly a substantial online community arises or how to design marketer messages suitable for social media platforms. Facebook is full of autocommunicating walls owned by tourism firms and destinations, mostly featuring informative postings from their own employees or project managers, and a few "external" fans. This implies that people's involvement in virtual communities may go well beyond activities of information search and the facilitation of travel decisions.

Consumer Tribes and Virtual Communities

By focusing on identifying individual needs and behavioral characteristics of social media users, tourism research to date fails to take the *collective nature* of social media into account. Consumers do not exclusively use new digital platforms to exchange information (and hence, reduce decision-related uncertainties) but also to build clusters of social affiliations with like-minded peers across geographic or temporal divides. Marshall McLuhan's prediction of society being retribalized based on computer-mediated, inclusive forms of communication, seems to be coming true (in Kozinets, 1999, p. 253). Today, there exists a variety of forms of e-tribes converging on social networking sites, online gaming worlds, and collaborative knowledge projects. People sharing (sub)cultural traits are today gathering in virtual communities, and the emergence of these "tribes" is often due to brand fandom or other consumption interests (Cova, Kozinets, & Shankar, 2007). Common for these affiliative groups is that their online interactions "are based upon shared enthusiasm for and knowledge of a specific consumption activity or related activities" (Kozinets, 1999, p. 254). As such, consumption-related interests and social interests often intertwine. Kozinets (1999) introduces a typology of online communities based on two differentiating features of

interactivity: social structure (loose vs. strong ties), and interaction focus (information exchange vs. socialization). For instance, chat rooms are characterized by weak social ties where the primary reason to participate is to socialize with each other; members of lists or rings are strongly connected, but their interaction is more focused on discussing specific themes. Each e-tribe has its own social hierarchy, ceremonies, and practices, which are shaped by shared behavioral norms and moral standards.

These differentiating features (social structure and interaction focus) define four ideal member types in virtual consumption communities, such as devotees, insiders, tourists, and minglers (Kozinets, 1999, p. 255). Devotees and insiders are assumed to be more involved with the consumption activity than tourists or minglers, and their relatively higher knowledgeability would ensure them higher ranks in the social hierarchy of the tribe. Marketers are eager to find ways to use these individuals as opinion leaders to market messages and to harness the inherent trustworthiness of peer-to-peer communications. This could, for example, entail giving away free samples of newly released consumer goods to bloggers for community reviews. Kozinets et al. (2010) demonstrate that such managed word-of-mouth endorsements are a result of a delicate balance between promotional messages and the bloggers' credibility among community members. In order to conform to the communicative norms of a forum and to remain loyal to their own virtual identity, bloggers adopt various narrative strategies while transforming commercial information to stories that are relevant to their particular peers (Kozinets et al., 2010).

Shifting the view of social media as e-tribalized communication platforms has several implications. First, as Kozinets (1999, p. 261) puts it, online consumers are "more active, participative, resistant, activist, loquacious, social and communitarian than they have previously been thought to be." Second, depending on the type of the digital platform, interaction among community members often has a social, ludic, and symbolic character. Hence, by posting brand meanings or promotional messages in these environments, marketers must anticipate that these will be creatively altered and transformed to serve communal purposes. Arguably, research on tourism social media must acknowledge the sociality of social media and pursue an understanding of the dynamics of tribal communication, which goes beyond implications for managerial action. How does meaning emerge in coproduced group communications? How does the social hierarchy of a virtual community affect which meanings endure and which perish? How do consumers relate to overt and covert promotional messages on social networks?

THE NARRATIVE PARADIGM AND SYMBOLIC CONVERGENCE THEORY

These issues can be addressed by taking an alternative worldview of communication epitomized by narrative paradigm theory (Fischer, 1984). It offers an understanding of the nature and function of communication as a constitutive force in the forming of social groups, communities, and organizations. It sees human beings as social storytellers (*Homo Narrans*), holding that social reality and human experience are ordered and communicated as stories. Building on the narrative paradigm, rhetorical theorist Ernest Bormann developed symbolic convergence theory (SCT), claiming that sharing common fantasies may transform a collection of individuals into a cohesive group. Voiced fantasies are instruments to share common experiences, meaning, and emotions. Telling and sharing fantasies enable sharing of a common symbolic reality and thus hold the key for building group consciousness:

Shared fantasies provide group members with comprehensible forms for explaining their past and thinking about their future—a basis for communication and group consciousness. (Bormann, 1985, p. 128)

SCT describes the interactive process through which human beings converge by telling individual fantasies, dreams, hopes, or fears in a shared symbol system (Bormann, 1985, p. 188) and offers a stringent analytical framework to capture the dynamic progression of meaning creation in groups. By accounting for the processes and symbolic ground that create and sustain group consciousness, SCT may also contribute to a new understanding of how virtual communities arise and interact on social media sites. This chapter discusses the potential of SCT as a framework to analyze the dynamics of social media communications and the cocreation of virtual consumer tribes on social media platforms. The theoretical challenge is to establish a framework to understand and critically examine unfolding communication patterns on social media that can eventually explain the collective behavior of bloggers, tweeters, and tripadvisors. The discussion below critically reviews the basic assumptions and elements of SCT and its adaptation to different contexts. This is followed by an examination of the implications of SCT in tourism social media and virtual rhetorical communities, illustrated by an example from a music festival's social network site.

The Tenets of Symbolic Convergence Theory

SCT is a general theory, combining socio-psychological and rhetorical (humanistic) traditions in communication studies, which offers a theoretical and analytical framework to study the process of group formation through communication. It views communication as a hybrid structuring tool, which creatively constructs and is being constrained by reality. In the beginning of the 1970s, small group communication researchers (Bales, 1970; Bormann, 1972) discovered that group consciousness arises from a particular sequence of communication acts and is sustained through the communication and collective creation of recurring fantasy themes. To illustrate the symbolic convergence process, Bormann introduced a conceptual vocabulary entailing: dramatizing message, fantasy theme, fantasy type, and rhetorical vision. The method of revealing the relationships between these concepts is termed fantasy theme analysis, and it focuses on direct observation of communication with either ethnographic, discursive, or quantitative (Q-sort, content analysis) approaches. Conducting a fantasy theme analysis is a hierarchical sorting process, sifting dramatic content into larger abstract categories (similar to the clustered coding approach of grounded theory). Dramatic content may be traced, for example, in conversations, mass media debates, customer responses to marketer messages, or virtual forum postings.

A central term in SCT is *fantasy*, which refers to the creative, imaginative, and shared interpretation of real events. Etymologically, it stems from the Greek work *phantaskikos*, originally meaning "to show or to make visible." As Bormann (1985, p. 130) states:

Rhetorical fantasies may include fictitious scripts but often relate to things that have actually happened to members of the group or that are reported in authentic accounts of history, the news media, oral history or folklore of other groups of communities.

A fantasy chain always starts with a dramatizing message, which is a narratively crafted comment or statement put on display by one individual. When individuals publicly share their own interpretation of an event (fantasy), they often do it by using rhetorical effects. Dramatizing messages may take various figurative linguistic forms, such as inside jokes, cryptic allusions, word plays, anecdotes, allegories, imaginary fables, or legends, which all have the capacity to catch the attention of the listeners (Bormann & Bormann, 1990). Dramatizing messages may stimulate the other members of the group to respond and participate in the story by expanding or enhancing it. When

a group of people is caught up in a fantasy, it can develop into an “explosive communication episode” (Bormann, 1983, p. 73), where several people join in to comment. The tempo of the conversation accelerates and similar emotional expressions (happiness, sadness, anger) are displayed. Not only do they appropriate (go along with) the story, but also creatively modify and add to it. The outcome of such a chain reaction is the shared fantasy theme, which will constitute the common symbolic ground to unite the members of the group (Bormann, Knutson, & Musolf, 1997). In other instances, the listeners may respond with apathy and ignorance or reject the dramatizing message by sneering at or ridiculing the messenger. With the sharing of several fantasy themes, common scripts or scenarios emerge. Eventually these develop into broad and consistent views on social reality, pulling together various symbolic elements and fantasy themes into a rhetorical vision (Bormann, 1983). A rhetorical vision could be defined as a grounding symbolic reality that “glues” the community together; the group of people who participates in it is called a rhetorical community. With the structured approach of fantasy theme analysis, one can identify and quantify fantasy themes and types converging into an ultimate (or sometimes several, opposing) rhetorical vision(s). Opposing rhetorical visions demarcate the rhetorical boundaries within communities and may reveal deep roots for cultural conflict.

¹SCT has been criticized for some explanatory pitfalls (Mohrmann, 1982). First, it does not clarify why people would share fantasies and start dramatizing reality in the first place, apart from referring to the basic assumption of the narrative paradigm (that humans are predisposed toward skilled storytelling). In an attempt to revitalize Bormann’s contribution, Olufwote (2006) suggests bolstering SCT with Karl Weick’s sensemaking framework: a process of organizing and structuring the unknown by “bracketing cues from a past experience in order to construct meaning out of them” (Weick, 1995, p. 464). When facing uncertainty or crisis, people use retrospective sensemaking to anticipate and enunciate predictable future scenarios. Viewed through Weick’s framework, the human predisposition to dramatize reality is essentially a collective sensemaking activity to understand lived experience and ultimately, oneself. Consequently, rhetorical visions may be divided into three master analogues: pragmatic, social, and righteous rhetorical visions (Cragan & Shields, 1981). A pragmatic rhetorical vision is built on rational and utilitarian arguments and practical ways of dealing with problems. Social rhetorical visions are concerned with developing, repairing, or maintaining alliances and relationships among people or social groupings, while righteous rhetorical visions gather elements

symbolizing morals and dedication for a higher cause (Bormann, Cragan, & Shields, 1996).

The second theoretical weakness concerns the convergence ideology itself, which assumes egalitarian group dynamics and conflict-free membership in rhetorical communities (Olufwote, 2006). By focusing on the members subscribing to the rhetorical vision, scholars underemphasize diversity and the potential of conflicting opinions. Achieving a cohesive group and common symbolic ground may be paved with disagreement and negotiations. This tenuous and dynamic process is acknowledged in recent contributions, which are reviewed in the next sections.

Applications of Symbolic Convergence Theory

Despite the weaknesses discussed above, SCT has had a significant impact on communication studies and has been adopted in a wide variety of areas, such as organizational communication, intercultural communication, and mass communication (Bormann, Cragan, & Shields, 1994, 2001; Cragan & Shields, 1995). Its popularity may be attributed to its general applicability to a range of communication phenomena on the individual, collective, and socio-historical levels (Olufwote, 2006). For instance, in an organizational communication context, Cragan and Shields (1992) illuminated how a new corporate symbolic reality may be repositioned by creating new and differentiated fantasy themes addressing distinct rhetorical visions of different market segments. Terry (2001) found that fantasy themes of mass-broadcast political campaigns also work effectively to persuade and engage voters. In the intercultural context, Bormann and Itaba (1992) demonstrated the universality of symbolic convergence processes. By comparing North American and Japanese respondents' reception to four different narrative dimensions, they found that people's predisposition toward sharing fantasies and dramatizing messages is similar across cultures. Last, but not least, SCT may provide explanations for understanding the functioning of groups and member commitment to collective causes.

Coalition researchers have recently identified the potential of the symbolic convergence approach in studying the dynamics of group development and the role of rhetorical visions in constituting, reinforcing, or splitting up a symbolic community (Broom & Avanzino, 2010; Olufwote, 2006; Taylor, 2005). Rhetorical visions are deemed crucial for coalition success as they may guide the actions or serve as ideological underpinnings of individual member's action (Foster-Fishman, Berkowitz, Lounsbury, Jacobson, & Allen, 2001).

However, rhetorical visions are seldom conflict-free. Considering Foster-Fishman et al.'s claim that a coherent vision is essential for maintaining a successful coalition, Broom and Avanzino (2010) studied and classified emergent fantasy themes in a nonprofit community coalition. They found two conflicting rhetorical visions serving complementary roles in maintaining group cohesion: one to keep members committed to the group, the other to create symbolic group boundaries and distinguish the coalition ("we") from other communities ("them"). However, contrasting rhetorical visions may also lead to potential group conflict and fragmentation. Demarcations between insiders and outsiders may marginalize certain groups or interests and, in the long term, destabilize symbolic communities. Paradoxically, particular fantasies that contributed to the emergence of a coalition in the first place may, if they become inflexible, run the risk of obstructing the sustainment and renewal of the group.

Bormann et al. (1996) suggest a life cycle analogy to describe how rhetorical visions emerge, grow, decline, and come to an end. They illustrate the rise and fall of rhetorical visions in a five-stage model through a genealogical analysis of the Cold War concept. The emergence of the rhetorical vision (stage one) can always be traced back to a distinct dramatizing event, in this case the Truman Doctrine speech. If several people dedicate themselves to the rhetorical vision, by weaving fantasy themes further and altering their behavior accordingly, the rhetorical vision enters into its second, consciousness-raising phase. In the third, consciousness-sustaining stage, members of the rhetorical community maintain their commitment to the vision either by reiterating or restating key fantasy themes or by defending it against criticism and counter-rhetoric. In this phase, it is important to notice how rhetorical visions adapt to change, as this affects their long-term survival. If the characters, stages, and plotlines are adjusted to new situations, then it is a flexible vision; if it remains static, it would be termed an inflexible vision. Over time, rhetorical visions may lose their explanatory power and decline, or give way to alternative/competitive visions. Eventually, rhetorical visions become too inflexible to explain changes in its community and often end with a rapid implosion.

The cyclical engagement in a fantasy theme has also been studied and confirmed in a tourism-related context. Lanier and Hampton (2008) studied visitor participation in five renaissance festivals in the United States to understand the relationships between the dynamics of fantasy engagement (exposure, learning, acting, modification) and control over the resources of the festival experience. They found that as visitors move through a fantasy cycle (from passively being exposed to it to actively modifying it), their

participation in the experience changes. In the fantasy-creating stage, their involvement in the experience is characterized by utilizing resources provided and controlled by the festival producer. In the consciousness-raising stage, visitors enhance their fantasy engagement by codesigning and coproducing stories together with the producers. Finally, consumers may take entire control over the experience, searching for new ways to produce and engage with the rhetorical vision (for instance, by staging medieval reenactment or role-play with other consumers). Consequently, visitor participation differs significantly in each stage and adopts different resources and strategies to enact renaissance fantasies. This approach may also contribute to a more dynamic reading of the archetypal tribal members described by Kozinets (1999). Rather than imposing a structural confinement and seeing devotees, insiders, tourists, and minglers as distinct individuals, one might argue that they could be the same person at various stages of a tribal career (see also the notion of the versatile tourist, Ooi, 2002b).

Symbolic Convergence and Tourism Social Media

SCT offers a framework that may be appropriate for delving deeper into the social dynamics of tourism social media. By exposing communication strings and online polylogues to fantasy theme analysis, the rhetorical vision of a virtual community may be identified. Such an analysis may also give an indication of the group cohesion and reveal symbolic grounds for group conflicts or fragmentation. For an illustration, this section explores a fraction of the symbolic converging practices of an established Scandinavian rock festival in cyberspace.

Popular cultural events and festivals are typical examples of tribal gatherings where sense of community is as important as the featured artists themselves. Marketers have long acknowledged the collective power of the community in creating, appropriating, and sustaining unique meanings connected with a festival brand. However, such tribal enactments have been so far concentrated within the temporal confines of the event. Social media platforms enable the creation of tribal practices and the negotiation of collective identities throughout the year, thereby offering new marketing opportunities to cater to the existential needs of a tribe.

Roskilde Festival is a Danish music festival established in 1971, currently attracting over 130,000 attendees every year. The essence of Roskilde Festival is labeled "Orange Feeling," referring to the iconic Orange Scene (the largest concert venue of the festival), but connotatively pointing at

However, rhetorical visions are seldom conflict-free. Considering Foster-Fishman et al.'s claim that a coherent vision is essential for maintaining a successful coalition, Broom and Avanzino (2010) studied and classified emergent fantasy themes in a nonprofit community coalition. They found two conflicting rhetorical visions serving complementary roles in maintaining group cohesion: one to keep members committed to the group, the other to create symbolic group boundaries and distinguish the coalition ("we") from other communities ("them"). However, contrasting rhetorical visions may also lead to potential group conflict and fragmentation. Demarcations between insiders and outsiders may marginalize certain groups or interests and, in the long term, destabilize symbolic communities. Paradoxically, particular fantasies that contributed to the emergence of a coalition in the first place may, if they become inflexible, run the risk of obstructing the sustainment and renewal of the group.

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a range of symbolic meanings that embrace ideologies born and cultivated in the 1970s (solidarity, community, rock and roll, liberal attitudes to sex, and boundary-crossing festivities). These (such as the traditional Naked Run competition or the donation of surplus consumables to marginalized groups) are manifested in tribal rituals during the festival as well as frequently mentioned and debated by the online community. Roskilde Festival's Facebook wall offers a particularly rich gateway to study the symbolic convergence of fans, as the virtual community is substantial, both in terms of number of fans (130,000) and average frequency of postings (67/day), with a 32:1 fan/wall owner posting ratio (Larson & Gyimóthy, 2012). For the purposes of this chapter, a fantasy chaining process is illustrated below, revealing contested rhetorical visions.

The distinct communication event started on July 27, 2011 (the day after the festival ended) with the wall owner posting a recurrent post-event question on Facebook: "Do you have a great idea how we can make Roskilde Festival in 2012 even better?" One dramatic response triggered an exalted discussion. Note the accelerated tempo indicated by the time stamps in brackets:

Better music less crap.... don't be like everyone else and make Roskilde Festival one big cleaning, organic beer, unknown music, come-together mekka. Thx. (19:20 by S)

It would be nice if the organization behind Roskilde Festival will use 2012 to decide whether it is a music festival a charity event or a Tivoli. Then the audience have a better opportunity to set their expectations from the type of the arrangement they are participating in. (20:03 by PLH)

Start by playing some damn good music. (20:08 TJS)

No, we need EVEN worse bands next year. They must be TOTALLY unknown and REALLY crap. Thanks in advance. (20:12 MT)

David Bowie....please convince him to come to Roskilde. I would gladly pay more for my ticket to hear one of the real legends. (21:17 AT)

The opening response by the "S" launches a chain reaction of dramatizing comments (Bormann, 1983, p. 73), rich in imaginative language, including allegory ("come-together mekka"), slang ("less crap"), double entendre ("we need even worse bands"), and analogy (referring to Tivoli, a historical

amusement park in Copenhagen). Some days later, another symbolic explosion takes place chaining further on the same theme and highlighting a clear disagreement in the fan community:

How about putting the energy produced by dancing festival guests into good use [link to website]. Join the co-creation of Audience Energy! (11:13 Roskilde Festival)

Use the money on some music instead :-). (12:29 MBR)

More rock n' roll, less Greenpeace bullshit. I'm sick and tired of all that stuff. It is not rock n' roll. (12:53 FBF)

These excerpts show different fantasy themes emerging, highlighting contested notions about the *raison d'être* of the Festival. The discussion starts with the reiteration and re-enchantment of the inherited rhetorical vision of a solidaristic and sustainable event (by actualizing it through the cues of organic beer, concerns about the future, charity event, putting dance energy to good use), which is directly disapproved of by a cheeky fan. In his view, pro-environmental activities are developed at the expense of the musical program, even though the festival claims that there is no irreconcilable conflict between the two:

Rock n' roll doesn't mean being reckless with the environment. (13:28 Roskilde Festival)

That is PRECISELY what it means. But seriously, it could be nice if RF concentrated more on the people who pay 1800 Kr to go to the festival instead of anything else. I just don't like the fact that Roskilde Festival has become a "Greenpeace Festival" and that everywhere you go you see almost religious signs and messages telling you what is right and wrong. The whole is getting on my nerves, because I see it getting more and more every year and the music is getting worse and worse. (13:39 FBF)

In this particular fantasy chain, "Greenpeace" is symbolically reassigned from meaning rebellious environmental activism practiced by a minority group to signifying actual governmental priorities on sustainable development. Hence, the discussion reflects a contemporary debate in Danish society where green is mainstreamed by the political majority. In contrast to egalitarian group dynamics of rhetorical communities suggested by Bormann (1985), the unfolding dialogue on the virtual forum is not devoid

of power negotiations. The fantasy chaining process is abruptly closed by an anonymous member of the festival communication team: "Perhaps you should find another festival to go if that's how you feel" (13:54 Roskilde Festival).

By using the corporate signature of Roskilde Festival rather than his/her own profile, this person gave additional weight to an arbitrary comment penalizing a rank-and-file member. Instead of letting the majority decide upon the boundaries of the rhetorical community and legitimate fantasy themes to be discussed, the representative of the wall owner takes the freedom to single-handedly "exclude" FBF. Within a few minutes, another fan is taking sides, approving of the new elitist line of the festival management:

The last festival newsletter this year talked about that RF isn't for everyone. They want creative people who care and not just drunk, "use and throwaway" people. I like Roskilde as it is and willing to pay almost 2000 DKK to get a festival who cares about the future of the world and the problems we will face. (14:09 DA)

Explicit statements of appropriate and less desired attendee behavior (not being reckless about the environment, not for "use and throwaway") are interpreted as a sign of orthodoxy, underscored by moral and religious metaphors (telling people what is right and wrong, "get-together mekka"). As the rhetorical vision is fixed into black-and-white value statements, the symbolic coalition begins to disintegrate: there are dedicated, fiercely protective fans, telling off others with an alternative vision. Paradoxically, the counter-rhetoric is also justified by a nostalgic interpretation of Roskilde Festival's cultural heritage (legendary rock music with related negative and provocative attitudes). The fissure within the symbolic community becomes articulated through a trade-off between musical quality and charity:

Lower the donation of money to humanitarian organizations and up the budget for bands this year. The 2011 budget was definitely weighed more on donations than on bands. And personally, I come for the music. (14 July, 17:53 MBR)

However, as argued above, the claimed trade-off between music versus charity or music versus environmentalism points to a deeper issue, which may indicate a mid-life identity crisis for the festival. The values of the 1970s flower-power generation are being mainstreamed by national political agendas and by the Danish middle-class, hence they have become hegemonic

symbols of the neatly streamlined welfare state. Paradoxically, although the rock festival community often defines itself as rebellious, refusing to comply with the rules, the symbolic community is crumbling from within when some members get into conflict over the very ideology that grounded the festival in the first place. Furthermore, the example also shows that despite the international appeal of Roskilde Festival and the potentially global reach of social media platforms, the symbolic meaning creation processes taking place on this Facebook wall are mainly embedded in a local (Danish) sociocultural context.

This case also illustrates the links between sensemaking processes taking place in the physical and virtual fan community, which bear important implications for practitioners. Community dynamics (convergence and disagreement on the dominant ideology and endorsed values of a festival) existed long before the emergence of social media. The decline and terminus of the rhetorical vision and the disintegration of a fan community may be one of the likely causes behind the collapse of festivals with a long tradition. However, such tribal disputes have been so far concentrated within the temporal confines of the event. The online platform extends the temporal dimensions of tribal co-enactment, allowing fans to exchange consumption knowledge, and socialize and simultaneously allows festival managers to tap into tribal discussions and take the “temperature” of the community. As demonstrated above, the online communication behavior of Roskilde Festival representatives may contribute critically to the sustainment of the symbolic community, which may not only include facilitation of virtual tribal gatherings, but also mediation in membership conflicts.

CONCLUSION

This chapter introduces a theoretical framework grounded in a narrative paradigm to inform studies of tourism social media. It is argued that SCT is appropriate for analyzing the constitution of online communities, owing to its capacity to explain the symbolic roots of group communication. It posits that collective consciousness emerges through a discursive process imbued by figurative language and fantasy themes. Fantasy themes grow into a rhetorical vision, encompassing the *raison d'être* of the symbolic community. Over time, rhetorical visions may become altered, mutated, and obsolete or challenged by alternative counter-visions, which can ultimately lead to the disintegration of the community.

As illustrated above, a similar pattern of sensemaking can be traced by studying communication patterns of online communities. The dialogue excerpts from Roskilde Festival's Facebook wall show that single postings with a dramatizing content trigger equally dramatizing responses and may weave into a fantasy chain. The emotional outbursts of individual fans point to recurring fantasies and socially shared narrations, implying that interactions are rarely about information exchange or targeted advertising messages. Rather, social media augments non-digital tribal practices and ceremonies and redefines the communicative practices of traditional communication channels. Instead of focusing on building dyadic relationships between the individual fans and the festival brand, marketers may now provide the festival tribe with a virtual *agora* with many degrees of freedom.

This virtual agora is characterized by a fluid structure and random interaction patterns. Most postings are autocommunicative (status) messages that are not responded to by the rest of the community. Particularly active, self-acclaimed devotees or insiders are likely to be considered "village tossers" or being collectively ignored, which questions a virtual hierarchy based on posting frequency alone. The wall owner itself (Roskilde Festival) is often subject to critical comments, which is sometimes responded to, sometimes not. However, representatives of the wall owner may use their position to settle debates and arbitrarily expel members from the rhetorical community. By letting fans appropriate the social media platform for a variety of comments, Roskilde delegates the communicative task of enacting and re-enchanting the Orange Feeling. On Facebook, the rhetorical vision is constantly evolving: it is confirmed, questioned, redefined, or reflected upon. In other words, it is *kept alive* by the tribe.

The fragmentation of tribal communications on Facebook also has implications for the conceptualization of a virtual social hierarchy. In contrast to Kozinets and his colleagues' approach, it is suggested here that the social hierarchy of the symbolic agora is indistinct. Anyone can enter a debate and no member can be considered as central over time. Power structures are ephemeral, emerging, and disappearing in fleeting alliances (for instance, when two or more fans endorse a retort with a "like" sign). Similar to a marketplace, convergences and divergences among members are temporal and do not fundamentally evolve into a solid hierarchy.

By bringing insights from consumer tribes and the narrative paradigm into market communications on tourism social media, a whole new array of research avenues lie ahead. There is a need for more empirical research that does not adopt, but problematizes, challenges, and extends SCT in a social media setting. Communications in a virtual community are significantly

different from those of a group meeting face-to-face. It is then plausible that the technological interface may influence the way rhetorical visions arise online. In contrast to Bormann's (1983) fantasy chain model, there is little consistency in the development of fantasy themes into one grand rhetorical vision. Owing to the chaotic and simultaneous character of Web 2.0 communications, sensemaking is partial, rather than hierarchical, and results in multiple collages or snapshots. However, the demarcation between these rhetorical snapshots is not clear-cut, as the contrasted categories are more interdependent than mutually exclusive.

These conditions raise a number of new issues to address. For instance, how do particular characteristics of online communication (simultaneity and lack of co-spatiality) affect coalition patterns in the fan community? How do ideological conflicts and counter-visions emerge and how are they resolved? Is there an asymmetry between posting frequency and tribal positions and how is this addressed by marketers? How and when do "silent" members of the virtual tribe engage in collective meaning creation? These and related questions may contribute with a renewed agenda to tourism social media studies.

Chapter 5

Social Media Sites in Destination Image Formation

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ABSTRACT

Studies about destination image have been discussed extensively in the literature due to its impact on tourist behavior. Despite the significant number of contributions, existing models are outdated in the context of globalization. This chapter synthesizes relevant literature and evaluates the effects of social media on destination image formation. Built on the seminal work by Gartner and that of Tasci and Gartner, the chapter extends the existing understanding with a conceptual model. The construct posits that, with the social media sites as the agent, an overall conative image of a destination can be formed by the overlap of provision and evaluation of cognitive and affective information by and among suppliers, consumers, and third parties.

Keywords: Destination image formation; globalization; social media sites

INTRODUCTION

From a psychological perspective, image refers to the mental representative of meaning, which involves a process of concrete imagery (Paivio, 1969).

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Pictures, as well as words, often arouse the image people develop in their minds. In the field of tourism, literature on destination branding has reached a consensus about the importance of image and its effects on behavior (Echtner & Ritchie, 1991; Gallarza, Saura, & Garcia, 2002; Hunt, 1975; Pearce, 1982; Pike, 2002).

Pike (2002) and Gallarza et al. (2002) have identified specific themes mentioned by various scholars of destination image. Pike (2002) analyzed 142 destination image papers published between 1973 and 2000. Out of 142 papers, only 2 focused on image formation. Gallarza et al. (2002) analyzed 65 works related to theoretical and conceptual approaches to tourism image published in main tourism journals and books between 1971 and 1999. They concluded that, despite many studies conducted in this area, there was no consensus on the process and nature of destination image formation. Their study recognized the work of Gartner (1993) for developing eight image formation agents and that of Baloglu and McCleary (1999) for explaining in detail the static and dynamic natures of destination image formation. These two extensive reviews by Pike (2002) and Gallarza et al. (2002) have served as important sources for the discussion in this chapter, especially in understanding the historical perspective of research in destination image.

Gunn (1972, in Gunn, 1988) pioneered the topic of destination image and initiated the concepts of organic and induced images. The former is formed through tourists' impressions about the destination without physically visiting the location. The impression normally derives from indirect sources not associated with any marketing activities. On the other hand, the latter refers to an image formed through the result of promotional efforts. Advertisements, for instance, are believed to have significant effects on the induced image that tourists have about a particular destination. Gartner synthesized previous studies and proposed that a destination image is "formed by three distinctly different but hierarchically interrelated components: cognitive, affective and conative" (1993, p. 193). In highlighting the importance of understanding the tourist selection process, Baloglu and McCleary (1999) emphasized image as an attitudinal construct that includes cognitive and affective elements. They believed that other than the stimulus factor, destination image is also formed by tourist characteristics or personal factors such as motivation and sociodemographics.

Different types of information sources have varying degrees of effect on cognitive and affective evaluation of a destination, which in turn affects how its image is formed. These information sources also include those brought about by globalization. Munar (2009) suggested that globalization

involves two elements: the expansion of the world market and the use of information and telecommunication technology. The latter, for instance, enables people to communicate with other users from many different locations while changing a vast variety of credible information. Therefore, it increases the flow of information beyond national boundaries and cultures and has changed the life of postmodern society in many aspects. This shift in social life has contributed abundant information from non-commercial sources including electronic word-of-mouth about actual visits to destinations. Hence, information that used to be unidirectional from business-to-customer has changed to customer-to-customer. Further, the emergence of the interactive Web (known as Web 2.0) enables rapid information sharing among users. In her study, Munar (2010a) explained the phenomenon of Web 2.0 and the typologies of these information-sharing platforms. According to her, one of the main elements of Web 2.0 is the online community (social media web sites). These social media web sites consist of the combination of user-generated content with some simple tools and applications. The communities vary in terms of size, membership, and activities involved. There are different types of social media web sites, including content-driven sites, media sharing sites, virtual worlds, blogging sites, social bookmarking and voting sites, and social networking sites.

Many studies have revealed how social media sites are making a tremendous change in modern life. The trends are occurring as a result of globalization, where technological advances act as a medium of information exchange worldwide. Information about destinations, for instance, has become abundant and easy to access through many types of social media sites. As a result, consumers are becoming more active in the search for information. Other than receiving information, they also can use the new platform as a supplier of information. Consequently, the image formation process has become more complex. While Ahmed (1991) claimed that induced image can be changed through strategic promotion and positioning efforts, its role in image formation is now becoming more uncontrollable, when people acquire many forms of information from other sources that can shape cognitive and affective images of destinations. Despite many studies about the wide usage of social media sites, limited research address their effects on the formation of destination image. In addition, the field of information communication technology itself lacks theoretical support for empirical research (Sheldon, 1997, p. 32). This chapter attempts to synthesize the literature and conceptualize a model that can explain and evaluate the effects of social media sites on destination image formation.

IMAGE FORMATION REVISITED

Following the introduction of the organic and induced image concept by Gunn in 1972 (in Gunn, 1988), Hunt (1975) examined the phenomenon of destination image as a developmental factor. Pearce (1982) conducted an empirical study to determine differences between pre- and post-travel images among British tourists who traveled to Morocco and Greece. In 1988, Gunn discussed the process of image formation, which included the accumulation of mental images about a destination, their modification by more information, a decision to take a trip, travel to the destination, participation in travel activities, return home, and modification of images based on experience. Such understanding of image formation was supported by Chon (1991), who agreed that significant destination image modification occurs as a result of a tourist's visit to the destination. Recognizing the implication of image formation on destination selection process, Gartner (1993) identified three components of destination image formation and originated the typology of eight image formation agents. The three components are cognitive, affective, and conative, while the eight agents are Overt Induced I, Overt Induced II, Covert Induced I, Covert Induced II, Autonomous, Unsolicited Organic, Solicited Organic, and Organic.

Echtner and Ritchie (1991) argued that most of the destination image studies prior to the 1990s were weak in conceptualization and measurement. The definition of image itself is often vague and incomplete due to the complex nature of the construct. Image is often described as "impressions of a place" or "perception of an area." Some studies use other terms to explain image, such as destination attractiveness, awareness, perception, attributes, and quality. Such a wide spectrum of perspectives has led to difficulties in developing a comprehensive definition that covers all aspects of the image construct. As Echtner and Ritchie focused on literature prior to 1990, Tasci and Gartner (2007) extended the literature by investigating the conceptualization and operationalization of the destination image construct since 1990, including the shift in focus as well as other related issues. They discovered that most research defined and measured destination image based on a particular set of aspects, showing that the theoretical basis remains insignificant.

Theoretical Framework

The main idea of Gartner's (1993) work focused on the three interrelated components of destination image: cognitive, affective, and conative. While

cognitive concerns the understanding and evaluation of a known product, affective involves motives and feelings an individual has for destination selection. This is often followed by an action component, known as conative. This action typically depends on the images developed during the cognitive stage and the affective evaluation of the destination. Baloglu and McCleary's (1999) empirical study was consistent with and supported Gartner's three-component proposition. In the second phase of Gartner's (1993) framework, he introduced the eight agents that stimulate the three image components, expanded and modified from Gunn's idea of organic and induced image. The key idea of induced image is that most parts of a physical product cannot be changed, but perceptions or images can be manipulated.

The first agent, called "Overt Induced I," is comprised of traditional advertising. Marketers attempt to construct a favorable image in the mind of the targeted audience. The media used for this purpose are highly visual to create emotional appeals. One example of this agent is advertisements on television. Since affective images of a destination could vary across positive and negative dimensions (Baloglu & Brinberg, 1997), positive emotion among potential tourists through advertising is stimulated. The second agent explained by Gartner is "Overt Induced II." This agent involves intermediaries such as travel agents and travel wholesalers who act as gatekeepers of information. Their main function is to create attractive images to their clients. They normally select and portray only favorable images, often unrealistic. Beerli and Martin (2004) recognized the important role of travel agents in influencing induced image compared to other secondary sources, such as brochure-related materials. Though, the levels of interaction involved may vary. Brochure-related materials, for instance, only involve a one-way interaction, information transferred from the materials to potential customers. In contrast, the use of travel agents involves a two-way interaction, whereby customers receive information and have the opportunity to raise questions or concerns. Thus, they believe that two-way interaction is more influential than the unilateral.

The third and fourth agents involve the power of an influential person. For "Covert Induced I," destinations create an agreement with a celebrity to attract the attention of potential customers. One example is Australia's strategy to collaborate with a celebrity such as Paul Hogan (Crocodile Dundee) to promote wildlife tourism to the international market. In addition, in early 2011, Tourism Australia chairman made a public announcement about the partnership between Tourism Australia and a well-known American series, *The Oprah Winfrey Show*, which has the potential to reach audiences in 145 countries. In the agreement, the television program was

required to showcase Australia as a world destination in at least two full episodes during the show's 25th season. Other partners that joined the venture were Qantas Airways, Tourism New South Wales, the Sydney Opera House, Tourism Victoria, Tourism Queensland, R.M. Williams, and Network 10 (Tourism Australia, 2011). Despite the enormous cost, Tourism Australia believed that it was worth the investment, considering the reputation of the program among millions of viewers. "Covert Induced II" utilizes the influence of an individual in the public eye, which includes familiarization tours organized for travel writers. In return, travel writers publish their experience in the destination as a way to promote it. In this case, people are not aware that the writers actually are appointed as promoters for the destination.

The first four agents describe the role of induced image in its total formation process. The next four focus on the influence of organic image. The fifth agent, "Autonomous," consists of independently produced reports, documents, movies, and news articles. These sources are believed to have an impact on cognitive and affective evaluation of a destination. The two categories of Gartner are news and culture. In most cases, these agents are independent and usually out of the immediate control of destination marketers. Tasci and Gartner (2007) viewed these independent sources as semi-dynamic and semi-controllable. Although destinations often have very little control over what appears in the news and culture, they believed that the destination marketers have the ability to adjust and modify their marketing activities depending on the information reflected by these sources. A study by Kim and Richardson (2003), for instance, suggested that a movie could be used as an effective tool to change destination images, due to its ability to affect audiences' interest in visiting a place. The sixth agent, "Unsolicited Organic," consists of unrequested information from various external sources. This information can be gathered through daily conversation with other people. Similar to the previous agent, this information is difficult to control. Although it has the potential to influence other people's intention to travel and the decision-making process, the credibility of the informer is important for the retention level. In contrast to the "Unsolicited Organic" agent, where information comes from unrequested sources, the "Solicited Organic" consists of information from knowledgeable sources, considered more reliable as the information normally originates from those who share a common social class or family life-cycle characteristics with the requestor. The last image formation agent discussed by Gartner is "Organic," sharing a similar source with the seventh agent. This type of information is acquired based on personal experience and sources are often credible.

While the framework by Gartner (1993) focused on the supply-side approach, Tasci and Gartner (2007) added demand-side and independent approaches. In the improved model, they emphasized the two ends of information transmission that involve destination (supplier) and perceiver (demand). The study suggested that a holistic concept of image should include three perspectives that deserve attention: the supply-side approach (projected), the demand-side approach (perceived), and the independent approach (autonomous). Despite the additional perspectives in the model, they still focused on unidirectional information transmission, since the marketing strategies are directed at the consumers and the potential to induce a positive image in their minds. The revised model is shown in Fig. 1. Gartner's (1993) framework and Tasci and Gartner's (2007) improved model provide the groundwork to examine the effects of social media sites on destination image formation. This discourse is necessitated by the dynamic nature of destination image formation and the sociotechnological advances of the past decades.

Effects of Globalization and Social Media Sites

Changes in technology have occurred rapidly in the era of globalization and have had effects on social life (Kozinets, 2008). One of the outcomes is the emergence of various types of social media that have grown tremendously for the past 10 years. This new media, known as Web 2.0, allows people to connect with their networks from many places around the world. The connections include text messages, pictures, and videos posted on the sites. People can easily upload photos and share with their friends and relatives through these social media sites. Presently, there are many types of social media sites used by tourists to fulfill their social needs, including Travelocity, TripAdvisor, Facebook, and Twitter.

Munar (2009) posited that the expansion of the world's market as a result of globalization has substantial effects on tourists' perceptions and feelings toward destinations. Previously, most marketers focused on creating a favorable image in the mind of potential tourists. The information tended to be unidirectional, as described by the first four image formation agents in Gartner's original framework. Even at the time the article was written in 1993, he noted that the credibility of the first four image formation agents range from low to medium, compared to the organic image with higher standing. In looking at the current situation, the vast development of social media sites has brought an even greater challenge to the credibility of these agents. The direction of information has changed significantly. The

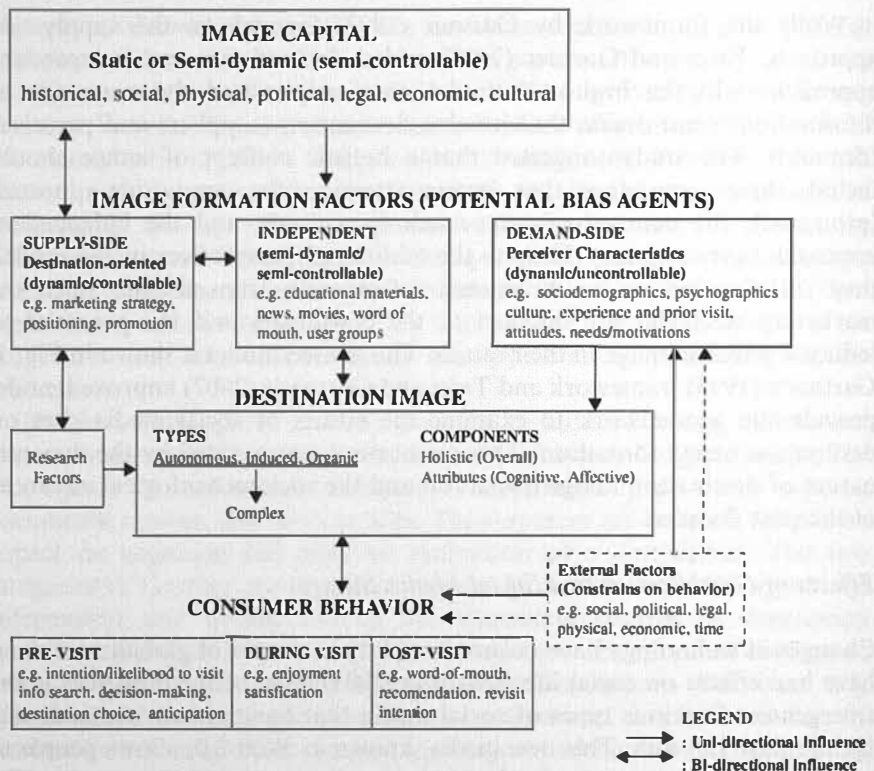


Figure 1. A Model of Destination Image and its Relationships
 Source: Tasci and Gartner (2007), reprinted with permission

effectiveness of the four agents that used to stimulate travel is consequently challenged by the information from social media sites. People tend to search for more reliable sources that are not necessarily associated with business. Such is the turning point where the strength of organic image seems to outweigh induced image.

With the development of social media, social network sites appear as one of the typologies of the system, showing a tremendous growth. Twitter, for instance, claimed over 75 million user accounts at the end of 2009 (ePractice Media, 2010). Facebook has more than 500 million active users to date, with the average user having 130 friends. These people spend over 700 billion minutes per month on Facebook and upload about 500 million photos to the site each month (Facebook Press Room, 2011). More than 5 billion pieces

of content are included on Web links, news stories, blog posts, notes, photo albums, and much more shared among users each week (ePractice Media, 2010).

The widespread use of social media sites raises issues related to social influence in the global market. Bronner and de Hoog (2011) used the term "e-fluential" to refer to people who post information on a review site. In most cases, peers, as influential groups, tend to affect the attitude and behavior of other individuals (Currie, Wesley, & Sutherland, 2008). The pictures and messages posted on social media sites about past tourism experiences are believed to have influence on destination image and choice. The same study by Currie et al. (2008) revealed the influence of proximal relationships on destination choice. It determined that stories about vacation experiences have a significant influence on peers' travel choice, especially among students. The influences include planning for a trip to the same or to a different destination. Most females stated that they were curious and excited about the stories of the destination. For males, jealousy became a stimulus to travel. The studies by Lam and Hsu (2006) and Currie et al. (2008) strengthened this contention by emphasizing the importance of reference groups in influencing travel behavior intention. Since the users of social media sites often communicate with their existing network regularly, they can be regarded as a reference group by their network. The reference group on the social media sites is an organic source of information that affects the image formation of a destination.

In addition to personal computers, social media sites can be accessed via mobile phone, creating a new culture among youths and adults. According to a study by Murnan (2006), youths between the ages of 18 and 23 reported a high use of mobile phones, followed by adults between the ages of 30 and 40. Furthermore, the use of smartphones continues to rise among these age categories. As current youth become adults, a new pattern of social life will likely be more common (Kwan, 2007). With the increased use of smartphones, many people can now update their status on their social media sites and upload or download pictures from almost anywhere in the world as well as publish them in real time. This trend may have substantial effects on the perceptions or feelings toward destination brands (Munar, 2009).

In studying tourist behavior, Litvin, Crotts, and Hefner (2004) believed that cultural dimensions such as power distance and the dichotomy of individualism and collectivism have a moderating influence on tourists' external search behaviors and travel patterns. This explains the varying communication preferences across cultures. Ishii (2006) presented an

example of Japanese people with unique personal relations, who are more likely to avoid direct communication with friends. Instead of face-to-face contact, the Japanese prefer to seek information and communicate with their network using mobile phones. Another study, by Jansen, Zhang, Sobel, and Chowdury (2009) examined microblogging (Twitter) as a form of electronic word-of-mouth for sharing opinions concerning brands and noted that social interpretation is often based on personal and subjective perspectives related to one's background, culture, and other factors. Gursoy and Umbreit (2004) also indicated that culture shapes the delivery and interpretation of verbal and nonverbal messages. Therefore, messages on social media sites may have varying effects on destination image formation among viewers, depending on cultural interpretations. A study by White (2010) investigated how people decode and interpret photos and how these images influence viewers' travel decisions. The study affirmed that the interpretation of meaning is influenced by a reader's sociocultural experiences.

Besides these concerns, another issue that rarely receives attention is how macro social and cultural conditions surrounding technology consumption form into ideologies that influence consumers' thoughts, narratives, and actions regarding social media sites. There are few empirical studies that systematically explore and document how technology ideologies affect interpretation and consumption acts. While electronic word-of-mouth involves consumers sharing attitudes, opinions, or reactions about businesses, products, or services with other people (Jansen et al., 2009), the way consumers express their emotions and satisfaction through social media sites has significant effects on brand awareness and its image among viewers. Doh and Hwang (2009) also found effects from various online messages on attitudes toward products and purchase intentions.

Furthermore, the contents and terms used in a social media site itself are subject to cultural interpretation. For example, Facebook uses the term "friends" to refer to the users' networks. Boyd and Ellison (2008) argued that the term is ambiguous and could be misleading. It could be interpreted as close friends, who always communicate with each other, or as ordinary friends who are in seldom (or never) communication. In addressing this complexity, Facebook has designed categories of friends, such as close friends and acquaintances. Users can group them based on their own interpretation. Since some people in the "friend list" are not necessarily so (they could be siblings, parents, or relatives), users can create other categories for these people. There is also a classification called "restricted friends." The purpose is to limit what people in this category can see without having to "unfriend" them. Based on the previous argument on social

influence by Currie et al. (2008) and the influence of sociocultural factors on the interpretation of social media by White (2010), any message or picture posted by an individual could carry different meanings depending on the category of "friends" who posted the message (proximal relationship) and the sociocultural background of the viewer.

Since social media sites are becoming part of daily activities for many people, they affect life in variety of ways. Hedonic elements such as social pleasures and enjoyment may be seen to merely satisfy social needs. However, from the perspective of social psychology, the concept of social influence is relevant as well. According to Hart, Ridley, Taher, Sas, and Dix (2008), curiosity is another element of hedonism in social media sites other than social pleasures and enjoyment. Their study of Facebook has shown that it is common among users to be "nosy" and stalk other friends by checking their status updates, photo albums, applications used, and other aspects of their life. This phenomenon is somewhat related to the concept of "techspressive" by Kozinets (2008). The concept explains how the interaction with technology can lead to technologically mediated pleasure, escape, expression, diversionary, and fleeting. A similar perspective, shared by Munar (2010a), referred to this activity as digital voyeurism. The term explains the pleasures of observing other peoples' private activities without making one's presence known. Consequently, this "nosy" tendency exposes users to different values of individuals. The text messages and pictures people normally post on their personal page represent beliefs and life orientation. This kind of exposure may further lead to social influence as previously discussed by Currie et al. (2008).

Conceptual Model

In an era of networking, many aspects in social life have changed. People are exposed to abundant information in their daily lives, whether they look for the information or the same flows freely to them. In the past, information about destination products reached customers through marketers. However, in this era, almost everyone is able to post destination pictures on social media sites and write reviews about the place, which has an impact on a brand's image and awareness (Jansen et al., 2009). Doh and Hwang (2009) concluded that the direction of electronic word-of-mouth messages (positive or negative) could affect a viewer's response. In the context of globalization, overall technological advance, and social media sites, a conceptual model could be proposed (Fig. 2). This model is built on the framework by Gartner (1993) that focuses on the supply-side of the

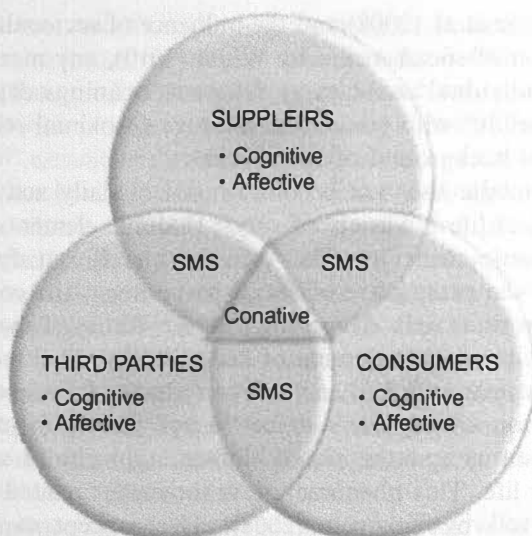


Figure 2. Effects of Social Media Sites on Destination Image Formation

destination image formation and its improved model by Tasci and Gartner (2007), which expanded the model by adding the demand-side and independent approaches.

The conceptual model recognizes the role of social media sites in shaping the three components of destination image: cognitive, affective, and conative. The model posits that social media sites connect suppliers and consumers, suppliers and third parties, and consumers and third parties, and at the same time influence the formation of the three image components through the interaction among suppliers, consumers, and third parties. Suppliers create marketing activities intended to induce positive images to consumers. Gartner (1993) discussed the role of image formation agents in instilling favorable images in consumers' minds. In today's world, an increasing number of suppliers make use of social media sites to convey their messages to consumers. This process involves psychological elements that contain cognitive and affective evaluation of information and reactions by consumers, followed by their actions or inactions, known as conative in Gartner's (1993) term. While destination marketers believe they can control the information provided to consumers, the interpretation of that information is often uncontrollable due to the dynamic nature of consumers and technology. Consumers in the conceptual model exhibit characteristics of

both receivers and senders; their interpretation of suppliers' messages and their reactions influence and invoke responses and reactions by suppliers and third parties. Depending on macro social and cultural conditions surrounding technology consumption (Kozinets, 2008), cognitive and affective evaluation of messages on social media sites is now multidirectional, interactive, dynamic, and fluid. It challenges the validity of the first four agents of destination image formation originated by Gartner, and the concept of induced image in general.

Prior to the introduction of the computer network, consumers had very limited access to product information. They were more passive and relied heavily on traditional media such as television and brochures with unidirectional information (Lueg, 2003). As a result, marketers tended to manipulate human cognitive characteristics by creating favorable images, in addition to the consumers' limited organic images that may form false product beliefs in the supply-side approach. Since technology has changed tremendously, the direction of information has started to shift from business-to-consumer and business-to-intermediaries-to-consumer, to consumer-to-consumer. The destination image is increasingly formed by information gathered from consumers' social media and their daily interaction with other members in their social media sites. During such interaction, consumers play dual roles as users and suppliers of information. The borderless world of information has encouraged consumers to become more active in searching for and providing information to others. Thus, the changing role of consumers leads to more uncontrollable information in the market. The effectiveness of traditional advertising in destination image formation is questioned.

Despite the indirect role of third parties, they have a powerful influence on affective and cognitive evaluation of destinations, leading to the formation of organic image. Organic image represents the existing image an individual has about a particular destination based on two important sources: existing knowledge and his/her previous experience at the destination. The former may be derived from daily activities and interactions with other individuals in person or through social media sites. Text messages and pictures posted by third parties on social media sites make new contributions to the organic image of a destination. Considering the ability of peers to influence travel decisions (Currie et al., 2008), this indirect information by third parties either enhances or dilutes the induced image attempted by destination marketers. In the situation where the individual has no intention to travel, the indirect information may not be perceived as intense. However, in another situation, when the individual has a prior

intention to travel, the message may entice him or her to pursue further information in enhancing the existing knowledge. One can conclude that third parties via social media sites play important roles in influencing both organic and induced image of a destination, explaining the overlaps between suppliers and third parties and consumers and third parties. The intersection where all three types of active components overlap, which is the conative, represents the action component of a destination image using Gartner's term. It marks the point where the overall image of a destination is formed. Therefore, the conceptual model illustrated in Fig. 2 suggests that mutual exclusivity of organic, induced, and autonomous image is practically nonexistent with the presence of social media sites.

CONCLUSION

The seminal work by Gartner (1993) has been influential in destination image literature. The understanding of how destination image is formed has been advanced by many conceptual and empirical contributions since then, including Tasci and Gartner in 2007. In the context of globalization and advances in information technology, particularly the emergence and popularity of social media sites, this chapter proposes a conceptual model of destination image formation that extends the existing understanding of it. The model consists of three intertwined parts that represent suppliers (destinations), consumers (tourists), and third parties, respectively. The model posits that, with the social media sites as the agent, an overall conative image of a destination is formed by the overlap and intersection of provision and evaluation of cognitive and affective information by and among suppliers, consumers, and third parties. Future studies are warranted to further articulate the conceptual relationships outlined in the model and empirically examine such relationships to advance the study of destination image and to assist the tourism industry in fully utilizing social media sites for image building.

Chapter 7

Inspiring Design: Social Media from the Beach

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ABSTRACT

This chapter outlines opportunities for designing place-based or localized social media services and technologies for tourist settings. Following an exploration of how ephemeral, collaborative social networks emerge, consideration is given to understanding tourist places in terms of networking and socialization. In the field of information technology design, there are many examples of experimental mobile, location-based services that provide informational overplays for tourism sites and generally seem to merely replicate the functions of guidebooks or online information services. However, viewing the performance of tourism through a lens that emphasizes place-making as a social practice could inspire the innovation and design of new mobile social technologies to enrich tourist places and interactions.

Keywords: Tourism; design; place; fieldstudy

INTRODUCTION

There is a growing realization that tourist sites are inherently social (Pearce, 2005). There are places constructed as much from social relations, as from

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the material performances afforded by the destination's topography. This should prompt a turn to the social as an important source of inspiration for the design of technologies and services that enable and stimulate new forms of interaction. Yet, much of the current design of digital technologies and services to support tourism remains centered on the production for and passive consumption of information by tourists. In this chapter a number of design sensibilities are proposed that might inform and inspire the design of innovative *in situ* tourist social media: mobile, social, and locative technologies designed to enhance onsite experiences. The chapter considers how digital technologies designed *for* places might be constructed in a manner sensitive to the social relations and interactions that are so crucial to the performance and experiential context of tourism.

Much contemporary design of mobile digital technologies intended for tourists (such as mobile information systems, mobile guides, or social media applications running on mobile devices) rests on a tacit assumption that tourism practices are predominantly guided sightseeing activities that require timely information procurement to be satisfying and rich (Benckendorff, Moscardo, & Murphy, 2005). Information technology design for tourists typically draws on a particular trope of tourism which supposedly is driven by an urge to "master space," a notion that privileges an organizing (and orderly) gaze (Hollinshead, 1999; Urry, 1990). An alternative view holds that tourism is considerably more complex and diverse than sightseeing or similar canonical practices (Selstad, 2007). The argument pursued in this chapter is that such reconceptualizations of the domain can be fruitfully employed in tourist technology design efforts. In his seminal work on design thinking, Buchanan (1992) describes placements as the repositioning of a design problem, shifting the underlying hypothesis about the nature of the problem a design solves. Since practical design interventions typically adhere to a (conscious or unconscious) set of ideas about the nature and category of the problems to be solved and the solution to be provided, such a reframing of the problem space can fuel innovation efforts. Here it is argued that, rather than accepting the tourist-as-sightseer, the tourist-as-networker and *place-maker* can be valuable labels for informing design work that focuses on social and location-based mobile tourist technologies.

The point of departure for arguments advanced in this chapter is that place making is central to being a tourist. Together tourists themselves *create* places through numerous and varied pretravel and onsite activities. Acknowledgment of this notion of performativity leads to a rejection of perceptions of tourist locations as strategically manufactured, static "sites" implicit in typical designs for mobile and location-based technologies.

Instead, tourist places should be seen as the product of the tourists' performances, performances that are replete with dialogical meaning making, appropriation, and transformational interactions. Further, while the furniture of a place works to afford certain performances—as do previous experiences, place-images, the assumptions that tourists carry with them from home, and perhaps a particular sociability that is part and parcel of being removed from one's mundane location, to say nothing of later reflections—tourist places are inherently ambiguous and open ended (Craik, 1997). Their situated construction, as experiential loci or sensibilities, might thus be considered foundational when designing for tourist socialities through technology.

Empirical work to support such designerly sensibilities should aim to elicit the diversity and richness in tourists' interaction with, and participation in, local material, social, and cultural topologies by being attendant to the indexical, contextual, social, and ultimately place-based nature of tourist performances (McCarthy, Wright, Wallace, & Dearden, 2006). Drawing on participant observations on Magnetic Island (North Queensland, Australia), this chapter supports a very literal network "placement" to inform future design of innovative, digital mobile, social, and location-based tourist technologies. Analysis of such observations provides a vehicle for read-dressing and reimagining tourists as networkers and thus offers a basis for using what (some) tourists do to influence design. Specifically, a tourist-tourist encounter at a beach, viewed through the lens of a networking placement, is used as a springboard to formulate five sensibilities that might shape an appropriate design space.

The empirical research carried out was framed as design ethnography (Salvador, Bell, & Anderson, 1999), aimed at inspiring and informing design work and methodology within the area of tourism social media innovation. Egocentric point of view (egoPOV) video data was collected using a form of visual ethnography (Bødker & Browning, 2012; Browning, Benckendorff, & Bidwell, 2009). The video was recorded on small cameras attached to participating tourists' hats. This was enhanced by "accompanied tourism," a variant on "accompanied shopping" traditionally used in retail experience ethnographies (Healy, Beverland, Oppewal, & Sands, 2007). From a methodological perspective, the egoPOV video and analysis method is discussed in relation to the conceptual and technology design-oriented work. The method employed shows how collection and analysis of the egoPOV data produces artifacts that can be used to shape the design of social and locative information technologies in keeping with the networker model.

SOCIAL MEDIA FROM THE BEACH

The Internet, the World Wide Web, and the current offspring of the many social media platforms that support cross-geographical collaboration and virtual communities (Rheingold, 1993) have been seen as technologies that facilitate new and hitherto unattainable kinds of community. Similarly, the increasing access to ubiquitous mobile devices (Weiser, 1991), such as smartphones (Barkhuus & Polichar, 2010), tablets, and location-specific networking services (Lane, 2003), have the potential to change the ways in which people interact with local topologies and resources. These new possibilities seem to urge researchers, designers, and practitioners to ask how, why, when, and where tourists might make use of opportunities to interact locally, using mobile social media platforms, in addition to their interactions with friends and family that tend to be distributed over geographical distance. A further relevant question is what effect this would have for the practices in and experiences of place (Dourish, Anderson, & Nafus, 2007; Wellman & Haythornthwaite, 2002).

A prominent notion in the social media discourse is that the Internet is increasingly becoming a "platform for participation" as opposed to a static presentation space for so-called "brochure-ware," static web sites that, so the canonical story goes, feature little more than logos, corporate information, and images. Research on social media technologies has focused extensively on participation in the form of user- or customer-generated content and the patent change in power relations between producers and consumers (Cook, 2008). Scholars such as Tapscott and Williams (2007) have popularized the idea of social media as facilitating new models for business in which user participation features as a driver for economic exploitation. Some proponents of social media and tourism research (Wang & Fesenmaier, 2004) emphasize participation through social media as a community-building feature of large travel community memberships (Wang & Fesenmaier, 2004), typically involving people who are widely geographically distributed. Another strand of research discusses the consequences of genre-typical social media for tourists in the form of travel-related web sites such as hotels.com, tripadvisor.com, and various travel blogs. Hotels.com and tripadvisor.com in particular facilitate "crowdsourcing" of user-generated recommendations to help decision making around what to do, where to stay, and what to see. Travel blogs facilitate peer sharing of experiences, as well as connectivity and trust-based virtual communities around destinations (Yoo & Gretzel, 2008), fundamentally changing consumer access to, and engagement with, information about sites and services.

One of the particular and frequently stated values of social media is the opportunity to aggregate and make available past visitors' and locals' insights about destinations (Bronner & de Hoog, 2011; Volo, 2010). Thus, tourists looking for suggestions to aid their decisions on travel are presented not only with the idiosyncratic beliefs of a single stranger or an organization wanting to promote its interests, but also aggregate data collected from a large number of reviewers. Arsall, Woosnam, Baldwin, and Backman's (2010) discussion of the perceived usefulness of such aggregated contributions provides an informative example of this research strand. Their study found that travel blogs and traveler online communities are highly influential resources for the pretrip stages of travel planning (and to some degree for maintenance of connections and community). Their research on how residents' knowledge of a destination is used by tourists focuses almost exclusively on residents and locals as information sources for tourists in the pretrip planning phase.

There is a tendency in commercially available mobile social media apps and services to give relatively high priority to features that are place-related and, in various ways, sensitive to geographical location. Place-related social media are seen as digital platforms for collaboration and participation explicitly concerned with consumers being colocated rather than being geographically dispersed. Along with the increasing accessibility of high-bandwidth mobile data infrastructures, a range of smartphone apps that support smaller community-based and localized knowledge sharing have emerged. In 2011, alongside high-profile location-based media platforms (such as Facebook Places, Gowalla, and Foursquare), mobile applications (LOCQL, Localmind.com, Yahoo!Local, Google Places, and Aloqa) are some of the contestants involved in providing knowledge relevant to geographical locations, often those with considerable opportunities for social interaction, and making it useful and searchable on a mobile platform when users or customers are on location.

Although the technological potential and social incentives seem clear, the commercial interest in location-based social media, however, has yet to demonstrate a comprehensive engagement with tourism as a complex and multifaceted concept. Such an understanding is vital to understand how to respond technologically to tourist locations becoming increasingly eligible for local, here-and-now interactions through the increasing mobilization of computers and data infrastructures. Both this type of research and the commercial application of it have many interesting opportunities to involve tourists and locals alike in the provision of content. This extension can and should be grounded in more direct access to the experience of the practice of tourism, if its potential is to be more deeply explored.

Though this chapter draws on the sociotechnical sensibilities essential to the general understanding of social media, a type of technological media that can enhance and extend collaborative efforts, it is further suggested that the social in tourism can be usefully understood as small-scale, intimate interactions. It is accepted that increasingly mobile media devices provide a plausible medium for facilitating and extending such interactions. To this end, issues of network size, critical mass, and other firmly established interest areas within social media, such as the tendency to focus on the centrifugal powers of social media, are excluded in the current study. Further, mainstream lines of inquiry inspired by Tapscott and Williams' (2007) suggestion of social software as "platforms for participation" and their ability to foster radically different business opportunities that also signify larger cultural and economic shifts (2007, p. 183) are not considered in the present chapter.

In contrast to research based on social media as user- or customer-aggregated information sources, this chapter draws on a study of fine-grained aspects of participation as it takes place within the local social context of a typical tourist location, a beach, with a view to eliciting interpretations of social interactions that might inspire designs of place-related social media. It shows how appropriate technological responses to the new mobility of digital tools and the ubiquity of data infrastructures can be based on engaging with tourists and their activities in place, taking inspiration from a profoundly situated understanding of human social behavior to inspire the design of IT.

Design Sensibilities

One of the original aims of introducing ethnographic practices into information technology research was to make findings from the domain of the practice to be engaged with available for technical interventions. This has often consigned much ethnographic work in design to requirements gathering, a tool for prescribing "what should be done" in terms of designing for the domain in question or for providing a simple bridge across the gap between social worlds and technical worlds. This instrumental view of ethnography in design has been criticized by Dourish (2006), who argues that the analytical commitment in ethnographic work is lost when the sole output is simple implications for technical work, since this entails an insistence on solving discrete, observable sociotechnical problems rather than more broadly understanding how actors participate in a particular system of practice and what new perspectives and new ways of thinking might be helpful in understanding the practice under scrutiny.

The fine-grained engagement with tourists covered in this chapter affords the grounding of sensibilities in the interaction under study (McCarthy, Wright, & Dearden, 2006), with a view to using such grounded sensibilities to support or inspire the design of social and experiential aspects of tourist technologies. So what is meant by design sensibilities and how are sensibilities related to design? Design sensibilities should be understood as tools that

underpin an empathic design process...[stress] sensual and emotional aspects of the relationship between designer, user, and artifact. Sensibilities are embodied in people as ways of knowing, seeing, and acting. They are not external representations or rules to follow blindly. (Wright & McCarthy, 2008, p. 10)

For this case study, the sensibilities are grounded in what Button calls "scenic field work" (2000), fieldwork that is descriptive rather than analytic of the domain under scrutiny, but derive from a particular theoretic position and a reflexive engagement with the process of walking within a "touristic" world, what it means to be a tourist, and what is at stake in the form of touristic sociality performed in the case.

In this sense, design sensibilities are not presented as "implications for design," at least not in the sense that they are traditionally reported in corporate ethnographies or in the academic research on human-computer interaction (Dourish, 2006). Nor are they "principles or guidelines for designing enchanting experiences (Sengers, Boehner, Mateas, & Gay, 2008), [since such] traditional approaches seem too formulaic and too removed from the particulars of felt life" (Wright, Wallace, & McCarthy, 2008, p. 10). In focusing on design sensibilities, according to the latter study, the emphasis is on a particular perspective of design practice which argues that successful designs (from practical, social, political, or cultural perspectives) hinge on empathy. Empathy, in this case, is meant to connote the ability of a designer to transcend one's personal experience to engage in the other as an object of concern. In other words, empathy is a specific kind of knowledge of and care for "the other," who, in Information technology design, is most often referred to as the user. Design sensibility, as the term suggests, aims to sensitize designers toward experiential qualities that might underpin an emergent design space. Rather than outlining scenic findings, artifacts yielded that can be used to open up a design space to intuitive, empathetic, and creative processes.

The practical approach outlined in this chapter is two tiered. First, since the argument that inspiring design for social technologies in tourist places requires sensibilities acquired through exploration and interpretation of tourist social interaction, a case of a tourist–tourist encounter is used to exemplify the networking and place making performed in and through a tourist place. However, environments such as those engendered by tourist networking and place making are fragile, itinerant, and dynamic and thus pose numerous practical and methodological challenges. In order to provoke the desired design sensibilities, designers of social media technologies (that facilitate and enrich tourist socialities and place making) require a set of low-impact and actionable methods to understand when, where, and how often very mobile tourists interact by using social networking in order to support their particular needs, wishes, and sensibilities. The second tier suggests and outlines a method of gathering data to support design in tourist environments in which mobile social media are typically used.

Mobile and Location-Based Media for Tourists

Often explored within proof-of-concept frameworks, research has focused on validation and evaluation of mobile information systems prototypes for different kinds of tourism (Park, Nam, & Shi, 2006). Inspired by the seminal Cyberguide project (Abowd et al., 1997) and the GUIDE project (Davies, Mitchell, & Cheverst, 1998), a project that utilized mobile computers in a variety of settings to design localized and context-sensitive information systems functioning as guides or visitor resources, several projects have focused on mobile information systems and guides for tourism. The mobiDENK project (Krosche, Baldzer, & Boll, 2004) shows how historical monuments, an archetypical feature of a tourist site, can be embedded with smartphone-accessible information, thus enriching the informational environment of a site. Technology acceptance research, assessment of end-user acceptability, and the adoption potential of digital technologies for tourists are also strongly represented in the tourism technology literature (Evjemo, Akselsen, & Schürmann, 2007; Schmidt-Belz, Laamanen, Poslad, & Zipf, 2003). Benkendorff et al. have researched tourist attitudes to the inclusion of digital technologies in the tourist experience itself to suggest drivers and moderators of technology acceptance (2005, 2006).

The work of Brown and Chalmers (2003), Tussyadiah and Fesenmaier (2008), and Axup, Viller, MacColl, and Cooper (2006) constitute three notable exceptions to the predominant focus on information and guide technologies, purely technical issues, and technology acceptance challenges

in a tourism context. Brown and Chalmers use an ethnographic study to draw out implications for designing mobile technologies for tourists. Tussyadiah and Fesenmaier use “netnography” to analyze and understand spatial patterns of the tourist experience. Both studies emphasize the need to approach tourism as a practice that takes place in the interaction with a particular setting. Brown and Chalmers focus on the improvised and collaborative problem solving in which tourists typically engage when at a destination, typically problems associated with planning and navigating while onsite. Tussyadiah and Fesenmaier examine what they tentatively call the “tourist experience.” Both studies emphasize how tourist experiences and practices are mediated or brokered by mobile technologies, and point toward implications for design. In a somewhat similar fashion, Axup et al. propose low fidelity prototyping interventions to explore social practices among backpacker tourists. Focusing particularly on mobile devices, Axup et al. investigate how ubiquitous computing service prototypes that offer matchmaking and information sharing for tourists can reveal the problem-space of tourist socializing practices to ultimately inform design.

Excluding such different approaches mentioned above, location-sensitive and location-dependent technologies in tourism are often designed around an incomplete notion of the tourist as a knowledge-deprived actor who needs timely and relevant provision of information to make order and sense of her or his surroundings (Bødker & Browning, 2012). Tourists are cast as informational detectives, using mobile technology to stitch together a meaningful story about a location. As an alternative to this, it is proposed that, in the age of ubiquitous and mobile computing technologies capable of facilitating co-localized collaboration and community, supporting a wider set of design objectives grounded in tourist performances, in the very experience of being a tourist, would be refreshing, stimulating, and valuable.

The EgoPOV Method

As Scarles notes, visual methods in tourism studies can be a “potential route to accessing the embodied, sensual and emotional experiences of tourists’ encounters with place” (Scarles, 2010, p. 1). Sharing the pace and rhythm of walking with tourists, creates a space for a certain closeness and bonding not attainable by typical (usually sedentary) interviews with participants (Lee & Ingold, 2006; Pink, 2009). For this research project, a series of field studies to explore tourists’ interaction with local topologies, including the social environment, were conducted. The field studies provided inputs for a

design ethnography intended to widen the design space for place-based and social technologies. EgoPOV (egocentric point of view) videos (collected from hat-mounted cameras) for gathering data and accompanying tourists on their walks were used to generate rich and relevant contextual data on the performance of tourism. The collection of data and the subsequent grounded theory-based analysis process is treated as a technological site of interaction in and of itself. Generating inspirational artifacts becomes a process of repeated interactions with the recordings and field notes collected onsite (Browning, Bidwell, Hardy, & Standley, 2008). This process yields artifacts grounded in the original activity, which can then be used to shape a design space. Compared to simplistic notions of the tourist-as-flâneur or tourist-as-sightseer, this method of shaping better aligns the design space with the notion of tourist-as-networker and tourist-as-place-maker.

The strength of the egoPOV approach lies in the way it provides a relatively unobtrusive means of capturing situations, interactions, and orientations. Mounted on the underside of the peak of a cap, the unobtrusive and lightweight camera quickly disappears from view, being absorbed into the garment, and does not hinder head movement or interactions. EgoPOV video is relatively undirected compared to other video methods. The researcher can accompany the tourist and does not have to aim a camera at the participants. By being grounded in the shared process of walking, the method also serves to produce useful artifacts for contextualizing and understanding the sensory and embodied environment of the participants (Browning et al., 2008).

An example of this involvement in the sensory world of the participants can be seen in a case where one of the authors is walking along the beach with Christiane and Paula, a young Danish and German tourist couple, on Magnetic Island. They are walking with their feet in the shallow water, Christiane wearing the hat with the camera on this hot, calm, and intensely sunny day. The participant researcher is conducting a think aloud and, as the respondents are quiet, feels the need to prompt the participants:

Researcher: Ah, ...could you talk a little about, about what you are thinking about?

Christiane: Yes, we...I actually don't think that much right now (Laughs). Just enjoying.

Researcher: So, when you are thinking something...

Christiane: ...yes...(walks, looking down at her feet in the water)

[9 seconds elapse]

Christiane: Again, I think it is strange why there isn't [sic] any people on the beach here, when they have these summerhouses...

This example shows how Christiane's immediate embodied interaction with her surroundings, her feet in the shallow water and the hot sand (which she later mentions) is disturbed by the researcher's prompt for "thoughts" or some representation of what she is experiencing. Quite a substantial interval elapses after the researcher's prompt, and her response seems somewhat unnatural and strained. Researchers are taught to probe, to ask, to interview, and to engage with quiet respondents to create rapport. However, here, at the beach, at this precise moment, Christiane is simply too immersed, fascinated with her own activity, caught up in the pleasure of simply moving her feet through the water, feeling, enjoying. Reviewing egoPOV sequences facilitates seeing and recalling such moments. It allows the researcher to notice how the participant's attention is engaged, to see that while she strolls down the beach, Christiane's attention is fixed on her feet, walking in a slow, contemplative, and peaceful pace without saying a word. Such interactions with an environment can be very hard to appreciate from, for example, interview data alone, and even from third-person (researcher) video recorded accompanied trips, as the actual posture, kinesthesia and head orientation can be difficult to capture (Browning et al., 2008). Thus, egoPOV lends itself to furnishing an ethnographic intervention with a richer and more embodied and sensory perspective that supports the kinds of sensory ethnographies (Pink, 2009) crucial for understanding and representing experiences.

Magnetic Island. Tourist participants were recruited at a local hostel on Magnetic Island with the cooperation of its operator, who conferred with the researchers before recruitment decisions were made. Magnetic Island is a 52-km² island, 20 minutes by boat from the city of Townsville. The main attractions on the island include the semisecluded swimming beaches and some water sports activities (kayaking, sailing, jet skiing), historical shipwrecks that ring the island, World War II remnants, and koalas and other wildlife to spot on the numerous island walks. The participants, who were either friends/cotravelers or couples, were given a free night's stay at the lodge and access to a 4 × 4 vehicle as an incentive. They had the freedom to choose to visit one or more locations that invited some interaction or

pleasurable traversing (e.g., beaches, forest areas, villages) during an approximately 4–5 hour trip. The researcher, who accompanied the tourists, engaged in casual conversation to create and retain rapport as well as to facilitate “thinking aloud” while moving around in the landscape. During the visit, one of the tourist participants wore a small camera mounted on the hat, while the researcher carried a standard handheld video camera and an audio recorder.

“Coconut” Beach. On this occasion, a young French couple in their mid-20s (Guy and Isa) and the researcher traveled by 4 × 4 vehicle down a winding gravel road toward one of Magnetic Island’s southern beaches. The researcher struggled with a notepad, an audio recorder, and a small video camera in the back seat of the car as the young French chauffeur parked in an overgrown parking lot. After getting out of the car, the car key-fob camera was mounted on Guy’s hat. Guy’s English is something of a parody: the “h” is not pronounced, so that the oft-talked-about weather in North Queensland was described as “ot,” as in, “It was ‘ot yesterday.” (In the following conversations, some francophone mannerisms are maintained, but edited so as to be readable.) The group walked down a narrow, overgrown path toward the beach, semienclosed by cliffs, while conversing. The foreshore has mixed vegetation, prominently featuring tall, swept coconut palms. Fig. 1 shows the beach area and the surroundings of what came to be called “Coconut Beach.”

Upon arrival at the beach, Guy first noticed a van. They quickly notice another couple, possibly also tourists, whom they identify as the owners of the van, and begin fantasizing about life on the beach. He promptly stated, “Oh, I am jealous,” and a little later, “[h]ow did they get the van [h]ere?” Guy and Isa were clearly attracted to the idea of the “traveler-style” van. They commented on the beauty of the place, noting the water and the bounding rocks that make the place look like something out of a tourism brochure. Fig. 2 shows the foreshore and the typical access way to the beach. An abandoned metal chair also prompted several comments that related to a fantasy of living or making a temporary home on the beach. Guy for instance, said, looking at the chair, “You see the chair? You sit, take your coffee...no one ‘ere’.”

Guy and Isa soon began to pay attention to the van owners’ efforts trying to catch a coconut with string and a piece of wood. The head-mounted camera showed Guy looking back toward the other couple several times. Isa unsuccessfully tried climbing a smaller palm tree, approximately



Figure 1. The Florence Bay Area on Magnetic Island (© 2011 Google/Tele Atlas)



Figure 2. First View of the Beach and the Other Tourists.

30 meters from the other couple, while Guy threw a stick to get a coconut from the same tree. At some point, he overthrew the stick and just missed hitting the van. The other couple (referred to by the researchers as Bob and Alice, who appear to be an Australian couple in their late 20s) promptly moved the car 10 meters back from Guy and Isa's tree. Guy moved gradually closer to the other couple, while looking up toward the coconuts they wanted to harvest. The other couple had clearly noticed Guy and Isa now, and they laughed a bit at their own efforts to get the coconut from the tree. Guy then went back to the other tree, and tried more vigorously to dislodge a coconut. He then again returned to the area occupied by the other couple who had now progressed in their effort. Referring to the coconut, Bob said:

"S' coming."

Guy: "Ah, it's very hard."

Bob: "Yeah, it's strong."

A coconut falls from the tree.

Isa: "Yay!"

Bob, (smiling, shrugs): "Only took two hours but..."

Guy and Isa laugh, Guy: "Two hours for one coconut..."

Bob: "Yeah, it's more energy than you get from it."

Isa: "And... you drink it, after?"

Bob: "Yeah, it tastes alright."

Guy: "It's good?"

Bob: "Not good enough for the work, but..." [Shrugs]

Now Alice, Bob's partner, takes a knife from the van and starts stabbing at the end of the coconut. She walks towards Isa and Guy.

Guy: "It's not too 'ard to open the coconut."

Alice walks towards Guy and Isa and places the coconut on the ground, picks it up and continues to knife it.

Isa: "You want some help, maybe Guy can try."

Alice: "Yeah, you can give it a try if you want..."



Figure 3. Success!

Fig. 3, Bob shows the result of the struggle to Guy and Isa—a freshly caught coconut.

The couples took turns trying to pry open the coconut, and after a few futile attempts, the conversation turned toward accommodation. Isa asked whether they stayed on the beach (in the van), but, as it happened, both couples stayed at the same hostel. As Bob and Alice prepared to depart, Guy said:

Guy: Oh, maybe we come back tomorrow [looks up at the palm tree], we have to think of a new technique, to get the coconut... [Bob and Alice laugh] ...ok, [Guy turns], maybe see you tomorrow.

Alice: Yeah, maybe

Guy: In the same place...

Alice: Have a good afternoon

Guy: Enjoy! [Laughter]

Guy and Isa decided to leave and started to walk away from the beach. Guy explains how “these are the best moments.” As they walked, they talked

about how great it is that suddenly, on a secluded beach, you could find yourself engaged in a kind of meaningless situation:

Isa: What did you do today, "Oh, we tried to take a coconut"...(laughs) but it is good to say that, you know...

Guy: I think, if we come here with some picnic, we can try *all* the day to take one coconut.

The whole sequence at the beach lasted approximately 16 minutes.

Study Analysis

The Coconut Beach instance was chosen as it provided numerous design sensibilities, some of which are reported here. The particular success of this encounter, in terms of the yield of inspirational insights, is perhaps due to the particularly good rapport developed with the participants, that led to engaging and rich interactions between both the researcher and the participants and the between the participants and the other couple on the beach. Although the sequence could be seen as being initiated by the researcher's presence and a possible tacit expectation of having something extraordinary happen during the walk on the beach, the interaction in and of itself does not seem "unusual" or strange in a tourist setting. Even when encumbered with the trappings of a research agenda, tourists go about their business of being tourists, of making place, and connecting with various sociomaterial networks.

Strathern (1996) notes that the network is "an apt image for describing the way one can link or enumerate disparate entities without making assumptions about level or hierarchy" (Strathern quoted in Burrell, 2009, p. 189). Through the lens of the network, the aim of the analysis was to identify and describe how disparate entities are enrolled into the performance on the beach. The interaction took place in a relatively bounded space (a beach and the foreshore). It is, of course, acknowledged that tourist networks extend way beyond the immediate experience and activity. However, since the objective here is to inspire designs of mobile and locative social media, providing an account of the immediate network of interaction, as a property that reflectively structures and shapes interactions, is useful. It is this interaction that plays a considerable role in Coconut Beach's evolution into a place.

The Coconut Beach case has some similarity with White and White's (2008) description of tourist–tourist social interactions at a campground in

the Australian outback. Both entailed “the possibility of sociability that was bounded, transitory, nonintimate, brief, and focused on functional issues, rather than engendering relationships requiring maintenance and nurturing” (White & White, 2008, p. 46). At Coconut Beach, the place making is not performed around a pre-given unit (a family, a group of friends, a group of fellow travelers) but around a transitory “chance encounter” and the incidental collaboration among strangers.

Similar to Bærenholdt, Haldrup, Larsen, and Urry’s (2004) observations of tourists temporarily taming the beachside to make it inhabitable and pleasurable, it is noticeable how Coconut Beach is transformed from its beginnings as a natural, attractive sight to a site of collaboration and performance through a transient network. Guy/Isa and Bob/Alice transformed the beach and foreshore from what is described in tourism brochures as a “natural” space into a performed place, where the social performance, afforded by the furniture of the space, gave rise to a new perspective. Coconut Beach promptly became a social place, a temporary small world wherein the tourists interacted. The coconut palm trees become physical nodes around which collaboration was carried out and fantasies of playfulness invoked. The palm trees were additively transformed from being part of the furniture of the location to practical challenges that required work to overcome. They became temporary *boundary objects* (Star & Griesemer, 1989) that provided flexible bridging between the two groups, allowing them to perform a short-lived, small-world network in the pursuit of their touristic and hedonic interests. Most of the activities during the actual encounter were carried out with references to the palm or the coconut, from which the couples derive a multitude of different meanings. From the beginning of the encounter, as Guy and Isa begin imitating Bob and Alice’s activity, to the final sequence where they cheer and lend a helping hand in opening the coconut, the setting worked as a catalyst for the collaborative activities. This process can be described as a process of domesticating the beach, the practice of making a location one’s own place despite the fact that most tourist places are public and easily accessible (Bærenholdt et al., 2004).

Larsen (2008) quotes Ingold to say that, “Just as the landscape is an array of related features so—by analogy—the taskscape is an array of related activities” (Ingold, 2010, p. 195). Larsen continues,

Taskscape highlights how tourists enact corporally and multi-sensually, routinely and creatively with landscapes. They step into the “landscape picture,” and engage bodily, sensuously,

and expressively with their materiality and “affordances.” And throughout this engagement they *build* landscapes and things, such as sandcastles. (Larsen, 2008, p. 28)

At Coconut Beach, the *i situ* network enabled the change from the beach as a “beautiful vista” to a playful, collaborative activity, as evidenced by the frequent comments during the interaction. The couples built and shared in a fantasy of leisure and agreed on a particular engagement in place, fundamentally unconcerned and free from the involuntary itineraries of the everyday. This is highlighted in Bob’s comment that the effort of getting the coconut from the tree was not really worth it, suggesting that the interaction was not to be taken too seriously. In interacting with the landscape and each other as part of it, the couples were engaged in a sociality founded on their voluntarily entering into a collaborative form of play.

In this setting, the interaction was performed with a particular touristic sensibility, the two parties constantly and jokingly referring to the fact that, for all practical purposes, the work they were doing was irrational and meaningless, devoid of any rational, practical purpose and quite different from their everyday lives. The assumption built up seemed to be that the activity was a form of play that occurred only within the boundaries of the beach and lacked any sort of plan or assumption of an end goal as would typically be required by collaborative work. This was supported by Guy’s reference to the van and to the chair as they came to represent situations of being somehow isolated from the real, everyday world. Yet this interaction is never monolithic but always interspersed, albeit occasionally, by more ordinary tasks. Guy’s statement, “I think, if we come here with some picnic, we can try *all* the day to take one coconut,” indicated that the research itinerary he was committed to, and the fact that time was limited, put some constraints on the activities. This was further demonstrated when, after the encounter, Guy and Isa were asked whether they are hungry. They not only nodded in unison, but Guy mentioned that they had completely forgotten about that. The participants and the researcher visited Horseshoe Bay to get some food. The bodily and mundane fact of hunger had intersected with the more playful activities.

Little verbal accounting seemed to occur during the encounter and no formal introductions were ever made between the tourists and the couple on the beach. Rather than spoken language, body orientation and movement become the primary devices for acquiring and maintaining contact. Guy and Isa seemed to gain initial recognition from Bob and Alice by imitating the “coconut catchers” at a distance, the latter couple laughing and cheering as

they came closer, so as to acknowledge the first couple's presence. Goffman (1967) in his essays on face work and interaction rituals argues that social interchange entails keeping up *face*, that is, a situationally constructed and embodied appearance of self that must be maintained. *Face* rests on social and interactional conventions, and actors in a social interchange work to maintain both their own integrity of *face* as well as the integrity of the others *face*. Bob and Alice's acknowledgement by way of body and verbal interjections such as "whoa" or "yay" as Guy and Isa come closer intimate an openness to extending the social interaction and eventually lead to Guy and Isa being included in their activity. That this is done carefully and nonverbally, rather than by explicit invitation suggests work, was performed to avoid the possibility of a rejection by the other couple.

Video has often been used as a supplemental data-recording tool in qualitative research contexts where human interaction is the main focus (Goldman-Segall, 1989, pp. 118–119). However, video data has a number of limitations, quite apart from the large data sets being awkward to work with (Buur & Soendergaard, 2000). Video cannot be considered as an objective document, and people's interaction cannot be recorded undisturbed. As Pink puts it, "people in a video are always 'people in a video'" (2007, p. 98). Not only is the footage always constructed in some way, it would be unethical to film the activity without the participants knowing. Further, knowledge that designers might be interested in does not necessarily exist as observable, delineable facts. Some of the most pertinent designerly information emerges from interaction with the technology used to capture the data and in the subsequent interaction with the artifacts that are the products of analysis of that data (Browning et al., 2009).

Rather than to contribute to a comprehensive ethnography of tourists' place making, the researchers' concern in this study was to produce a subjective, designerly account aimed at inspiring design. This is never an impartial project, but rather is produced by an iterative process that, in turn, uses and is reflexively informed by the bodily collaboration of the participants and the relationships staged between the researcher and the participants. The key idea is that the video of the participants' traversals is not simply a supplemental recording that helps in the production of weak ethnographic knowledge, something to be transformed into a written account of the interactions at Coconut Beach, but rather a way of providing a site for further interactions around interpretations of the activities depicted in the video representation (Browning et al., 2008). It is this intervention that affords the shaping of a design space, grounded in the interactions that occurred at Coconut Beach. By the researchers repeatedly "revisiting" Coconut Beach in

the video sequences, a number of themes emerged that hinted at particular qualities of the interaction, which helped to open up the design space. Even such a partial analysis of the short sequence on Coconut Beach presented above raises valuable insights for inspiring and informing technical design.

The Tourist-as-Networker

If the intention were traditional ethnographic inquiry, the data collected might be considered sparse and not empirically generalizable, such as would be required if the intention was a broad, ostensibly objective understanding of tourists' behavior. Rather, the experiential data, and, importantly, the products of interaction with it, should be viewed as artifacts for inspiring design interventions, affording the innovation of mobile and *in situ* social media technologies for tourists. Five design sensibilities are highlighted that suggest new points of departure for the design of social media technologies aimed at tourists.

Tourist Sites Are Places. Following Harrison and Dourish (1996), a *place* can be understood as a *space* that is practiced in a particular manner. Tourist locations are not simply transient or nomadic spaces. The gaze does not master them: the distance and difference seemingly afforded by the tourist gaze collapses in the face of the bodily and social performances that engage tourists as active participants in the (re)construction of meaningful and significant places. Thus, designing mobile and *in situ* social media for tourists entails understanding place making as a necessary, dynamic, embodied engagement that draws on networks between the furniture of a space and social activities. In the Coconut Beach case, the people, context, palm trees, coconuts, Bob and Alice's van, and the derelict chair, as well as the playful activity of catching coconuts, constitute some of the central nodes used for place making. The transformation of Coconut Beach, from a beautiful vista, narrated as a fantasy place of leisure, into a place of collaboration and play, demonstrates how tourist performances are inherently unpredictable. Places are unfinished. Meaning, as it relates to place, although necessarily indexical to the location, derives from the situation that evolves during the processual social interaction that takes place. In considering the theme of social media, it follows that innovative technologies, as tools for extending or making possible onsite tourist social interactions, should be designed with a sensibility for their capacity to shape place, and to give rise to particular networks-in-place and situated

performances. Social media, in this sense, are productive of place, rather than merely an informational overlay for the tourist/consumer.

The Tourist in Place. If Urry's notion of the tourist gaze (1990) has been an influential way of understanding how tourism tends to subsume locations under a predominantly visual regime, the metaphor of the tourist-as-networker emphasizes the assemblage of the active tourist body through material, cultural, and social constituents. To be a tourist is to be *in place*, immersed in networks of things, people, information, discourses, and interactions. A sensibility to networked performances by tourists, such as those presented above, spawns a richer repertoire for the early problem-setting stages of design, since it fundamentally questions received notions of tourism as pure leisure, a primarily visual, colonizing endeavour or as a quest for authenticity. For instance, designing and innovating social media could utilize an understanding of tourist practices as the construction of a series of networks that allows for embodied play and provide means to connect to itinerant and brief forms of place making as drivers or motifs in the design process. In terms of the design of social media, the trope of the tourist-as-networker again emphasizes how media are not incidental to, but *productive* of place. Networks gives rise to the creation of new nodes, new constellations of interaction in the social environments performed in place.

The Importance of the Body in Place-based Interaction. Social networks facilitated in and through digital networks are typically seen as tools to transcend colocation and geographical distance. With colocated social networking facilitated by digital media, the body (which has been left rather inconsequential in "virtual" networks) becomes a piece of "consequential equipment," according to Goffman. If the body facilitates "activities that are consequential, problematic, and undertaken for what is felt to be their own sake" (Goffman, 1967, p. 185), the design of colocated social networks needs to be sensitive to the ways in which the body is used appropriately in a locale, and how the (social, communicative) body demarcates and arranges space. In the case of *in situ* tourist social media, observing liminalities and the shifting boundaries between public and private locales affords understanding of how to represent availability and openness to social interaction or the types of social interaction in which users are prepared to be involved. This sensitizes designers to the often tacit signals in embodied interactions, and reminds designers how bodily cues such as proximity, gestures, and other signals might be made available to understand how places are negotiated in the continuum of the private and the public.

Shifting Tempos and Rituals. Associated with the body as a medium for negotiating availability and openness, the intensity of the social interaction on a tourist site fluctuates. In the Coconut Beach example, Guy and Isa walk to-and-fro, not immediately deciding whether to begin a conversation with the other couple. The ritualistic component embodied in the interaction is evident in the way Guy and Isa imitate Bob and Alice, thus suggesting that they find their coconut catching "game" interesting. At times, Guy and Isa's movements back and forth seemed defensive and hesitant, as if preparing for a loss of *face* and potential rejection from the other couple. At other times, their advancements seemed probing and direct, aimed explicitly at establishing contact. The other couple reacts to Guy and Isa's phatic advancements with laughter and interjections, acknowledging their presence and opening themselves to further interaction. This advancement and withdrawal of engagement is characteristic of the mutual recognition and negotiation of interaction (Goffman, 1967) Designing for such encounters requires a sensibility toward the social minutiae that define pleasurable social interactions from confrontational or adverse interactions.

Ephemerality and Memory. The social networks performed in the Coconut Beach example entail no formal introductions and neither party makes any lasting commitments. Formalities or lasting commitments were apparently not prerequisites for the collaboration. Subtle cues to the status of other tourists perhaps became more appropriate when entering into a conversation and collaboration, such as when Guy noticed the van while walking to the beach, and when Isa subsequently fantasized about Bob and Alice staying the night on the beach. These cues, indicating Bob and Alice's status as tourists of a particular kind, worked as prompts for interaction, as Guy and Isa became curious about (and somewhat envious of) the other couple. Even though the encounter was short and uncommitted, Guy and Isa seemed to linger on the subject of the meeting during the walk back to the car. They mentioned the Australian hospitality and what they perceived to be the national laid-back nature. This later brought to mind other stories from their travels around the country. In this way, they linked their recent encounter with Bob and Alice to other experiences of the same kinds of sociability they had experienced during their travels in Australia. This emphasizes the need to understand how, in practice, a design of place-based social media for tourists should begin to mediate the social landscape, how connections formed might require a "phatic," connective, and ongoing component, but also how interactions facilitated by technologies might fade over time or become connected to other ephemeral-yet-memorable interactions.

In sum, the design sensibilities developed from the encounter give rise to new ways of understanding the tourist site as a social place. They suggest new perspectives from which to intervene technologically in tourist experiences. Localized or place-based tourist social media that productively utilize the often concentrated-yet-ephemeral social encounters give rise to opportunities for creating services to enrich travel experiences and to support the temporary sociality and network building that can arise during tourist activities. Shifting the emphasis away from the interpretational situations that mobile tourist technologies have typically been designed to intervene in, such as providing objective information about places or sights or aiding in way-finding, opens up possibilities for designing with a more holistic notion of the tourist experience. It allows designers to address a wider range of concerns in tourism: interpretation, emotional experiences, and the embodied, social, and affective components of being a tourist.

CONCLUSION

The encounter related and analyzed above is a type of experience that can be used to demonstrate a plausible vision of the aesthetics and affective components of a particular kind of tourist experience. Harrison (2001) argues that the aesthetics of tourism experiences are to be discovered in both monumental encounters (of the canonical type), as well as in the mundane things *in situ*, that, despite their everydayness, are pleasingly sensual, such as the smell of the ocean, the feel of the sand between one's toes, the taste of a cold beer, and so on. Relating Porteous' notion of environmental aesthetics, Harrison argues that more often, striking and gratifying aesthetic moments occur in a liminal engagement with place, by being connected as well as disconnected to a place, or by being tentatively and ephemerally connected. In the case related above, these occurred when the couple set off on a potentially (socially) risky encounter, "bumping into" practices where the social and collaborative experiences mattered rather than interpretational work or information work. Their "work," in terms of attention, bodily exertion, and social skills, in facilitating the interaction was not simply a set of problems to be overcome, but part of the hedonic and pleasurable landscape.

This chapter shows how a performative view of tourism can give rise to design sensibilities that transcend the typical (techno-centric) understanding of tourist practices as distanced and informational. The Coconut Beach case

demonstrates how a location can take on a particular kind of meaning through social activities performed there. Attending to this performative notion of tourism will enable designers and developers of place-based social media to look beyond the information-seeking tourist, and to focus on the socializing activities that tourists carry out as they perform the making of meaning *in situ*. Crucially, in meaning making at a particular location, tourists are engaged in constructing or reconstructing their sense of a place that is indexed to a location. They are enriching their understanding of that place by interacting in place in a dialogical and processual manner. This process does not begin or end with their interaction in a specific location. In all probability, it began before they arrived and will almost certainly continue after they leave. But it is their engaged interaction in *place* that puts the meat on the bones.

This chapter has argued that tourist sites are fluid places made up of social, technical, and natural things, and that technological media that facilitate or aid social interactions in place can become means by which places are temporarily and dynamically made by tourists. Seeing the tourist-as-networker provides designers with the opportunity to reconsider tourist practices and enables new ways to think about social technologies and services for tourism. Social media in place need not be solely about aiding the formation of collaborative interpretational situations where technology is used, for example, in an effort to aggregate data and information from large numbers of users. Instead, in this chapter, it is suggested that social media in place might purposefully be built around enabling or enriching situations of place-based sense-making, extending the possibilities for engaging in social performances and play when visiting tourist sites. This requires a turn toward an ontology that foregrounds performative and emergent aspects of being a tourist. Being a tourist or experiencing in a touristic manner requires an effort, and resulting experiences may arise out of seemingly serendipitous encounters and situations. Similarly it requires an engaged and deep engagement in tourists' actual practices of place making in the effort of supplying inspiring research artifacts that can aid designers of place-based social media.

Such an effort might give rise to technologies that, for example, support pleasurable experiences by enabling short-lived and ephemeral connections among tourists, allowing them to get in touch with strangers and thus support the collaborative staging of place (e.g., in purposeful, if somewhat irrational, activities) that make sites pleasurable and memorable. New services and technologies could be part of the appropriation of sites and the relating of places in terms of "our sense of self, our personal history, and our

anticipated future" (McCarthy et al., 2006, p. 126). Although such services support social meetings and networked activities, they might equally augment the reflection on embodied, sensory experiences and narratives of place and bring enriched and even new aspects to the full experience of being a tourist.

Chapter 8

The Virtual Fan(G) Community: Social Media and Pop Culture Tourism

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ABSTRACT

This chapter focuses on the importance of social media for pop culture fans. A web survey for fans of the *Twilight Saga* is implemented, using the concepts of cognitive, affective, and evaluative social identity and personal, product, and situational involvement. The purpose is to examine to what degree social identity and involvement can explain pop culture fans' future intention to travel, make recommendations to others, and use social media. Findings show that pop culture fans use social media to a large extent and that these means are important for making decisions about traveling and event participation. Moreover, the chapter shows that involvement dimensions are more important than social identity dimensions to explain future intention to travel, to recommend to others, and to use social media.

Keywords: Pop culture tourism; virtual community; social identity; involvement

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INTRODUCTION

Pop culture can be defined as a culture liked by many, something other than "fine culture," situated in the context of mass production and consumption, culture by the people for the people, accessible, and commercial (Lindgren, 2005; Strinati, 2004). The term "pop culture tourism" refers to tourism induced by pop culture. The tourists that engage in this type of tourism can be characterized as fans. This form of tourism is becoming increasingly popular (Beeton, 2008). It is highly demand driven (Müller, 2006), and since tourists associate the destination with dramatic events or dramatic characters portrayed in literature, on TV, or in a film (Kim & Richardson, 2003), it tends to create strong emotional ties to the destination visited. Tourists are mainly attracted to the mythology of a destination, not the "real" place (MacCannell, 1999; Selwyn, 1996). Perhaps this is an even more important aspect for pop culture tourists (Connell, 2005) since their motives are far more complex than what the traditional push-pull model suggests (Beeton, 2005).

The majority of published research within the field of pop culture tourism has been focused on film tourism. According to Beeton's (2010) review, scholars have moved from estimating tourist flows (Riley, Baker, & Van Doren, 1998; Riley & Van Doren, 1992; Tooke & Baker, 1996), to exploring tourism motives (Beeton, 2005; Riley & Van Doren, 1992), and management issues and effects on destinations (Beeton, 2005; Mordue, 2001), to postmodern interpretations of the phenomenon. To date, the literature is dominated by case-based research, in which specific destinations and/or films/TV-series have been in focus. One of the most investigated cases is the film series *Lord of the Rings*, shot in New Zealand (Buchmann, 2010; Buchmann, Moore, & Fisher, 2010; Croy, 2010; Jones & Smith, 2005; Tzanelli, 2004). Another popular research case within the field is *Dracula* tourism in Romania (Huebner, 2011; Light, 2007, 2009; Shandley, Hamal, & Tanase, 2006; Tănăsescu, 2006). This research has to a large extent focused on the recreation of a destination's image as a result of a popular book/film character. Furthermore, regional effects of film and TV-series tourism have been documented in a number of studies on the British Isles (Brereton, 2006; Meaney & Robb, 2006; Young & Young, 2008). For example, *Harry Potter* (Iwashita, 2006; Mintel Group, 2003) and *Braveheart* (Scottish Enterprise Forth Valley, 2000) have been under study. Australia is another example where the effects of film tourism have been documented. High-profile cases are Ned Kelly (Frost, 2006) and the Australian outback (Frost, 2009). Hence, research on this form of tourism is not new. However, the explosive

growth of the creative industries of film and TV in recent decades, offering consumers an enormous number of choices and hence fierce competition among businesses, combined with the increased use of Internet and social media making popular culture products more accessible, calls for additional perspectives on research in this field. Fans of pop culture do not exist in isolation. They communicate with each other, facilitated by various Web 2.0 applications, and access new information on the phenomenon in question from the constant flow of updates and sources available on the Internet. The contribution of the research in this chapter is thus to introduce technology mediation into the study of pop culture tourism.

It is by now a widely established fact that consumers' use of social media applications such as Facebook and Twitter reached enormous proportions by the end of the first decade of the 21st century. Also, the number of blogs on the Internet is now counted in the hundreds of millions (Pingdom, 2012; Tumbler, 2012). Social media are very much the essence of Web 2.0 and the applications on the Internet are characteristically customer-centric, user-generated, interactive and dynamic, foster community participation, and build on collective community intelligence (O'Reilly, 2005). Social media have become increasingly important for tourism. PhoCusWright (2010) reported on social media in travel and states that travelers' reviews, photos, trip planning and sharing, and blogging are all influencing how these people connect to and interact with suppliers and products. Results from Xiang and Gretzel (2010) support this view. They found that social media constitute a substantial part in the search engine results of travel searches. PhoCusWright (2010) also noted that there was a 34% increase between 2008 and 2009 in number of visitors per month to social travel websites.

The possibility of using the Internet to diffuse information and share opinions at the "speed of light" is an important factor that influences the proliferation of pop culture phenomena and hence potentially also the development of pop culture tourism. As Guex states, "the Web has become for many a travel companion who gives good advice and has an attentive ear" (2010, p. 426). The study reported on in this chapter investigates whether various forms of social media use are important for pop culture fans in terms of planning and choosing to travel and participate in events. The purpose is to examine to what degree social identity and involvement can explain pop culture fans' future intention to travel, to make recommendations to others, and use social media. The study explains to what extent fans use social media to make travel decisions, and what characterizes these fans in terms of involvement and social identity. These are important factors

both for developing marketing strategies and for destination planning and development.

SOCIAL MEDIA AND POP CULTURE TOURISM

Literature on social media in a tourism context is limited but rapidly increasing. Importantly for marketing management, use of social media has been researched from the perspective of how a destination or a tourism company is portrayed in social media (Jeong & Jang, 2010; Schmallegger & Carson, 2009; Wenger, 2008; Ye, Law, & Gu, 2009; Zhang, Ye, Law, & Li, 2010). Further knowledge is found in the majority of tourism-related research, which is focused on user behavior from various aspects. Research on why consumers use social media can be exemplified by research on triggers of electronic word-of-mouth (Jeong & Jang, 2010), motivations to write online travel reviews (Yoo & Gretzel, 2008), and using online reviews and recommendations (Zhang, Pan, Smith, & Li, 2009). Further, research on satisfaction (Jiang, Mills, & Stepchenkova, 2008), perceived usefulness (Zehrer et al., 2011), consumers' response and source credibility (Xie, Miao, Kuo, & Lee, 2010), and the complementary role of online reviews for holiday decision making (Papathanassis & Knolle, 2010) contribute to understanding the value and impact of social media for tourists. Literature specifically focusing on member participation, involvement, and identification can also be found (Arsal, Baldwin, & Backman, 2009; Casaló, Flavián, & Guinalíu, 2010; Huang et al., 2010; Qu & Lee, 2011; Sanchez-Franco & Rondan-Cataluña, 2010).

Research focusing on participation, involvement, and identification points to a relevant feature of social media: the formation of virtual communities where users share content and communicate. The forming of these social communities seems particularly relevant for pop culture communities due to the often high levels of involvement of users.

Formation of Consumer Tribes and Virtual Communities

Highly involved pop culture consumers are often referred to as fans. It has been suggested that fan tourists to a large extent are motivated by sociocultural and social belongingness needs such as cultural and tribal connections (Chen, 2007; Kim & Chalip, 2004; Smith & Stewart, 2007). From a marketing perspective, Cova and Cova (2002) suggest that citizens

in the 21st century are more interested in social links and the identities that come with them, than in the pure consumption of objects. Cova et al. (2007) argue that these new types of consumers, consumer tribes, are active and enthusiastic in their consumption, sometimes to the extreme, and produce a range of identities, practices, rituals, meanings, and even material culture. Maffesoli (1996) defines a consumer tribe as "A group that is loosely connected, inherently unstable, and is held together essentially through emotion and passion" (Maffesoli cited in Otnes & Maclaran, 2007, p. 52).

Unruh's (1980) concept of the social world can be seen as an early conceptualization of the phenomenon of consumer tribes, noting that common "worldviews" are often created that unite social actors in terms of practices, procedures, and perspectives. Four features of involvement are typical for social worlds: voluntary identification (the entry into and departure from the social world is relatively free, accessible, and occasionally unnoticed); partial involvement (any social actor can only be involved in a portion of the total "goings-on" in any social world); multiple identification (all actors, organizations, events, and practices are probably involved in, or function to support, multiple social worlds); and mediated interaction (reliance on channels of communication rather than spatial, kinship, or "formal" ties necessarily implies the importance of mediated interaction in forming and maintaining social organization in social worlds). Unruh (1980) discusses communication centers as vital to the coordination of activities, production, and interrelationships among those involved in the social world. Whatever formalization occurs in social worlds (Unruh, 1980) arises out of these centers of communication. They are generally the "hub" of debates concerning authenticity, procedural matters, the extension or contraction of boundaries, and decisions revolving around the organizational focus.

Social media can be seen as a form of communication center in Unruh's (1980) conceptualization of social worlds. In the early 1990s, following the rise of online discussion groups, the concept of a virtual community was introduced. In 1993, Reingold defined a virtual community as "social aggregations that emerge from the Net when enough people carry on ... public discussions long enough, with sufficient human feeling, to form webs of personal relationships in cyberspace" (quoted in Parks, 2011, p. 105). Parks refines this definition as

... a group might qualify as a virtual community if its members engaged in collective action, shared in rituals, had a variety of relational linkages, and were emotionally bonded

to others in a way that conferred a sense of belonging and group identification. (2011, p. 177)

In virtual communities, such as Second Life, people are motivated by entertainment and getting away from real life, as well as to meet and interact with people from around the world, to communicate and maintain relationships (Zhou, Jin, Vogel, Fang, & Chen, 2011). Similar motivations are found in research on participating in online social networks. Chung and Buhalis (2008a) found that information acquisition (such as finding information, sharing experiences), social-psychological (seeking identity, belongingness), and hedonic benefits (having fun) influence level of participation and attitude toward an online travel community. Parra-López et al. (2011) confirmed this and also found that there is a series of conditioning factors that can act as incentives for tourists' social media use: availability of the technology, altruism, the environment, individual predispositions, and trust of the users' information exchanged and written online. They also found that the users' perceived costs (related to possible loss of privacy, the effort required, and/or the difficulty of using the technologies), have no significant impact on the predisposition to use social media.

People are further motivated to contribute to content in social media. Yoo and Gretzel (2008) found that those who write online reviews are motivated by the sense of helping travel service providers, concerns for other consumers, and needs for enjoyment and a desire for positive recognition from others. Bronner and de Hoog (2011) confirm this in their study of tourists who post onsite. They found the following motivations: being self-directed, helping other vacationers, getting social benefits, empowering consumers, and helping companies. They also found that the main discriminating factor for why a tourist chooses a particular site is the factor that sets tourists with a primarily self-directed motivation apart from those with a more other-directed help motivation. Jepsen (2006) found that an information search in virtual communities to some extent replaces information from marketer-dominated sources.

Based on these literature insights and the fact that pop culture fans are also tourists and part of a community, a number of hypotheses emerge:

H1: Online pop culture fans are intensive users of social media.

H2: Social media are important for pop culture fans when planning and making decisions about travel and event participation.

Social Identity and Online Community Participation

Social identity and a sense of belonging are important for understanding any social community. Social identity is widely used to explain group and collective behavior (Bagozzi & Lee, 2002). Research on social identity and virtual communities (groups of people who interact online for the sake of achieving personal as well as shared goals) is part of a more general theme of research that tries to understand the nature and role of the social influence exerted by the community on its members. Bagozzi and Dholakia (2002) and Dholakia, Bagozzi, and Klein Pearo (2004) use the concept of social identity to understand virtual community participation. They state that social identity "captures the main aspects of the individual's identification with the group in the sense that the person comes to view himself or herself as a member of the community, as belonging to it" (Dholakia et al., 2004, p. 245). In their research, social identity is conceptualized as having cognitive, affective, and evaluative components. The cognitive component concerns how the individual forms a self-awareness of virtual community membership, the affective component implies that social identity includes a sense of emotional involvement with the group, and evaluative social identity is focused on the evaluation of self-worth on the basis of belonging to the community. Dholakia et al.'s conceptualization of social identity was later used by Cheung and Lee (2010) to study intentional social action in online social networks. The importance of all three dimensions of social identity was confirmed, and their results show the importance of social identity in the development of a virtual community.

Similarly, the real value of online travel communities lies in the extent to which members can identify with the group through interaction (Casaló et al., 2010). Highly interactive travel community members are more likely to share and promote the community with others (Qu & Lee, 2011). According to social exchange theory, people interact in virtual communities because they expect that it will be rewarding both in terms of tangibles such as goods or money and in terms of social benefits such as friendship. Further, the outcomes of interaction as well as the interaction itself can offer benefits. Interaction is about how to interact, with whom, and what should be exchanged (Füller, 2010). Research on consumer interactions in virtual communities shows that the stronger the social ties and the more enjoyment experienced in interactions, the more likely the member is to display reciprocal behavior (Chan & Li, 2010). Hence, consumers not only focus on utilitarian values but also value hedonic social relationships and enjoyment when determining their engagement in virtual communities.

However, virtual communities are found to consist of both “lurkers” (persons who read but never post) and “posters”; lurkers are the more common role (Baym, 2010). Welser, Gleave, Fisher, and Smith (cited in Baym, 2010, p. 87) identified two different kinds of posters: “answer people” (frequently respond yet never initiate) and “discussion people” (both initiate and respond). Discussion people could be considered “e-fluentials,” who are opinion leaders who spread information via the Internet (Burson-Marsteller cited in Sun, Youn, Wu, & Kuntaraporn, 2006, p. 1105).

As noted above, a sense of belonging is important in online communities. Although research shows that members of a travel community with a high degree of identification with the group take an active role by sharing knowledge, they may not be influenced in their product-related behaviors. Nevertheless, this is moderated if members of a community are highly interactive (Qu & Lee, 2011). Furthermore, in blogs people share detailed accounts of experiences. These blog posts later influence readers and potentially impact purchase decisions. Research has shown that blog users find multiple evaluations that are concordant to be helpful, irrespective of whether they are positive or negative. Negative postings are not always a bad thing if they are followed by a positive counter-reaction (Zehrer et al., 2011). Attempting to influence behavior and retain customers for their online services, websites such as Virtual Tourist and Lonely Planet have integrated community functionalities to build a sense of belonging and trust (Sanchez-Franco & Rondan-Cataluña, 2009). Consequently, three additional hypotheses about online communities are proposed:

- H3: A high level of perceived social identity increases pop culture fans' future intention to travel and participate at events.
- H4: A high level of perceived social identity increases pop culture fans' future intention to recommend to others to travel or participate in events.
- H5: A high level of perceived social identity increases pop culture fans' average use of websites/blogs/communities.

Concept and Practice of Involvement

The extent of consumers' involvement with an object is said to impact behavioral decisions (Zaichkowsky, 1985, 1986). According to Andrews, Durvasula, and Akhter (1990), the level of intensity in involvement varies by

product types, situations, and individual conditions. Involvement is defined by Park, Lee, and Han as “the perceived personal relevance of a product based on the individual consumer’s needs, interests, and values” (2007, p. 129). In order to explain bloggers’ intention to purchase travel products, Huang et al. (2010) propose modeling involvement at three levels: personal, product, and situation. The first is related to consumers’ inner needs, interests, and values. The second is focused on the consumers’ perceptions about the product such as the risk involved, price, symbolic meaning, endurance, pleasure, importance, brand, and purchase duration. The third is defined as the situations that consumers face when interacting with product communication, purchasing the product, using the product, and risk perceptions. High-involvement travel bloggers are more likely to form a favorable impression toward marketing communication in blogs (Huang et al., 2010). Sanchez-Franco and Rondan-Cataluña (2010) find that level of purchase involvement has a strong moderating effect on consumers’ willingness to engage in online service relationships and that virtual communities should be designed according to the customers’ involvement levels. Furthermore, Cai, Feng, and Breiter (2004) conclude that consumers who have high levels of purchase involvement are more likely than others to use the Internet to search for destination information. These studies clearly show the effect of involvement on consumer perceptions and behavioral intentions.

Hence, different personal perceptions, product characteristics, and situations will lead to various levels of involvement. In this study, Huang et al.’s (2010) model of involvement (personal, product, and situation) is used to understand pop culture fans and their use of social media. Level of involvement is explored, both in the pop culture phenomenon itself and involvement in the online community. The effect of involvement on future travel intent and intention to recommend is also investigated. Therefore, still three more hypotheses about online communities are proposed:

- H6: A high level of perceived involvement increases pop culture fans’ future intention to travel and participate in events.
- H7: A high level of perceived involvement increases pop culture fans’ future intention to recommend to others to travel or participate in events.
- H8: A high level of perceived involvement increases pop culture fans’ average use of websites/blogs/communities.

The Twilight Saga Fans, Tourists, and Web Users

The empirical case for the role of social media in tourism discussed in this chapter is focused on the pop culture phenomenon and international blockbuster movies and bestselling books known as the *Twilight Saga*. This is a story about the teenager Bella Swan and her impossible romance with vampire boyfriend Edward Cullen. It is primarily set in the small town Forks (Washington) which is the rainiest town in the continental United States. She also befriends a young man called Jacob Black who turns out to be a werewolf. The story has a strong romantic element with a touch of fantasy (<http://www.stepheniemeyer.com>). The four books included in the series have sold a total of 116 million copies worldwide (<http://www.publishersweekly.com/pw/by-topic/childrens/childrens-book-news/article/44733-little-brown-to-publish-official-twilight-guide.html>). The five films in the series that have been released on the big screen and on DVD/BlueRay have grossed more than US\$ 4 billion worldwide (The-numbers.com, 2012a–2012d).

Contrary to the media-perpetuated image of Twilight fans as young, screaming, obsessive girls, the *Twilight Saga* attracts a wide range of fans, mostly females between the ages of 8 and 80 (Wilson, 2011). Twilight's main attraction can be found, according to scholars, in its vacillation between contradictory messages: "a series that presents neither a subversive nor a conservative view of larger social contexts but is an ambiguous mixture of both" (Wilson, 2011, p. 8).

The *Twilight Saga* fan community includes many websites, blogs, forums, and online networks that are dedicated to this phenomenon. These fans discuss their own constructed meaning of Twilight: "In both the virtual world and the real world, love, romance, and desire are held up as the meaning behind Twilight." In addition, their online behavior includes more superficial elements, at least among the more mature female fan-base, which focuses on the romantic message of the saga: "albeit in a more 'sexed-up' form ... a sort of Playgirl for Twilight fans (sans the full-frontal nudity but with plenty of bare chests and bulging muscles)" (Wilson, 2011, p. 44).

Furthermore, fans use Twilight websites, blogs, and forums when searching for and communicating information before, during, and after their Twilight-related travel. Many of them include various types of explicit tourist information (Fig. 1), often provided by other users. For example, a user-generated slide show with voice-over and music can be found on one website. The slide show includes screen dumps from films compared to real

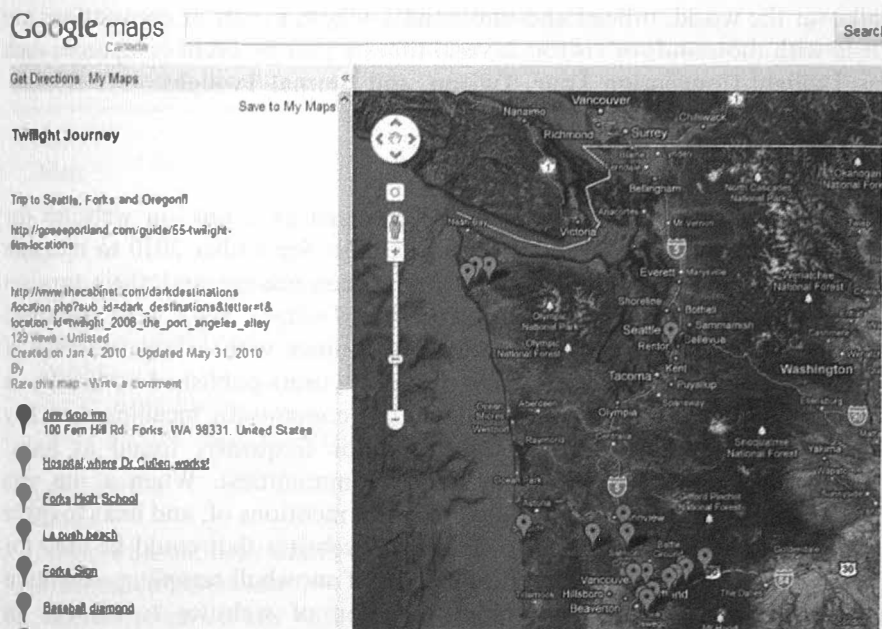


Figure 1. Google Map with Places Linked to Twilight

life photos taken by a fan traveling to Italy where there are several locations connected to the books and films. These “online spaces” constitute a platform for fans to interact, search for, and share information related to their interest in this pop culture phenomenon and hence potentially influences the behavior of these fans, including their tourism behavior. The fandom can be described as very organized, not least when it comes to tourism. There is an abundance of examples of online Twilight fandom: organized trips to the locations where the films have been shot, to the destinations where the books are set (Twatwaffels on Twitarded.blogspot.com), and Twilight events, conventions, and get-togethers (TwiMOMs Conventions and Get-Togethers on Twilightmoms.com). The principal destinations for Twilight tourism in terms of setting (where story is set, Frost 2006, 2009) are two small towns in the United States and in Italy: Forks (Washington) and Volterra (Tuscany). Regarding the locations where the films have been shot, the main attractions are Portland (USA), British Columbia (Canada), and Montepulciano (Italy). In addition, in major cities

all over the world, official and unofficial Twilight events or conventions are held with thousands of visitors several times a year by event companies such as Twilight Convention Tour, Twicon, and Eternal Twilight.

Study Methods

An international web survey was implemented as a link on websites for Twilight fans offering Web 2.0 applications in September 2010 to measure the activities of the *Twilight Saga* online community and their tourism behavior. Forty websites dedicated to the *Twilight Saga* were identified through a search for websites/blogs/communities with a large number of visitors/users (based on the number of visitors/users published by the site or through their position as nodes in the online community, meaning that they were frequently linked to by other sites or frequently found as links/mentions in Twitter flows or in online communities). When a site was identified, it was searched for affiliation with, mentions of, and links to other sites, which were then added to the list of websites that could be used for sampling. This can be described as a form of snowball sampling. Attention was also paid to the geographical location of websites to achieve an international representation of respondents. Only sites using the English language were included. But based on country of origin of the fans contributing with content, as seen in comments by fans, an attempt was made to include as many countries as possible. The owners/administrators of the websites were contacted and invited to publish the link to the web survey, and six of them published the link. The link was also picked up by Twitter users and was both tweeted and re-tweeted, generating additional respondents from the online Twilight community.

The questionnaire was developed based on literature reviews for the research themes included in the survey and pilot tests were conducted using friends and colleagues as test respondents. The survey measured behavior related to Twilight tourism and participation in events, motivation, perceived value, future behavioral intention, as well as use of the Internet, including the use of websites. Thirty-eight questions were included and items were measured using a Likert-type scale from 1 to 7 as well as categorical, dichotomous, and open-ended questions. The total number of respondents was 967.

Table 1 shows the descriptive distribution of the sample. However, due to the positioning of the background questions at the end of the survey, the number of respondents to these questions is lower than that of other parts of the questionnaire.

Table 1. Sample Descriptives

Sample Descriptive	% of <i>n</i> = 407-433
Gender	
Men	1
Women	99
Age	
Between 12 and 67	Median: 20
Country of origin	
Sweden	64
North America	19
Other (South America, Asia, Europe, Australia)	17
Family status	
Single	48
Single with children under 18	3
Married/common law	8
Married/common law with children under 18	12
Other	29
Education	
Less than high school	27
High school	24
Undergraduate	41
Post graduate	8

Measurement items on the average use of Twilight-related websites, experience of Twilight-related content on the Internet, purpose of this use, type of use, and Twilight-related tourism behavior were developed by the authors (Table 2). Furthermore, from the literature review it is assumed that future intention to participate or recommend as well as average use depend on two variables: social identity and involvement. Six items adapted from Dholakia et al. (2004) and Cheung and Lee (2010) were used to measure social identity. Based on Huang et al. (2010), 13 items that measure involvement were adapted (Table 3).

The dataset was prepared for further analysis and cases considered as outliers were removed. The total number of respondents retained for further analysis was 881. Reliability tests of the scales used in the regression analysis

Table 2. Measurement Items

Items	Scale	Construct
How often on average do you visit a Twilight-related website/blog/community?	Time scale	Web usage
When did you first start searching for Twilight-related content on the Internet?	Time scale	
When searching for Twilight-related content on the Internet, which are the three main purposes?	Multiple response options	
Have you participated at a Twilight-related event/trip (e.g., convention, visit to movie locations or places portrayed in the books, movie premier, DVD release, get-together, party)?	Dichotomous	Behavior
Please evaluate the following statements regarding your use of social media and your participation at Twilight-related events/trips.	1 = Not at all, 7 = to a large extent	
- I have used information in blogs/communities to plan my participation. - Information in blogs/communities influenced my decision to participate. - Information in blogs/communities influenced my decision NOT to participate. - Information in blogs/communities was helpful while I participated. - After I participate, I have shared my experiences on blogs/communities		
How many Twilight-related events/trips have you participated in where Twilight was the primary motive for your participation?	Numeric	

Table 2. (Continued)

Items	Scale	Construct
How many Twilight-related events/trips have you participated in where Twilight was the secondary motive for your participation?	Numeric	
How many Twilight-related events/trips have you participated in where Twilight was the secondary motive for your participation?	Dichotomous	
Regarding your most recent trip/event: What was your primary source of information when planning your event/trip?	Response options	
To what extent is it likely that you would do the following?	1 = Not likely, 7 = extremely likely	Loyalty
- Participate at a Twilight-related event/trip		
- Recommend to others to participate at a Twilight-related event/trip		

showed acceptable levels of Cronbach alpha coefficients (Nunnally, 1978), cognitive social identity (0.88), affective social identity (0.93), evaluative social identity (0.96), personal involvement (0.83), product involvement (0.75), and situation involvement (0.86). The dataset was also evaluated in terms of normality, linearity, and homoscedasticity.

Twilight Fan Behavior and Internet Use

The majority of the respondents (66%, $n = 772$) state that they have traveled to Twilight-related destinations or events. Further, 63% ($n = 517$) report that their interest in Twilight was the primary motive for traveling. The most important source of information ($n = 326$) is Twilight websites (62%), other

Table 3. Operational Measures for Social Identity and Involvement

Items	Scale	Construct
Please evaluate the following statements as regards to your use of Twilight blogs/communities	1 = Strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree	Social identity (Cheung et al., 2010). Items 1 and 2: cognitive social identity, items 3 and 4: affective social identity, items 5 and 6: evaluative social identity.
1. My self-image overlaps with the identity of the user group as I perceive it		
2. When I'm interacting with other users on blogs/communities I feel there is an overlap between my personal identity and the identity of the group		
3. I am very attached to the user group		
4. I have a strong feeling of belongingness toward the user group		
5. I am a valuable member of the group		
6. I am an important member of the group		
Please evaluate the following statements in relation to your involvement in Twilight.	1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree	Involvement (Huang et al., 2010). Items 1–4: personal involvement, items 5–8: product involvement, items 9–13: situation involvement.
1. I'm interested in reading blogs about Twilight information and photos, etc.		
2. When reading information in blogs I feel the information is appealing		

Table 3. (Continued)

Items	Scale	Construct
3. When reading information in blogs I feel that Twilight is relevant in my life		
4. When reading information in blogs I feel that Twilight means a lot to me		
5. I'm interested in Twilight		
6. Twilight is essential to me, thus it is difficult to choose between Twilight and my other hobbies		
7. Purchasing Twilight products is a ways of rewarding myself		
8. The Twilight products I purchase symbolize my personality and character		
9. I think Twilight blogs provide good efficiency in information searching		
10. I think Twilight blogs provide sufficient information		
11. I think what is written in Twilight blogs is reliable		
12. I think the communication in Twilight blogs is free from being interfered by sales-persons		
13. I think the communication in Twilight blogs is free from being interfered by friends outside the Twilight community		

websites (16.5%), and social media (10.5%). Specifically, respondents use information in blogs and communities to plan trips and events ($M = 5.64$, $n = 464$) and during their participation in events ($M = 5.59$, $n = 459$). They also state that they share these experiences on blogs and communities ($M = 5.19$, $n = 461$) and that it had influenced their decision ($M = 5.19$, $n = 462$) to travel.

Future travel intentions to Twilight-related destinations are indicated by the fact that 61% ($n = 500$) of the respondents state that it is likely or extremely likely that they will participate in a Twilight-related event or trip. Among respondents, 60% ($n = 498$) also state that it is likely or extremely likely that they will recommend to others to participate at a Twilight-related event/trip.

Twilight fans are avid users of the Internet: 92% ($n = 881$) visit a Twilight-related website, blog, or community from several times a day to a few times every week. They are also experienced users: 50% of respondents ($n = 868$) started to search for Twilight-related content on the Internet between one and two years ago, 30% more than two years ago, and a minority, 20%, did so more recently (up until a year ago). The most important reasons for searching for Twilight-related content on the Internet is to find information in general, to find information on the actors/characters, to read or watch Twilight-related content, to find exclusive Twilight content, and to interact with other fans.

Social Identity, Involvement, and Effects on Use and Future Intention

The variables used for analyzing the effects of social identity and involvement are: future intention to participate in a Twilight-related event/trip (F1), future intention to recommend to others to participate in a Twilight-related event/trip (F2), average use of Twilight-related websites (AU), cognitive social identity (CSI), affective social identity (ASI), evaluative social identity (ESI), personal involvement (PI), product involvement (PRI), and situation involvement (SI).

As shown by the mean values in Table 4, the majority of respondents perceive strong links between the virtual community and themselves, with the highest mean occurring for affective social identity indicating that emotional ties are most important. Involvement variables, on the other hand, show much higher means. The high mean of personal involvement shows how respondents perceive that what is available on Twilight websites, blogs, and communities is very much linked to their inner needs, interests,

Table 4. Descriptive Statistics of the Dependent and Explanatory Variables

Variable	<i>n</i>	Mean	Standard Deviation
F1	500	4.99	2.158
F2	498	4.83	2.156
AU	881	2.06 ^a	1.148
CSI	396	3.0051	1.780
ASI	394	3.1256	2.029
ESI	400	2.9438	2.040
PI	439	5.8759	1.140
PRI	433	4.4307	1.496
SI	417	5.0293	1.323

^aThe scale is reversed and 1 represents several times a day and 8 less than every six months.

Table 5. Pearson's Correlations

Scale	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
F1	—	.813 ^b	-.350 ^b	.361 ^b	.425 ^b	.389 ^b	.483 ^b	.473 ^b	.393 ^b
F2		—	-.245 ^b	.273 ^b	.345 ^b	.311 ^b	.415 ^b	.402 ^b	.353 ^b
AU*			—	-.215 ^{a,b}	-.334 ^{a,b}	-.328 ^{a,b}	-.433 ^{a,b}	-.381 ^{a,b}	-.357 ^{a,b}
CSI				—	.638 ^b	.527 ^b	.409 ^b	.466 ^b	.376 ^b
ASI					—	.800 ^b	.409 ^b	.475 ^b	.349 ^b
ESI						—	.361 ^b	.429 ^b	.361 ^b
PI							—	.542 ^b	.580 ^b
PRI								—	.498 ^b
SI									—

*The scale is reversed and 1 represents several times a day and 8 less than every six months.

*The scale is reversed so that 1 indicates high frequency of use.

^b $p < 0.001$ (Sig. 2-tailed, pairwise exclusion of cases).

and values. Situation involvement also has a high mean score, indicating how valuable the respondents perceive the use of these online websites, blogs, and communities.

In order to test the direction and strength of the linear relationship among the concepts of social identity, involvement, and Twilight fans' future

intentions to participate in a Twilight-related event/trip or to recommend this to others, Pearson's correlation was used. Results of correlations between measures of future intention, average use of websites/blogs/communities, social identity, and involvement are shown in Table 5. The interpretation of the results follows the criteria established by Cohen (1988). Between the dependent variables (F1 and F2), the correlation effect is considered large. Large effects are also found between CSI and ASI, CSI and ESI, ASI and ESI, PI and PRI, and PI and SI. All other correlations are considered moderate except between F2 and AU, F2 and CSI, and AU and CSI, which have small effects.

Three models were tested with multiple regression analysis conducted on the three independent variables separately. The independent variables for all the models were cognitive social identity, affective social identity, evaluative social identity, personal involvement, product involvement, and situation involvement. The dependent variable for Model 1 was future intention to participate in a Twilight-related event/trip. For Model 2, the dependent variable was future intention to recommend to others to participate in a Twilight-related event/trip, and for Model 3 it was average use of Twilight-related websites/blogs/communities.

High correlations between dependent and independent variables are first indicators of causal relationships within the overall construct. No multicollinearity problems are shown in the correlations or the tolerance or VIF statistics when compared to established thresholds (Hair, Anderson, Tatham, & Black, 1998; Leech, Barrett, & Morgan, 2005).

As seen in Table 6, in Models 1 and 2 the largest significant contributions to explaining future intention to participate and future intention to recommend to others to participate in a Twilight-related event/trip was found with the personal involvement and product involvement variables. However, in Model 3, apart from large significant contributions to explain average use of Twilight-related websites by the personal and product involvement variables, cognitive social identity also makes a significant contribution to explain this behavior.

The combination of variables that entered the regression explain 33% of the variance in Twilight tourists' future intentions and 24% of their future intention to recommend, as well as 25% of average use of Twilight-related websites/blogs/communities. The effect size (f^2) for Model 1 was .05, for Model 2 it was 0.32, and for Model 3, 0.34. Using Cohen's (1988) conventions for effect size, these are all large effects.

Table 6. Regression Analysis of Social Identity/Involvement on Future Intention/Average Use

Model 1 ^a						
Dependent Variable	F1 (Future intention to participate at Twilight-related event/trip)					
Variable	Standardized coefficients		Collinearity statistics		t-Statistic	Sig.
	Beta	Std. Error	Tolerance	VIF		
CSI	.014	.070	.546	1.832	0.251	.802
ASI	.133	.084	.289	3.463	1.683	.093
ESI	.078	.076	.356	2.806	1.088	.277
PI	.241	.108	.561	1.783	4.237	.000
PR1	.200	.081	.579	1.727	3.569	.000
SI	.077	.089	.608	1.644	1.416	.157
Model 2 ^b						
Dependent Variable	F2 (Future intention to recommend others to participate at a Twilight-related event)					
CSI	-.040	.075	.546	1.832	-.642	.521
ASI	.133	.090	.289	3.463	1.572	.117
ESI	.043	.081	.356	2.806	.560	.576
PI	.208	.115	.516	1.783	3.430	.001
PR1	.176	.086	.579	1.727	2.939	.003
SI	.100	.095	.608	1.644	1.713	.088
Model 3 ^c						
Dependent Variable	AU (Average use of Twilight-related website/blog/community)					
CSI	.133		.546	1.832	2.180	.030
ASI	-.112		.289	3.463	-1.331	.184
ESI	-.119		.356	2.806	-1.571	.117
PI	-.257		.516	1.783	-4.262	.000
PR1	-.146		.579	1.727	-2.466	.014
SI	-.108		.608	1.644	-1.875	.062

^aModel fit: $R^2 = .334$, F -value = 30.616, $p = 0.000$.

^bModel fit: $R^2 = .241$, F -value = 19.396, $p = 0.000$.

^cModel fit: $R^2 = .253$, F -value = 20.743, $p = 0.000$.

CONCLUSION

The proliferation of social media use in customers' online activities raises questions as to the effects of this for marketing in general as well as consumer behavior. Based on previous research and available statistics it is clear that social media influence the behavior of tourists in their planning, purchasing, and post-consumption activities. In social media communities, tourists are motivated by entertainment, communication, interaction, and maintaining relationships (Chung & Buhalis, 2008b; Jepsen, 2006; Yoo & Gretzel, 2008; Zhou et al., 2011). Social identity and a sense of belonging are important for the development and success of online communities (Casaló et al., 2010; Chan & Li, 2010) and tourists' level of involvement can explain the formation of certain behaviors (Cai et al., 2004; Huang, 2010; Sanchez-Franco & Rondan-Cataluña, 2010).

Highly involved pop culture consumers can be characterized as fans and they are often motivated by sociocultural and social belongingness needs (Chen, 2007; Kim & Chalip, 2004; Smith & Stewart, 2007). They are also engaged in traveling to places in connection with their interest and they use and meet on various website forums, blogs, and communities. The results of this study show that pop culture fans use social media to a large extent and that they are important for making decisions about travel and event participation. Similar to earlier research on virtual communities in general, and travel communities in particular (Chung & Buhalis, 2008a, b; Jepsen, 2006), the results show that information acquisition is an important user motive, as is contributing content through sharing. The high level of sharing among the fans indicates that this pop culture virtual community, contrary to the findings of Baym (2010), consists of active posters to a high degree. Moreover, the high levels of average use of Twilight-related websites and that affective social identity was found to be the most important dimension of social identity, indicate that indeed these online pop culture fans resemble what Parks (2011) suggests and define a virtual community.

Earlier study findings indicate that all three dimensions—cognitive, affective, and evaluative social identity—were important for the development of a virtual community (Cheung & Lee, 2010). The results reported in this chapter do not support this finding since the mean scores for social identity are much lower than those for involvement dimensions. A possible explanation could be the measurement items *per se*. For instance, the social identity scale used lacks items more closely related to emotion and passion, which are proposed to be important dimensions of a consumer tribe

(Maffesoli, 1996). Personal involvement and product involvement were found to be the most important factors explaining use of social media, future intention to travel and participate in events, and to recommend to others. This implies that fans' inner needs, interests, and values, as well as perceptions about the product, are most important to explain tourism behavior and use of websites and blogs. Cai et al. (2004) specifically found that high levels of purchase involvement increase the likelihood of using the Internet for an information search. This result is consistent with the present study where product involvement, including purchase, was found to significantly increase average use of Twilight-related websites and blogs. Emotional ties and self-awareness are also somewhat valuable explanatory factors as seen by significant or near significant effects on the dependent variables from affective and cognitive social identity. Perceptions of self-worth seem to be less important, implying that fans do not feel that it is important to be valued by the community.

Interactivity has in previous research been found to affect community-related behavior as well as product-related behavior (Qu & Lee, 2011). Although this study did not specifically measure the effect of interactivity on future intention to participate and recommend or on average use, the results indicate the relevance of interactivity with the community. The most important motives for use as well as the relative importance of cognitive social identity, including the interaction aspect of overlap between self- and group identity, are indicators of the influence of interactivity.

This chapter contributes to the understanding of social media use in tourism, particularly, how social media connect to future tourism behavior is better understood. The results also indicate the importance of the cultural dimensions in the virtual community under study. The tribal characteristics of pop culture fans—the common identities, practices, rituals, meanings, and culture that they have produced (Cova et al., 2007)—explain their high involvement in the virtual community. Therefore, the cultural dimensions in a virtual community influence the fans' motives to travel. Hence, the study shows that it is evident that social media are important in shaping tourism behavior. The online travel-related activities do have an influence on the actual physical travel, thus an integration of the virtual and physical can be seen. Therefore, social media are an important part of tourism studies.

The chapter also indicates that the industry connected to pop culture tourism should be aware of the opportunity to use social media in distinguishing the pop culture tourists' inner needs, interests, and values and that their marketing strategies can be formulated accordingly. Furthermore, the findings indicate that fans' perceptions about the product

are important for their use of social media and tourism-related behavior. This can be seen as an implication that not all types of tourism products can expect the same benefits from social media marketing. Pop culture tourists can be characterized by their strong involvement in a specific phenomenon (in this case, the *Twilight Saga*) and this drives their use of social media and consequently their intention to travel. This in turn supports the idea that social media use is an important link between pop culture fans and their tourism-related behavior.

Several topics for future research can be drawn from this study. First, the reasons for the weak contribution of social identity toward future intention to travel, recommend, and use social media need to be further explored. Second, if in fact pop culture fans' disposition to be highly involved and show high levels of social media use actually mean that they are somehow different from other tourists, this needs to be validated by comparing them to other types of tourists. Third, since social identity and involvement only partly explain the variance in future intentions and use of websites, blogs, and communities, other concepts need to be explored to complement these findings.

Regarding methods to study social media use in tourism, it is proposed that tourists with high levels of social media use need to be further studied from as many aspects as possible, especially in terms of concepts that can explain the motives behind their use. On the other hand, further knowledge on areas of tourism-related behavior where social media use is not so widespread is needed. For the study reported in this chapter, an online survey was used and the sample was users of websites, blogs, and communities connected to the *Twilight Saga*. A type of snowball sampling was used to frame a sample which, as much as possible, represents the online community of Twilight fans. The generalizability of the results from a sample where the population, to a large extent, is unknown in terms of size and general characteristics, is always a potential limitation. Therefore, a mixed methods approach using triangulation is proposed for future research to increase both reliability and validity. For instance, focus group interviews or in-depth interviews with tourists who use social media for various purposes could be complemented with online surveys and experimental designs.

In this case study, the sample is almost entirely based on female respondents. Although this is in line with the population of Twilight fans, it remains to be explored how the results compare to studies with a more equally distributed sample in terms of gender or a sample dominated by men. For example, would the results be similar for other pop culture fans in

terms of social media use? This is important future research since it would clarify whether the results are attributable to a gender aspect or a specific pop culture phenomenon, or whether they could be generalized to a larger population.

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Chapter 9

Digital Social Construction of a Tourist Site: Ground Zero

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ABSTRACT

Reviews of Ground Zero, New York on TripAdvisor show a diversity of interpretations. Amidst the cacophony of voices, there is communication and a semblance of community. This sense of community—despite the lack of strong coherent and consistent views, a plethora of diverse topics, and heterogeneous perspectives—is brought together and built on chronotopic (time-space) structures. Drawing inspiration from Bakhtin's chronotopes, this chapter shows how spatial and temporal structures are negotiated. The negotiation processes demonstrate that tourists now have a global platform to communicate and are able to stake claims of legitimacy to interpreting foreign heritage. Thus tourists are layering new meanings on historical sites and are contributing to the rewriting of local histories, all as part of glocalization.

Keywords: Chronotopes; glocalization; tourist communication; heritage interpretation; emerging authenticity

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INTRODUCTION

Social media are transforming the tourism industry. With millions of persons commenting, complaining, and complimenting on social media platforms, an era of active public participation in the appreciation and interpretation of attractions and destinations has been initiated. These media have supposedly increased the transparency and empowered the customer base (Israel, 2009; Tapscott, 2009). For instance, the popular tourism website TripAdvisor, which is used as a case in this chapter, allows travelers to evaluate and express their thoughts and feelings toward tourism products. This development has not only created a cacophony of voices in social media but also in the tourism industry as a whole. Different contributors have different approaches and perceptions, giving rise to very diverse types of meanings and perspectives. The spectrum of views ranges from the playful to the serious, the celebratory to the disapproving. Regardless, the sum of different views creates a myriad of voices and opinions and a virtually linked group emerges and evolves. These groups, arguably communities, are constituted by seemingly helpful strangers and fleeting "friends" (Adkins & Grant, 2007).

This chapter shows that Web 2.0-based tourist communities not only reveal how visitors interpret places, inform of the range of different tourist interests, these so-called communities also document and subsequently recreate and enrich the attractions. Drawing on Bakhtin's concept of the chronotope, the recreation of the attraction entails three interrelated processes: re-temporalization, re-spatialization, and re-culturalization. These processes are part of "glocalization" (Robertson, 1995).

Tourism Social Media, Glocalization, and Chronotopes

Globalization does not just entail cultural homogeneity, but also dynamic and conflicting processes of "glocalization," with the local-global nexus playing a crucial role in the way places are consumed, imagined, and changed (Robertson, 1995). International tourism contributes much to glocalization. Local societies host foreign tourists, increasingly aiding the convergence of tourist behavior and subsequently the emergence of the tourist-way-of-doing-things or tourism cultures (Ooi, 2002a). Similarly, the pervasive use of social media has glocalizing patterns. On one hand, online communities, social networks, and interactive forums share a common set of rules and features, constituting a semblance of global culture (Castells, 2001). On the

other hand, the interaction in virtual forums is also embedded in localized sociocultural practices and circumstances. Social media are affecting the global tourism industry; a comparison between traditional and social media interaction would help in understanding the process.

First, when compared to other traditional mass media such as newspapers or television broadcasts, social media encourage high levels of interactivity and participation among users (Cook, 2008). This is a potential that has been realized in Web 2.0 platforms like TripAdvisor and Facebook. But at the same time, not all users contribute to the discussions. Second, tourist-generated content can spread widely in an out-of-control manner. One dominant metaphor describing social media is "a virus." Virtual content can spread quickly and globally, like viral diseases. These media bring massive reach in an instant allowing communication with large numbers of people in different locations and at different times (Baym, 2010). At the same time, many stories do not spread.

Third, social media allow for multiple temporal structures as tourists may use online communities to engage in synchronous and asynchronous communication (Litvin et al., 2008). While face-to-face conversations are gone as soon as they have taken place, tourist-generated digital content can easily be stored and replicated. At the same time, online content is also ephemeral and what was posted one day can be modified or gone the next. This way, online content may remain for "eternity" or be modified or deleted instantly. Fourth, the use of these media is becoming increasingly mobile with tourists uploading and accessing user-generated content through mobile technologies (such as posting on Twitter from a mobile phone). The contribution to content has been democratized, in the sense that almost anyone with the appropriate equipment and with Internet access has the possibility to express her or his views, perspectives, and reflections. Contributors do not usually encounter content gatekeepers at the first instance.

Finally, as a consequence of the last point, these media also change what is communicated. Because of the invisibility of the content gatekeepers at the outset, tourists increasingly communicate emotions and feelings, for example, through immediate exclamations of pleasure or displeasure, use of smileys, like-button signs, and the like (Munar & Ooi, 2012). Such expressions also communicate an emotional sense of honesty. Generally, tourists' online conversations and electronic word-of-mouth can change the credibility of different information sources (Litvin et al., 2008), the perception of specific advertisements (Huang et al., 2010; Mack et al., 2008), and affect online information search patterns (Huang et al., 2010).

Despite the uncertainty and fluidity in social media platforms, user-generated content plays an increasingly major role in traditional marketers' strategies (Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). But the use of social media is not universal. Social media practices—as well as media adoption, Internet use, and levels of e-literacy—vary greatly across the globe (Gursoy & McCleary, 2004). Technology adoption and use depend on demographic characteristics (Hsu, Ju, Yen, & Chang, 2007) and national travel markets (Gretzel et al., 2008). Furthermore, the stability and strength of social media communities are questionable. Scholars have argued that traditional late-modern communities are based on reflexivity and individual choice (Beck & Beck-Gernsheim, 2002; Giddens, 1987; Lash, 2002). Castells (2001) suggests the relevance of individual choice and self-connectivity in the era of the Internet. Virtual tourism communities made up of review makers and storytellers appear in an unpredictable gray zone between both the local and the global and the personal and the public. Relationships are instantly created and dismantled. While traditional communities rely on personal identities, anonymous reviewers decouple their identities from their reviews. Fake reviews or misinformation do not necessarily entail penalties for the contributors or the administrators of the sites. In user-generated reviews, the richness of social and personal cues is poor.

In making sense of this complexity in the so-called “virtual world”—the blending of the local and global, communication among strangers and fleeting friends and asynchronized exchanges—meaningful dialogues and discussions still take place. The many diverse narratives are built on chronotopic structures (Bakhtin, 1981). Chronotope literally means “time-space” (Bakhtin, 1981, p. 84). The concept of chronotope asserts the primacy of space and time in the human experience (Bakhtin, 1981; Ooi, 2001; van Loon, 1997; Vice, 1997). Even in cyberspace, messages and stories have temporal and spatial dimensions. This study demonstrates how time, space, and meanings are reconstituted in the cacophony of voices and messages on social media platforms. To Bakhtin, time and space form an intricate matrix that gives body and organizes narratives in the text. A chronotope is a “primary means for materialising time in space, [and it] emerges as a centre for concretising representation, as a force giving body to the entire novel” (1981, p. 250). The narratives in social media, even if they are built mainly on experiences and memory, as will be shown later, offer the authority of solidity because of their temporal and spatial anchors.

Chronotopes heuristically separate time and space, and organize texts “according to the ratio and nature of the temporal and spatial categories represented” (Holquist, 1981, pp. 425–426). One can theoretically frame

time and space as separate and distill them from the attached emotions and values in human experiences, but Bakhtin observed that

[L]iving artistic perception ... makes no such divisions and permits no such segmentation. It seizes on the chronotope in all its wholeness and fullness. Art and literature are shot through with *chronotopic values* of varying degree and scope. Each motif, each separate aspect of artistic work bears value. (Bakhtin, 1981, p. 243, emphasis in original)

The articulations in social media are not mediated by one single author but by many people and constrained through the channels of communication. As a result, the cacophony of different voices can be confusing. There are different styles of writing, bringing together diverse genres of communication. The mishmash of articulations in social media does not offer a clear flow, but time-space structures remain embedded. As this chapter exemplifies in the case on Ground Zero in New York, the actual physical space and the fateful day (September 11, 2001) have become the spatial and temporal focal points for users of TripAdvisor to connect, communicate, and exchange. Those focal points, however, eventually evolve into a tumbleweed-like time-space structure that leads to the re-spatialization, re-temporalization, and re-culturalization of the site.

This chapter examines the consequences of the pervasive use of social media in the tourism industry and it does so by analyzing the representation of a tourist site—Ground Zero in New York City—in TripAdvisor. In the age of globalization, many objects and places are now part of a global awareness (Held, McGrew, Goldblatt, & Perraton, 1999). Ground Zero in New York is one of them. It is a site that is meaningful and even sacred to people around the world. It is a magnet for Web 2.0 discussions on the Internet. Social media are platforms that bring together people with different backgrounds, experiences, memories, and agendas. With the cacophony of voices and the absence of a “master story weaver,” the exchanges have led to the new narratives on Ground Zero.

RECONSTRUCTING GROUND ZERO

The *re-temporalization* process accentuates how the linear chronological flow of time is subverted, as memories, thoughts, and feelings are expressed and presented in Web 2.0. Tourism scholars often divide up a trip into pre-visit,

visit, and post-visit phases (Jafari, 1987). This partition is also replicated in social media research (Fotis et al., 2012). This traditional division, however, becomes ambiguous and fluid in digitized communication, because a person uses the Web 2.0 before, during, and after the trip; on this medium, communication is often asynchronous (Baym, 2010). Comments and reviews are piled up without respect to whether entries were made during different stages of the tourism experience. They are based largely on personal experiences, perceptions, and memories. The fuzziness of temporal references in user-generated contents has consequences. For instance, visitors may be unaware of changes in the destination over time or have dated, preconceived ideas, all of which could lead to pleasant or unpleasant experiences when they evaluate their visits. Past memories, preconceptions, and expectations are blended with the newer site visit experiences in the reviews. With different individuals expressing their own personal reflections, and articulating their own mental construction of time and history of a site, a tourism social media platform offers a carnivalesque mesh of temporal layers. At the same time, the fateful day of September 11 in this case, is the focal point that gives readers and visitors the foundation to jointly articulate their (own diverse) versions of history.

Re-spatialization highlights how the physical boundary of a destination or attraction is mentally constructed in social media. Destinations and attractions often have a well-delimited physical presence, but as discussed later, people's memories and experiences of a place are not necessarily tied to fixed boundaries. Instead, people make mental, experiential, and imagined linkages to other places and selectively describe the place based on their own experiences, thus creating multiple spatial boundaries of an attraction or destination. The physical aspect of place is exerted in the narrative but it is actually being reimagined, leading to a re-spatialized destination. In spite of the fact that different people refer to the same place and the same event (such as Ground Zero and September 11), history gets constructed through narrations and images, as stories are layered one after another, especially when people make comparisons and links to other places. As these layers of stories travel through social media, readers around the world create their own perceived spatial boundaries for the attraction or destination.

The *re-culturalization* of destinations and attractions is inextricably tied to the processes of re-temporalization and re-spatialization, because meanings and interpretations are embedded with temporal and spatial dimensions. Social expressions of time and space carry cultural meanings. With the creation of new temporal and spatial interpretations, so do new social and cultural meanings. Tourists lack the local knowledge of residents,

instead they imbue new meanings, as mentioned earlier. The tourist perspective has gained currency in the context of the Web 2.0 platform. For example, online travel reviews and user-generated content are often perceived as more likely to provide reliable information than content posted by tourism organizations (Yoo & Gretzel, 2008). What is perceived as authentic by tourists, however, can be perceived differently by residents. Social media sites have created a parallel virtual existence for the destination and attraction that sidelines local residents by giving primary attention to tourists. But there is no coherence in constituting the tourist-centered story. Instead, contrasting tales and interpretations melt together, constituting new aspects of the site, as will be shown later. What pulls the diverse interpretations together is the chronotopic concreteness of the physical space and September 11. From these starting points, a tumbleweed of temporal and spatial structures develop; together histories are rewritten and invented.

In sum, Web 2.0 tourism platforms are crucibles for the emergence of virtual destinations and touristic spaces, which are filled with tourism stories and imagery. History is literally being written, but not in a coherent manner, as more and more persons join in the discussion and add multiple layers of different views and information. In this way, the idea of what is to be a community is also being transformed. There is diversity and disagreement, and consensus and joint-affirmation (Munar, 2010a; Munar & Ooi, 2012). Despite the semblance of a community, online communities most often do not entail recurrent communication, strong familiarity or the establishment of deeper interdependent relationships (Kozinets, 2002, 2008). The cacophony of views makes for a thriving, fluid community of sporadic connections. Members come and go; many are strangers to one another. Some have the intention of being helpful while others enjoy the possibilities of self-expression, self-enhancement, and prestige (Bronner & de Hoog, 2011). The local cultural context that defines the physical destination has been represented by tourist-oriented perspectives, as tourists themselves create their own destination in ways that they themselves can enjoy, criticize, and feel for. This carnivalesque situation is also orderly if one is to understand it as the re-temporalization, re-spatialization, and re-culturalization of the attraction or destination.

Study Methods

As already stated, this chapter studies TripAdvisor, with Ground Zero in New York as the focal point of discussion and review. It examines the

multiple and contrasting meanings and interpretations coming together on a common platform (TripAdvisor) in order to conceive cyber "realities." The inherent ontological frame adopted for this study is the constructive approach (Markham, 2004). In no way the intent is to provide a coherent picture of a virtual community in TripAdvisor; instead, it aims to highlight the heterogeneity and chronotopic fluidity in the articulations of Ground Zero. At the same time, it is important to acknowledge that it is possible for researchers to make sense of this diversity; somewhat coherent stories, interpretations, and histories emerge.

The study method consists of participative observation and it has been used by social scientists in conducting web research (Munar, 2010b; O'Reilly, Rahinel, Foster, & Patterson, 2007). Kozinets (2002, 2008) describes this method as an online evolution of ethnography and defines it as an application of methods of cultural anthropology to online cyber culture. Bronner and de Hoog (2011) suggest that analyses of tourists' contributions can adopt either site-centered or topic-centered approaches. This research adopts a site-centered and genre-focused approach and analyzes one social media site and its reviews. The platform is TripAdvisor, which is the largest networking site focusing on travel and tourism. The main type of content in TripAdvisor is the review of tourism products and offerings. TripAdvisor has over 20 million members; in May 2012 it claimed to have more than 60 million tourism product reviews (TripAdvisor, 2012a). Contrary to other social media sites, such as Facebook, TripAdvisor is an open network. It is not necessary to register or become a member to access the published content. However, it is necessary to create a virtual identity to upload content onto the site.

This study has two different streams of data analysis. The first investigates the structure and possibilities of TripAdvisor to map how tourists make use of this website to present their travel experiences. The analysis was conducted by making several visits to the website between February 2011 and January 2012 with the aim of examining the evolving stories. The second stream involves an extensive documentary analysis of a sample of travelers' reviews of Ground Zero in New York. The sample was established using TripAdvisor's search engine and classifying the reviews of these heritage sites by date and language (English). The search specification was "Ground Zero." The quotes used in this chapter are extracted from the search results of TripAdvisor. More than 80 posted reviews were analyzed.

Following the classical anthropological tradition of ethnographic fieldwork, the researchers observed, interpreted, internalized, reflected, and made sense of the happenings. This chapter does not offer a single authoritative interpretation of the so-called community. On the contrary, the study

inquired what constitutes this community when there are so many different contrasting voices and messages. The simple answer is that TripAdvisor and Ground Zero are the focal points of the group. However, the researchers attempted to delve deeper. Most of the entries are not atomized and unrelated to others. If users are having exchanges, one wonders, what they are saying and how they are bonding. It was only at a later stage of the study that it was decided to use Bakhtin's chronotope to help present the muddy situation without trying to marginalize the diversity. The researchers recognized that they were ordering a narrative onto the heterogeneous narratives they had encountered, internalized, and reflected on.

The Social Digital Construction of Ground Zero

September 11 has been one of the most fateful days in recent history. The sight of two airplanes crashing into the Twin Towers of the World Trade Center in New York has been etched into the collective memory. Official memorial services are held every year to mark the incident. The site where the twin towers once stood soon was dubbed Ground Zero. The redevelopment of Ground Zero has, however, been fraught with debates and controversies. These include the redevelopment of the site, having a Muslim community center close by, and the placement of the memorial. The attacks have also transformed air travel, with security checks at airports tightened all over the world. Ground Zero has become a tourism attraction. It is also a focal point in TripAdvisor, as foreigners and locals come together to tell their perspectives on this site.

Re-temporalization: The Mental Gaps and Leaps

September 11 offers a plethora of memories to people around the world. The memory remains vivid for many and is thus temporally "frozen" in people's minds. In contrast to the memories they hold, many reviewers were disappointed when they visited the site. For instance, StephP09 (January 30, 2010) of Medicine Hat, AB declared "Nothing to see" and wrote: "It is really just a construction site so there is absolutely nothing to see." Similarly, Gary488 of Leeds, UK (August 16, 2011) repeated: "Not worth a visit until the development is done. There is nothing to see but a building site."

To StephP09 and Gary488, a construction site is a non-sight. They have decoupled the massive construction project from its tragic history in their statements, revealing what is interesting and what is not to them. On the

other hand, at about the same time, Robo34 of Iowa City commented with the headline, "Must see, but not much to see yet":

It was surreal to visit this site, especially the fire department across the street from the construction. There were a couple small memorials there along with a poster showing all the brave men and women that gave and lost their lives on 9-11. It was emotional. After spending the first 2 days seeing all the other sites of NYC, I felt this experience cut through all the phonies and advertising and pomp that makes this city what it is. It was sobering, and I'm glad I did it. (April 29, 2010)

Larkie25 of Gainesville, Florida succinctly headlined his contribution, "Things to see is what you can't see anymore" (April 17, 2010). The disenchantment in what is to be seen by some of the reviewers and this last quote bring to mind the greater sensitivity that tourists put on visual elements (Urry, 1990). The site has already been previously imagined and visually objectified and the unfinished, chaotic, and unpredictable view of a construction site does not always live up to the expectation of the tourists' fantasy. Inherent in these contrasting views is that memories and expectations are essential in experiencing and evaluating Ground Zero as a tourist site. A historical site like Ground Zero, by definition, is meaningful because of its past and its stories. Tourists' anticipation regarding this tragic site has been nurtured by massive non-touristic information. One may then argue, these individuals may recall images of devastation broadcast by global media, but in the reviews these recollections are not considered part of the site they have come to visit. This disappointment by some visitors arises from unfulfilled (and incorrect) expectations. Prentice and other researchers show that tourists have preconceptions and they want to reinforce them through their tourism experiences (McIntosh & Prentice, 1999; Prentice, 2004; Prentice & Andersen, 2007). During their trips, these tourists will intentionally seek to affirm their own notions of the sites. These tourists find their heritage experiences richer when they confirm their expectations and see familiar aspects of the heritage sites they visit.

Regardless, in the context of how memories are expressed on TripAdvisor, the temporal dimension in the historical product has become an evaluative criterion of the site. Two opposing views are highlighted. The first is that memories are in the past, and Ground Zero does not have anything to show relating to September 11 because it has been cleaned up and rebuilt. For these tourists, their visits are not worthwhile because their memories of the

fateful day will remain as memories, which are not reified, from their perspective. The second view is that those memories are what make Ground Zero the site it is. The world has moved on but being there, armed with one's memory, makes the visit meaningful. But if the memories are what really matter, is visiting the physical site necessary? There will always be an inherent temporal gap between the past and the present. In the case of the discussion on TripAdvisor, different people package Ground Zero along diverse, selective, temporal elements. As a whole, the TripAdvisor community has created a set of "packaged pasts" (Ooi, 2001) that gives Ground Zero several temporal links between the past and present, allowing individuals diverse ways of appreciating, criticizing, remembering, and experiencing the site.

Re-spatialization: Place Linkages

Ground Zero is a site for tourists even though it is based on a tragic event. Different people have different relationships to it. The Bakhtinian chronotopic perspective suggests that time and place are always embedded in any articulations, and so September 11 is a temporal marker in people's memories; the subsequent images of the disaster have come to define the spatial spot of that memory. The disaster area may be where the attacks took place, but the search for meanings to experience the disaster site led to people redefining the boundaries of Ground Zero—that is, re-spatializing the site.

Many tourists see Ground Zero as a pilgrimage site, a must-visit stop in their itinerary of New York. To people around the world, Ground Zero carries emotional meanings. Hertfords, from Hertfordshire, United Kingdom, however, lamented emotionally that they could not visit the new memorial after traveling "five thousand miles":

If you are planning to visit ground zero and would like to visit the new memorial, then for gods sake get your passes as flying half way round the world and [practically begging] to be let in does not work! (October 10, 2011)

While people around the world remember Ground Zero as September 11, the physical place is now managed and regulations are used to control visitor numbers. Tourists do not necessarily know that. Without the local knowledge, travel can bring about physical and emotional anxiety related to feelings of uncertainty and unfamiliarity in foreign places (Ooi, 2005).

User-generated content fills in the needed local knowledge to save other visitors from disappointment, as Hertfords attempted to do. Tourists contributing to social media sites reveal altruistic behavior and a wish to help fellow tourists (Chang & Chuang, 2011). Essentially, the space has acquired new contexts that require the management of public access. Distant tourists are unaware of administrative changes and carry only iconic images of the place from September 11.

Ground Zero is also re-spatialized by association. For instance, an anonymous contributor from Chicago, Illinois (April 14, 2005) visited Pearl Harbor before and declared that Ground Zero is “our second pearl harbor.” A reviewer from Muroia, Spain, said:

So, you go there, you see all those pictures of the minutes before and after, you see the name of the people who died ... you remember that day when you were watching TV and didn't believe what your eyes were seeing, you remember 4 bombs in 4 trains a year ago in your own country ... well, just to see that my stomach turn upside down, and my eyes start watering ... I don't think that's at all a place to go, as if you'll going to the central park. (July 20, 2005)

What happened in Pearl Harbor and in Madrid were terrible tragedies. Comparisons made to Ground Zero were drawn on the horrors of the events. These are examples of tourists' contemplative views on the sites and also of the centrality of emotions in making spatial connections. These places are coupled together based on their emotional responses (or these places are “twinning”). Inadvertently, a map emerges containing tourism sites that are supposedly similar and emotionally laden.

Such an emotion-related map may have a different shape at a much smaller scale. The following examples show how Ground Zero is associated to nearby places that carry stories. Mental spaces are much more fluid than physical ones. On TripAdvisor, many reviewers provide emotional maps and tips to appreciate the site better, effectively redrawing the boundaries of Ground Zero. SueMunn of Luton, Beds suggested:

Just stumbled across this Irish Bar after having been to Ground Zero. The place is wonderful. Paul (owner's son) was fabulous. He has a photo album of the aftermath of the tragedy and the rebuilding of the bar which was so moving. His stories were amazing and he has the most fabulous

outlook on life. [...] Met the most amazing people who all shared their own experiences of that terrible event. To really understand the enormity of how this shook the local people, O'Hara's is a must see. (September 26, 2006)

This bar is presented as an authentic space that offers non-staged interpretations, moving the emotional contents of the actual physical site to the bar that carries the stories. With it, Ground Zero as a pilgrimage site has been spatially enlarged. Similarly, TABWisconsin recommended going to the St. Paul's Chapel:

When I was at Ground Zero, there were tarps along all the fences so you couldn't see anything on the ground ... but you could see the rebuilding. I also went across the street to the St. Paul's Chapel. The Chapel tells and shows so much. I am struggling to explain what this experience meant to me. I was so touched by the stories and the artifacts [...] A very very worthwhile place to visit. (September 10, 2011)

In these cases, tourists draw personal emotional maps. In the context of TripAdvisor, the dialogue between mental and physical spaces are cast out, indicating that Ground Zero is only a focal point; September 11 as a space is limited only by people's mental mapping. Ground Zero as a place is spatialized through people's memories and experiences, and TripAdvisor is digitizing the creation of a folklore.

Re-culturalization: Indignation and Change

One may argue that the re-temporalization and re-spatialization of Ground Zero is also about the re-culturalization of the site because new meanings are introduced to the site. Through the sharing of their analysis and opinions, tourists help construct new signs and meanings. One of the issues dealt with by the virtual tourist community is the touristification of Ground Zero. A reviewer from Toronto voiced concerns about touristification, with the heading: "Ground Zero unfortunately now a tourist money trap!"

Last weekend I visited the WTC and was truly disgusted that the area around this site has become home to hoards of people selling twin towers pictures, t-shirts, statues, trinkets, flags,

including conspiracy theory wackos giving speeches how this was an inside! A street musician was actually playing a solemn version of the Battle Hymn of the republic with his violin case open for tips. [...] I never thought New York would allow this cemetery to be disrespected after 9/11! (September 23, 2008)

Tourism is seen as having a corrupting influence. To many, there seems to be tacit "do's and don'ts" for a memorial site like Ground Zero. What is acceptable and unacceptable is negotiated online. For instance, StickyNic, from the United Kingdom, declared, "Not a tourist attraction":

It's a very chilling and surreal experience, I had never been to New York before so I can't actually imagine the towers being there [...] People were taking pictures but I didn't feel right doing that as I kept thinking that the remains of people's bodies have evaporated on that site.

It made me put my life in perspective. People should go to pay their respects but not to take pictures or treat it like a tourist attraction. (July 8, 2005)

Earlier in 2004, a fierce debate had ensued. A New Yorker stated:

It is somewhat understandable that tourists may be interested in seeing the World Trade Center site, but please do not treat it as an "attraction". It is not an attraction so please do not go if you are going to be taking lots of pictures and act as though you are visiting a museum or something. New Yorkers do not really appreciate that because we actually were there or near there on 9/11. There is also not really anything to see there, so I don't suggest you go unless you are very respectful about it. I have seen many tourists happily taking pictures of the site like it is just another attraction, but it is not. (August 9, 2004)

Some reviewers "step-out" of the tourist role and claim to represent the "voice" of the locals. Beall195 from Kansas agreed with the above comment:

I was in NYC this summer and went to the WTC site. To pay my respects. I am a Firefighter and I lost friends in the attack. I can understand if you're going here to pay your respects, but this is a grave site. Not a photo opp. I was extremely saddened by how many people were taking family photos here. I shoot

shots for our fire department and I didn't even take my camera out of it's bag. Should you go? Well, think about why you're going. If you're going to pay respect and to help you get the reality of this terrible day ... ABSOLUTELY. If you're going to shoot photos or just to stare at the hole. ABSOLUTELY NOT. Just realize over 2000 people died there and 343 were firemen saving others' lives. (November 23, 2004)

A contributor from England would not visit the site after reading Beall195's posting:

After reading the comments from the fireman, although strongly put, I am not sure now whether I can bring myself to visit Ground Zero, because as he so rightly put it, it is not and never will be a tourist attraction and yet in me visiting the site, that is what its becoming. I think I'll now pay my respects at a distance. (November 28, 2004)

Responding to these concerns, local New Yorker stevewesb encouraged tourists to visit and take pictures, with the headline "Living across WTC—why you should visit/take pictures":

Consider that each time a family views their pictures from the WTC site they remember: those that lost their lives; the 4+ story, NYC-block grave; the black "shroud" that encapsulates the Deutsche Bank building.

But in addition to this, the family photos hopefully bring about memories of enjoying NYC, the friendliness (thanks to 9-11) of New Yorkers, and thank those that still continue to protect us.

Visiting, taking pictures, seeing WTC is a healing process. If tourists STOP coming to visit this area then the area will continue to be economically damaged (April 2, 2005)

The contributor then suggested that visitors remain respectful during their visit, reflecting on the tragedy and the sacrifices made by the fire and security services. Taking pictures is not to be seen as disrespectful. The discussion of Ground Zero as a tourism site shows that tourists are concerned with touristification. There is no definitive conclusion on how tourists should

behave; they now constitute a significant stakeholder to the site. The concerns accentuated here show that Ground Zero is not just about September 11. People have emotional links to the place and tourism is seen as a boon or a bane by various persons. Regardless, Ground Zero is a magnet for tourists visiting New York and is a global space. TripAdvisor has documented Ground Zero as a tourism space with conflicting views. As a result, Ground Zero acquires a tourist-centered story beyond September 11 and local development. Ground Zero is being re-culturalized. Time will tell if a consensus will emerge on how tourists should interpret and behave at the site. The contestations continue.

CONCLUSION

This chapter has shown that a tourism site like Ground Zero is being re-spatialized, re-temporalized, and re-culturalized in a Web 2.0 platform. There are a number of conclusions to draw from this study.

The first conclusion is on how social media has transformed the tourism industry. One of the transformations is the proliferation of the tourist-centric perspective of attractions, as presented in social media. Tourism mediators remain important in the industry, but tourists themselves are coming together to mediate each other's experiences.

The examination of the reviews shows how tourists understand themselves as part of a community of fellow travelers who come together to create, share, and exchange information. Tourists are not passive spectators. Tourism social media transforms tourists' communicative practices. Reviewer contributions appear in a fluid gray zone between the local and the global, between the personal and the public. They share their personal emotions but try to establish global rules of appropriate tourism behavior. They share private experiences of grief and expose them to millions of viewers. The case of Ground Zero shows how the site is being re-temporalized, -spatialized, and -culturalized. There is no tight consistency or coherence in the collection of reviews. Nevertheless, the exchanges in the virtual community reflect many of the concerns and issues tourists have and also reflect their roles as cocreators of heritage experiences.

The second conclusion, which is related to the first, is on the proliferation of the use of social media. The innovative feature of tourists' online review making is that this new form of mediation of the tourism experience cannot be fully controlled by the industry. Tourist-created content shapes

experiences. Sharing digital reviews broadens the access to experiences of "touristhood" so that tourists do not only see their experiences in contrast to their own day-to-day activities, but also in many different contexts based on other travelers' experiences (Tussyadiah & Fesenmaier, 2009). As tourists are not living close to the sites, their sense of time, place, and the culture in relation to the site differ from that of locals. Tourist perspectives are now being articulated and memorialized in TripAdvisor. In other words, tourists have now found a platform to get "organized." They now have a global channel to communicate with others around the world, asserting their views and voices, laying claim to tourism sites and staking claims of legitimacy to their own interpretations. Could it be then postulated that social media quicken the emergence of new global tourism cultures? Further research is needed.

Finally, the third conclusion deals with tourism destination and attraction management organizations. A site like Ground Zero is acquiring new meanings as time flows. Practitioners and researchers alike tend to concentrate on the authenticity of the stories. That is rightly so. However, this study shows that tourists are now layering new meanings onto the historical site, and these meanings are being documented on social media platforms. This is an opportunity for market research and the creation of new narratives for historical tourist products. A more fundamental question is then: who has the authority to write and rewrite history?

This study shows that Web 2.0 is not making traditional tourism mediators redundant. Instead, social media have empowered tourists. They do not just exert their influence through their buying power now but also their ability to articulate and exchange their views at a global level. Nonetheless, their voices remain diffuse, and there is little consensus, like many other "real" societies. Thus, this chapter ends by bringing up a newer (after the memorial has been officially inaugurated) entry on Ground Zero in TripAdvisor, one that is likely to start another spatial and temporal thread in the tumbleweed. Time2Seel, from Melbourne, Australia:

This memorial is very eloquent, humble, and respectful. You're able to spend as much time there as you like, and just read the names. It becomes a personal experience when you see the photos/notes/roses left next to some of the names. (October 25, 2011)

And the story continues and the history is in the making.

Chapter 13

Tourism and Media Studies 3.0

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ABSTRACT

The term “social media” generally refers to the multi-point creation and distribution of electronic communication. It is understood in opposition to broadcasting. This chapter explains the history of media studies as a means of comprehending these newer media in the context of tourism. They need to be studied in the light of existing media, even as we seek a new form of truly interdisciplinary work that brings existing approaches together. Taking its agenda from social movements as well as intellectual ones, and its methods from social sciences and humanities, Media Studies 3.0 should focus on gender, race, class, sexuality, sustainability, and pleasure across national lines—an apt setting for those working on tourism.

Keywords: Media studies 1.0; Media studies 2.0; Media studies 3.0

INTRODUCTION

The term “social media” generally refers to the multi-point creation and distribution of electronic communication. It is understood in opposition to broadcasting (though the notion that the most popular pastime worldwide now and in the last century should be other than “social” is bizarre). This chapter explains the history of media studies, which may be of value for

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comprehending these newer social media in the context of tourism. The chapter discusses the social media in the light of their defunct, venerable, and middle-aged counterparts.

Across history, media studies have been dominated by three topics: ownership and control, content, and audiences. Approaches to ownership and control vary between neoliberal endorsements of limited regulation by the state to facilitate market entry by new competitors, and Marxist critiques of the bourgeois media for controlling the sociopolitical agenda. Approaches to content vary between hermeneutics, which unearths the meaning of individual texts and links them to broader social formations and problems, and content analysis, which establishes patterns across significant numbers of similar texts, rather than close readings of individual ones. Approaches to audiences vary between social psychological attempts to correlate audiovisual consumption and social conduct, and critiques of imported audiovisual material threatening national and regional autonomy. These three components, fractured by politics, nation, discipline, theory, and method, are embodied in what is called here Media Studies 1.0 and Media Studies 2.0. These two formations cover a new Media Studies 3.0, and offer some examples of how the media and tourism intersect in the contemporary moment.

TOURISM AND MEDIA STUDIES

Media Studies 1.0

Media Studies 1.0 derived from the spread of new media technologies over the past two centuries into the lives of urbanizing populations and the policing questions that this posed to state and capital: What the effect on the public of these developments would be and how they would vary between those with a stake in the social order versus those seeking to transform it. By the early 20th century, academic experts had decreed media audiences to be passive consumers, thanks to the missions of literary criticism, distinguishing the aesthetically cultivated from others, and psychology, distinguishing the socially competent from others (Butsch, 2000, p. 3). The origins of social psychology can be traced to anxieties about "the crowd" in a suddenly urbanized and educated Western Europe that raised the prospect of a long-feared "ochlocracy" of "the worthless mob" (Pufendorf, 2000, p. 144) able to share popular texts. In the wake of the French Revolution, Edmund Burke was animated by the need to limit collective exuberance via restraint

on popular passions (1994, p. 122). He was not alone, then or now. Consider the opening line of Baroness Orczy's famous adventure tourism novel of the Terror, *The Scarlet Pimpernel*: "A surging, seething, murmuring crowd of beings that are human only in name, for to the eye and ear they seem naught but savage creatures, animated by vile passions and by the lust of vengeance and of hate" (2009, Kindle Locations, 10488–10489). Elite theorists from both right and left emerged across the 19th century, notably Pareto (1976), Mosca (1939), Le Bon (1899), and Michels (1915). They argued that newly literate publics were vulnerable to manipulation by demagogues. Even Mill spoke of "the meanest feelings and most ignorant prejudices of the vulgarest part of the crowd" (1861, p. 144). The founder of the "American Dream," the Latino James Truslow Adams, regarded "[t]he mob mentality of the city crowd" as "one of the menaces to modern civilization." He was particularly disparaging about "the prostitution of the moving-picture industry" (1941, pp. 404, 413). These critics were frightened of socialism, democracy, and popular reason (Wallas, 1967, p. 137). With civil society growing restive, the emergence of radical politics was explained away in sociopsychological terms rather than political-economic ones. The psy-function warmed itself by campus fires, far from the crowding mass. In the United States, Harvard took charge of theorizing, Chicago observing, and Columbia enumerating the great unwashed (Staiger, 2005, pp. 21–22). Tests of beauty and truth found the popular classes wanting, and helped promulgate the idea of the newly literate and suddenly enfranchised being bamboozled by the artistically shameless and unscrupulously fluent.

The US Payne Fund studies of the 1930s investigated the impact of films on what a gaggle of sociologists labeled "'superior' adults" (this expression referred to "young college professors, graduate students and their wives") versus children from juvenile centers. Researchers wanted to know, "what effect do motion pictures have upon children of different ages?" especially on people defined as "retarded." These pioneering scholars boldly set out to discover whether "the onset of puberty is or is not affected by motion pictures" and what they called "The Big Three" narrative themes: love, crime, and sex (sound familiar?). They pondered "demonstrations of satisfying love techniques" to see whether "sexual passions are aroused and amateur prostitution ... aggravated" by the screen, gauging reactions through "autobiographical case studies," questionnaires asking whether "All Most Many Some Few No Chinese are cunning and underhand," and "skin response," as measured by psychogalvanometers attached to young people in cinemas and hypnographs and polygraphs wired to them in their beds (Charters, 1933).

The Payne Fund studies birthed seven decades of obsessive social-scientific attempts to correlate youthful consumption of popular culture with antisocial conduct, scrutinizing audiences in terms of where they came from, how many there were, and what they did as a consequence of participating (Miller, 2009). In 1951, Smythe wrote of this effects research, "[e]verybody seems to be doing it, especially those who are best qualified by virtue of the fact that 'they wouldn't have a television set in the house'" (2004, p. 318). Bob Dylan remembers the 1960s in Greenwich Village not only because he was singing in coffee shops but as a time marked by "Sociologists ... saying that TV had deadly intentions and was destroying the minds and imaginations of the young—that their attention span was being dragged down." The other dominant site of knowledge Dylan encountered was the "psychology professor, a good performer, but originality not his long suit" (2004, pp. 55, 67).

Just such purveyors of normal science continue to cast a shadow across that village, and many others. The pattern is that when cultural technologies and genres emerge, young people are identified as both pioneers and victims, simultaneously endowed by marketers and critics with power and vulnerability. They are held to be the first to know and the last to understand the media—the grand paradox of youth, latterly on display in the digital sublime of technological determinism, as always with the super-added valence of a future citizenship in peril (American Academy of Pediatrics, Council on Communications and Media, 2009). New genres and technologies are accompanied by concerns about extreme distinctions among generations. The latest manifestation of this anxiety can be found in much pop-intellectual work that divines the existence of "digital natives" (Tapscott, 2009).

Concerns about supposedly unprecedented and unholy risks deriving from new media recur with each major technological and generic innovation. Damnation was sure to follow cheap novels during the 1900s, silent then sound film of the teens and 1920s, radio in the 1930s, comic books from the 1940s and 1950s, pop music and television in the 1950s and 1960s, satanic rock and video cassette recorders of the 1970s and 1980s, and rap music, video games, the Internet, and sexting since the 1990s.

The satirical paper *The Onion* (2005) cleverly mocked these interdependent phenomena of moral panic and commodification via a *faux* study of the impact on US youth of seeing Janet Jackson's breast in a 2004 Super Bowl broadcast. Something similar can be seen in conventional tourism research into social media, which warns corporations about how to avoid negative responses and encourage positive ones, lest the herd-like public turn against

a particular company or resort (González, Gidumal, & López-Valcárcel, 2010; Pan, Xiang, Law, & Fesenmaier, 2011; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). The audience must be controlled as if it were an unruly mob of 19th-century socialists. This anxiety and desire for surveillance has particular force when the social media are identified as causal agents, or at least facilitators, of child sex tourism (George & Panko, 2011).

Effects studies suffer all the disadvantages of ideal-typical psychological reasoning. They rely on methodological individualism and fail to account for cultural norms, let alone the arcs of history that establish patterns of text and response inside politics, war, ideology, and discourse. Each laboratory test, based on, as the refrain goes, “a large university in the Midwest [of the United States],” is countered by a similar experiment, with conflicting results. As politicians, grant-givers, and pundits call for more and more research to prove that the media make you stupid, violent, and apathetic—or the opposite—academics line up at the trough to indulge their contempt for popular culture and their rent-seeking urge for public money. Media Studies 1.0 rarely interrogates its own conditions of existence—namely, governments, religious groups, business leeches, and the media themselves account for social problems by diverting blame onto popular culture. It takes each new medium and genre as an opportunity to affirm its omniscient agenda (Miller, 2009).

Whereas effects research focuses on the cognition and emotion of individual human subjects via observation and experimentation, another way of considering audiences looks to the customs and patriotic feeling exhibited by collective human subjects, the grout of national culture. In place of psychology, it is concerned with politics. The media do not make you a well- or ill-educated person, a wild or self-controlled one. Rather, they make you a knowledgeable and loyal national subject or a *naïf*, ignorant of local tradition and history. Cultural belonging, not psychic wholeness, is the touchstone of this model. Instead of measuring responses electronically or behaviorally, it interrogates the geopolitical origin of popular texts and the themes and styles they embody, with particular attention to the putatively nation-building genres of drama, news, sport, and current affairs. Adherents hold that local citizens should control television, for instance, because they can be counted on to be patriotic in the event of war. Many nations prohibit foreigners owning TV licenses. The United States is a prominent example.

In addition to audience research and cultural policy, Media Studies 1.0 also includes political economy, which focuses on infrastructure rather than audiences, and critical theory, which is concerned that the audiovisual sector turns people away from artistic and social traces of authentic

intersubjectivity and toward control of individual consciousness. Both work from the *nostrum* that the media are all powerful. Political economy is more policy oriented and political in its focus on institutional power. Critical theory is more philosophical and aesthetic in its desire to develop modernism and the avant-garde. They began as one with lamentations for the triumph of industrialized cultural production and the loss of a self-critical philosophical address. The two approaches are also linked via a distaste for what they deride as mass culture. Because demand is dispersed and supply centralized, the media supposedly operate via an administrative logic. Far from reflecting already-established and -revealed preferences of consumers in reaction to tastes and desires, they manipulate audiences from the apex of production. Coercion is mistaken for free will, and culture is one more industrial process subordinated to the dominant economic forces within society. It seeks a maximum of standardization and a minimum of risk. The only element that might stand against this leveling sameness is said to be individual consciousness. But that consciousness has itself been customized to enable efficient media production (Adorno & Horkheimer, 1977).

Media Studies 2.0

For Media Studies 2.0, popular culture represents the apex of modernity. Far from being supremely alienating, it embodies the expansion of civil society, the first moment in history when political and commercial organs and agendas became receptive to, and part of, the popular classes; when the general population counted as part of the social, rather than being excluded from political-economic calculations. At the same time, there was a lessening of authority, the promulgation of individual rights and respect, and the development of intense but large-scale human interaction (Hartley, 2003; Shils, 1966). This perspective has offered a way in to media audiences that differs from Media Studies 1.0 and its faith in the all-powerful agency of the media. For in Media Studies 2.0, the all-powerful agent is the audience. It claims that the public is so clever and able that it makes its own meanings, outwitting institutions of the state, academia, and capitalism that seek to measure and control it. In the case of children and the media, for example, anxieties from 1.0 about turning Edenic innocents into rabid monsters, capitalist dupes, or mental Americans have been challenged by a new culturalist perspective. This formation has animated research into the generic features and intertexts of children's news, drama, action-adventure, education, cartooning, and play and how children distinguish between

fact and fiction and talk about the media as part of social interaction (Buckingham, 2000).

Faith in the active audience can reach cosmic proportions. It has been a *donnée* of 2.0 that the media are not responsible for anything. This position is a virtual *nostrum* in some research into fans, who are thought to construct connections with celebrities and actants in ways that mimic friendship, make sense of human interaction, and ignite cultural politics. Media Studies 2.0 commonly attacks opponents of commercial culture for misrecognizing its capacity to subvert patriarchy, capitalism, and other forms of oppression. The popular is held to have progressive effects, because it is decoded by people in keeping with their social situations. The active audience is said to be weak at the level of cultural production, but strong as an interpretative community. All this is supposedly evident to scholars from their perusal of audience conventions, web pages, discussion groups, quizzes, and rankings, or by staring at screens with their children. Consumption is the key to Media Studies 2.0—with production discounted, labor forgotten, consumers sovereign, and governments there to protect them.

Cybertarian technophiles, struck by the digital sublime, attribute magical properties to contemporary communications, and cultural technologies that obliterate geography, sovereignty, and hierarchy in an alchemy of truth and beauty. Cybertarians see omniscient, omnipotent audiences outwitting the efforts of capital, the state, and parents to understand and corral them. The new-media *savants* who construct the latter model routinely invoke precapitalist philosophers, dodging questions of state and capital by heading for aesthetics (Cogburn & Silcox, 2008). A deregulated, individuated media world supposedly makes consumers into producers, frees the disabled from confinement, encourages new subjectivities, rewards intellect and competitiveness, links people across cultures, and allows billions of flowers to bloom in a post-political cornucopia. It is a kind of Marxist/Godardian wet dream, where people fish, fornicate, film, and finance from morning to midnight. At such moments, one can say that what Eagleton (1982) sardonically named The Reader's Liberation Movement is in the house. In his survey of this work, Mosco rightly argues that such "myths are important both for what they reveal (including a genuine desire for community and democracy) and for what they conceal (including the growing concentration of communication power in a handful of transnational media businesses)" (2004).

In tourism, the aggregated effect of collective knowledge via social media that is associated with personal recommendations of destinations is a good example of these claims (Popescu & Grefenstette, 2011). Such findings excite 2.0 advocates, as per the unseemly way that tourism experts egged on by

social media salivate over wealthy foreigners; a typical instance is the discourse of Chinese consumers liberated from the state (Arlt & Thraenhardt, 2011). Such sanctioned greed is some distance from research that illustrates how the social media function as surveillance-and-control devices in places as diverse as China and Australia (Qiu, 2007) or the World Privacy Forum proposing that people are in a “one-way mirror society,” where power accretes to corporations through the supposedly even-handed tool of interactivity (Dixon, 2010).

The fundamental dilemma for adherents of Media Studies 2.0 is this: Can fans or tourists be said to make rational evaluations of core questions of social justice such as labor exploitation, patriarchy, racism, climate change, and neo-imperialism—or in some specifiable way make a difference beyond their own selves—when they interpret TV unusually, each other about romantic frustrations, play pirated versions of Scrabble on Facebook, or take a cruise based on amateur recommendations?

Has the society gone too far in supplanting the panicky Woody Allen nebbishness of 1.0 (“I’m kind of bothered that ...”) with the Panglossian Pollyanna nerdiness of 2.0 (“Cool stuff”)? Keen, a lapsarian prophet of the Internet, argues that the new landscape is abuzz with noise and ignorance rather than subtlety and knowledge (2007, p. 12). He sees a dreary world of constant clatter and frenzied imagery denaturing aesthetics in favor of uninterrupted stimulus. This is no 2.0 utopia! Postrel, then editor of the libertarian *Reason* magazine and later a *New York Times* economics journalist, wrote a *Wall Street Journal* op-ed welcoming 2.0 as “deeply threatening to traditional leftist views of commerce ... lending support to the corporate enemy and even training graduate students who wind up doing market research” (1999).

Media Studies 3.0

One needs more *frottage* between Media Studies 1.0 and 2.0, breaking down the binary between them. Media Studies 1.0 should register struggle, and 2.0 should register structure. Currently, 1.0 draws one’s attention to audience inoculation and corporate control, but leaves out productive labor and environmental implications. Media Studies 2.0 uptakes and adds responses, but again marginalizes these key topics. Media Studies 1.0 misses moments of crisis and hope, presenting a subject-free picture of structure but no agency, other than psychological response, shareholder maximization, and managerial rationality. Its nationalistic cultural policies often deny the

banality of protected cinema, the futility of quota-driven television, and the partiality of who is chosen to create national images and appear in them. Media 2.0 misses forms of domination and exploitation, presenting an institution-free picture with agency but no structure, other than fan creativity and reader imagination. Further, both 1.0 and 2.0 are doggedly tied to nativist epistemologies that must be transcended. The nativism is especially powerful in the United States, the United Kingdom, and their academic satellites such as Israel and Australia, where effortless extrapolations from very limited experience support totalizing theories and norms, due to the hegemony of English-language publishing and scholarly links to the warfare, welfare, and cultural bureaucracies. The following remark (paid for by Vodafone) encapsulates 2.0:

Mobile phones have become affective technologies. That is, objects which mediate the expression, display, experience and communication of feelings and emotions. ... They are an extension of the human body ... building and maintaining ... groups and communities. (Lasén, 2004)

This will not do. Thankfully it is challenged by a remark that could come from 3.0—funded by a nongovernment organization of Mexican electronics workers:

The increasingly faster and more versatile computers, appealing mobile phones, high-definition TVs, Internet, tiny music players, ingenious photo cameras, entertaining games consoles and even electronic pets give us the idea of a developed, pioneering and modern world. It is indeed a new era for many; but the dark side of this prosperous world reveals a very different reality, that far from taking us to the future, takes us back to a darker past. (Centro de Reflexión y Acción Laboral, 2006)

Media Studies 3.0 is as much about experiences as technologies or institutions. The media color the world. They give it meaning; and the process is reciprocal. The sounds, stories, and pictures that *are* the media—whether social or antisocial—actually come from people. Old stories from oral traditions become commercial narratives. Letters to the editor tell newspapers what interests their readers. Audience measurements and focus groups instruct producers on which TV shows are likely to succeed and why.

Fans become creators as they write zines that in turn become story ideas. Marketers trawl street fairs, clubs, and fan sites to uncover emergent trends. Coca-Cola hires African Americans to drive through the inner city selling soda and playing hip-hop. AT&T pays San Francisco buskers to mention the company in their songs. Street performance poets rhyme about Nissan cars for cash, simultaneously hawking, entertaining, and researching. Subway's sandwich commercials are marketed as made by teenagers. Cultural studies graduates become designers, and graduate students in New York and Los Angeles read scripts for producers and pronounce on whether they tap into audience interests.

Semiotics textbooks that critically deconstruct commercial culture adorn advertising executives' bookcases. Precariously employed part-timers prowl the streets with DVD players under their arms to ask target audiences what they think of trailers for upcoming movies, or while away their time in theaters spying on how their fellow spectators respond to coming attractions. Opportunities to vote in the Eurovision Song Contest or a reality program determine both the success of contestants and the profile of active viewers who can be monitored and wooed. In all these instances, audience creativity is important. It informs and frightens producers, simultaneously offering them leads on stories and trends and daunting them with its changeability and friskiness. End-user licensing agreements ensure that players of corporate games online and contributors to official discussion groups about film or television sign over their cultural moves and access. Such topics frequently elude 1.0 and 2.0. They do not fit those models.

Studying tourism through the media and vice versa must blend ethnographic, political-economic, and aesthetic analyses in a global and local way, establishing links among the key areas of cultural production around the world (Africa, the Americas, Asia, Europe, and the Middle East) and diasporic and dispossessed communities engaged in their own cultural production. Media 3.0 needs to be a media-centered version of area studies, with diasporas as important as regions. It must be animated by collective identity and power: how human subjects are formed and experience cultural and social space. Taking its agenda from social movements as well as intellectual ones, and its methods from economics, politics, communications, sociology, literature, law, science, medicine, environmental studies, anthropology, history, and art, Media Studies 3.0 should focus on gender, race, class, sexuality, sustainability, and pleasure, across national lines—an apt setting for those working on tourism.

One can gain some tips on doing this from the history of theorizing culture. It has usually been studied in two registers: via the social sciences

and the humanities—truth versus beauty. Culture has been a marker of differences and similarities in taste and status, as explored interpretatively or methodically. In the humanities, cultural texts have long been judged by criteria of quality, as practiced critically and historically. For their part, the social sciences have focused on religions, customs, times, and spaces, as explored ethnographically or statistically. Thus, whereas the humanities articulate differences through symbolic norms (e.g., which classes have the cultural capital to appreciate high culture and which do not), the social sciences articulate differences through social norms (such as, which peoples cultivate agriculture in keeping with spirituality and which do not) (Benhabib, 2002; Wallerstein, 1989). This distinction feeds into the Cartesian dualism separating thought from work. It assumes that humans have two distinct natures: the intelligent and the corporeal. One is focused on action, the other on reason. That binary has dominated media studies, posing oppositions of society versus economy and audience versus meaning. It haunts 1.0 and 2.0.

For all its sticky origins in Cartesianism, this bifurcation and silencing of labor and culture cannot and should not hold. Historically, the best critical political economy and the best cultural studies have worked through the imbrication of power and signification. Blending them can heal the fissure between fact and interpretation, the social sciences and the humanities, and truth and beauty, under the sign of a principled approach to cultural democracy. Grossberg recommends “politicizing theory and theorizing politics” by combining abstraction and grounded analysis (1997). That requires a focus on the contradictions of organizational structures, their articulations with everyday living and textuality and their intrication with the polity and economy, addressing production, consumption, and social stratification. Half a century ago, Smythe studied TV texts as “a group of symbols” that “serve as a medium of exchange between the mass media and the audience.” He recognized that analyses of infrastructure and content must be supplemented by accounting for the conditions under which culture is made, circulated, received, interpreted, and criticized: “The produced program is ... more than the sum of the program ingredients” because it is encrusted with “contextual and explicit layers of meaning” that emerge during its creation and consumption (1954, p. 143).

Relevant work toward 3.0 is already underway. Rajagopal notes that because the television, the telephone, the Internet, the neoliberal, and the outgoing tourist are relatively new to India, “markets and media generate new kinds of rights and new kinds of imagination ... novel ways of exercising citizenship rights and conceiving politics” (2001). For Winocur

(2002), women's talkback radio in Latin America since the fall of US-backed dictatorships has offered a simultaneously individual and social forum for new expressions of citizenship in the context of decentered politics, emergent identities, minority rights, and gender issues—a public space that transcends the subordination of difference and the privileging of elite experience. Mosco (2004) starts from the power of mythology then “builds a bridge to political economy” in his investigation of neoliberal *doxa* about empowerment, insisting on “the mutually constitutive relationship between political economy and cultural studies” as each mounts “a critique of the other.” One can note similar intent animating such innovations as Sarai, the Free Software Foundation, and the Alternative Law Forum—exemplary instances of Media Studies 3.0 in formation. They blend internationalism, political economy, ethnography, and textual analysis, and resist the binarism of 1.0 and 2.0.

The art world can incarnate this approach in its critical views of tourism. For instance, Amsterdam's urbanscreens.org uses electronic billboards as public space to encourage active citizenship, as do Ars Electronica of Linz and Melbourne's Federation Square. Artists draw attention to personal multimedia messaging services and corporate occupancy of public space by placing passersby on billboards, as per Zhang Ga's Times Square *People's Portrait*, for all the world a throwback to Judy Holliday's moment of celebrity in the classic Hollywood film *It Should Happen to You* (George Cukor, 1954), when she buys advertising space in Columbus Circle to promote herself.

Anderson and Wolff (2010), lapsed sacerdotal zealots of the new media from *Wired* magazine, say the web is dead because social networks and software applications are supplanting the old fantasy of an open frontier with a new hegemony of a few institutions. Schiller (2007) challenges social media enthusiasts to query the way that economic inequalities fuel new consumer needs, as people rush to purchase inferior services at high cost. In the United States, for instance, the decline in governmental oversight of the media since World War II has diminished the quality and regulation of competition, allowing telecommunication companies to exploit the need for connectedness in times of fragmentation.

CONCLUSION

To understand media infrastructure, it is necessary to address technological innovation, regulation, labor, ownership, control, and environmental impact,

utilizing ethnographic, political-economic, scientific, and public-policy research. To understand content, one must address production and undertake content and textual analysis, combining statistical and hermeneutic methods. To understand audiences, ratings, uses-and-gratifications, effects, active-audience, ethnographic, and psychoanalytic traditions, combining quantitative and qualitative measures should be standard.

Two examples from 3.0 can be used to show the relationship between the media and tourism. They concern major tourist spots thematized in films. Each involves environmental destruction and popular responses to corporate malevolence. They blend older and newer media in artful ways appropriate to 3.0.

Much of Fox Studios' *Titanic* (Cameron, 1997) was shot in the Mexican village of Popotla. During the making of the picture, the national film studio Churubusco was renovated and a National Film Commission established, with satellites across the country providing *gabacho* moguls trips in governors' helicopters, among other services. Restoring Mexico to the Hollywood map gained the film's director Cameron the Order of the Aztec Eagle from a grateful government. *Titanic* was, in this context, a screen testimony to the 1994 North American Free Trade Agreement/Tratado de Libre Comercio, which has seen offshore film and television production in Mexico increase thanks to easy shipment of technology, especially for low-budget shoots. Studio owner Rupert Murdoch approvingly cited the number of workers invisibly employed in making the film:

this cross-border cultural co-operation is not the result of regulation, but market forces. It's the freedom to move capital, technology and talent around the world that adds value, invigorates ailing markets, creates new ones.

Meanwhile, local Mexican film production spiraled downwards, from 747 titles in the decade prior to the agreement/tratado to 212 the following decade (Maxwell & Miller, 2006; Miller, Govil, McMurria, Maxwell, & Wang, 2005, pp. 164–65).

There is a cruel irony to this liquid globalization of cultural labor: the cost of the film could have provided safe drinking water to 600,000 people for a year. People submerged in the credits to *Titanic* (or not listed at all) supposedly benefited from the textualization of a boat laden with wealthy tourists and *lumpen* steerage that had been sunk by invisible ice and business bombast 80 years earlier. During filming, Popotla was cut off from the sea and local fisheries by a 6-feet-high and 500-feet long movie wall, built

to keep citizens away. Fox's chlorination of surrounding seawater decimated sea urchins, which locals had long harvested, and reduced overall fish levels by a third (Kushner, 1998; Miller et al., 2005, p. 165). Today, Popotla is promoted as a destination for smiling foreigners eager to see where their favorite drowning sequences were shot at the charmingly named "Foxploration" (http://www.bajatours.org/about_rosarito_beach; <http://www.rosaritoinn.com/foxtour.htm>).

Such arrogant despoliation has not gone unanswered. In collaboration with artists like Jim Bliesner, the Popotlanos decorated the wall with rubbish to ridicule the filmmakers, and adopted the rallying cry *mariscos libre* (freedom for shellfish). (Photographs are available at rtmark.com/popotlaimages.html.) This nifty environmental critique has largely eluded journalistic and scholarly analysis. Ars Electronica awarded the Popotlanos a prize for "symbolic low-tech resistance to real high-tech destruction" that was in keeping with the movie's textual—if not industrial—class politics. But the award was a fraction of the money Ars Electronica gave the film's producers for their innovative special effects. Resistance has come from groups using social media to pose as officials from the World Trade Organization to underscore the damage done to livelihoods and the environment. The Popotlanos' view of Cameron's putatively green, pro-indigenous, anti-imperialist *Avatar* (2009) is not on record, but their town is currently vilified by the likes of *The Washington Times* as a site for "illegals" seeking to enter the United States (Coombe & Herman, 2000; gatt.org/popotla.html; Kushner, 1998; *Popotla vs. Titanic*, n.d.; Sekula, 2001; Spagat, 2010).

Cameron acknowledges the need to change filmmaking in light of the ecological crisis. He is quick to point out that "*Avatar* was an enormous battle film that took place in a rainforest but was 100% C[omputer-]G[enerated]" (Cheney, 2010; quoted in Miller, 2010). When he castigated the Pacific Northwest for extracting oil from tar sands, the *Edmonton Sun* editorialized in best un-Canadian fashion "James Cameron is a Hypocrite" for working in California, where energy comes from power companies that use coal from elsewhere (*Edmonton Sun*, 2010).

Three years after *Titanic*, Fox made *The Beach* (Boyle, 2000), where a modern-day Asian Eden suddenly turns nasty for jaded tourists. Like the earlier film, it starred the environmental moralist Leonardo DiCaprio (Biggs, 2000). *The Beach* was shot in Maya Beach, part of Thailand's Phi Phi Islands National Park. Natural scenery was bulldozed because it did not fit the company's fantasy of a tropical idyll: sand dunes were relocated, flora rearranged, and a new strip of coconut palms planted. The producers paid off the government with a donation to the Royal Forestry Department, and

campaigned with the Tourism Authority to twin the picture as a promotion for the country. The damaged sand dunes of the region collapsed in the next monsoon, their natural defenses against erosion destroyed by Hollywood bulldozers. Thai environmental and pro-democracy activists publicized this arrogant despoliation, while the director claimed the film was "raising environmental consciousness" among a local population whose appreciation of these things lagged "behind" US "awareness" (Law, Bunnell, & Ong, 2007; Miller et al., 2005; Shoaib, 2001; Tzanelli, 2006). Director Boyle heroically announced his intention to "give something back to Thailand" by hiring Thai apprentices but then complained that "[w]e were hauling 300 fucking people around wherever we went. And you know how hard it is to learn Thai names. Every lunchtime was like a prime minister's reception" (quoted in Gilbey, 2002). Before the film was released—but no doubt after having had their consciousness raised—the Ao Nang Tambon Administration Organization, the Krabi Provincial Administration Organization, and various environmental groups filed a suit against Fox and local officialdom for contravening the National Parks Act and the Environmental Protection Act. It took seven years, but the Thai Supreme Court found in their favor in 2006 (*The Nation*, 2006). The reaction of the "300 fucking people" who were being "hauled around" during production is not on record.

The political-economic background to such ecologically destructive filmmaking implicates tourism. Structural adjustment as peddled by neoliberal high priests at the World Bank, the International Monetary Fund, the World Trade Organization, and the sovereign states that dominate them has encouraged the Global South to turn away from subsistence agriculture and toward tradable services, beyond manufacturing capacity and in the direction of human exchange. In much of Southeast Asia, these policies pushed people into littoral regions in search of work. Fish-farming corporations created a new aquaculture, displacing the natural environment of mangroves and coral reefs that protect people and land. The requirement to reconstitute themselves as entertaining heritage sites and decadent tourism playgrounds induced Thailand, Indonesia, and Malaysia to undertake massive construction projects. They built resorts at the point where high tides lap, attracting more and more workers and decimating more and more natural protection. Areas that had not been directed to remove natural barriers suffered dramatically fewer casualties in the 2004 tsunami (Bidwai, 2005; Sharma, 2005; Shiva, 2005). That ugly side to tourism and the media is something 3.0 can specify, engage, and struggle against. Doing so might make for a truly social media.